

Figures of Speech Master Notes

Every figure of speech with its clue words, a memory trick, easy examples and lines from the 25 syllabus poems — segregated by family and checked against the poem texts.

36 figures explained **25** syllabus poems analysed **971** poem quotations checked word for word **144** practice questions

Faster than fairies, faster than witches,

From a Railway Carriage · Robert Louis Stevenson

Alliteration f...f...f

Simile a comparison with “than”

Hyperbole no train beats fairies

One line, three figures — this book teaches you to spot each one.

1 Start Here: Figures of Speech in TNPSC

Begin here. This section explains what a figure of speech is, what the 2022 syllabus names, which 25 poems it lists, how questions are framed and how to finish these notes in one week.

1.1 What is a figure of speech?

A **figure of speech** is a special way of using words to make an idea more vivid, more musical or more forceful. **Literal** language says exactly what it means. **Figurative** language compares, repeats, plays with sound or exaggerates, so that the reader sees, hears or feels more.

Figures come in two broad kinds:

- **Figures of meaning** — the words mean more than they say: Simile, Metaphor, Personification, Hyperbole.
- **Figures of sound and pattern** — the sound or the arrangement of the words is special: Alliteration, Onomatopoeia, Anaphora, Repetition.

Rhyme scheme and rhyming words are really sound patterns. The syllabus lists them with the figures of speech, so these notes treat them as figures too (see 3.8 and 3.9).

Tamil-medium students already know two of them from Tamil grammar: *uvamai ani* is the Simile and *uruvaga ani* is the Metaphor.

WHY POETS USE THEM

- **To paint a picture.** “*Like a child at play.*” lets you see the young river as a playful child.
- **To make music.** Repeated sounds and rhymes make lines pleasant to hear and easy to remember.
- **To stress an idea.** “*And miles to go before I sleep*” comes twice, to stress how much work is still left.
- **To show strong feeling** in a few words: “Oh!”, “Alas!”.
- **To make big ideas easy to grasp.** Anger becomes a growing tree (5.8), life becomes a journey (5.1) and a river becomes a human life (5.11).

LITERAL OR FIGURATIVE?

Literal sentence	Figurative sentence	Figure
Chennai in May is very hot.	Chennai in May is as hot as an oven.	Simile (3.2) — as ... as compares the city with an oven
Chennai in May is very hot.	Chennai in May is an oven.	Metaphor (3.3) — the city simply is an oven
The sun shone on the paddy fields.	The sun smiled on the paddy fields.	Personification (3.4) — the sun does a human act
The pressure cooker made a loud noise.	The pressure cooker hissed and whistled.	Onomatopoeia (3.5) — hiss and whistle copy the sound

Rows 1 and 2 carry the same idea. With "as ... as" it is a simile; with only "is" and no comparing word, it is a metaphor. Learn this difference first; Section 6 explains more such pairs.

1.2 What the syllabus says

The 2022 revised TNPSC General English (SSLC standard) syllabus names these figures of speech: **Alliteration, Simile, Metaphor, Personification, Onomatopoeia, Anaphora, Rhyme Scheme, Rhyming Words, Repetition**, and ends the list with **"etc."** So other figures can also be asked. **Allusion, Oxymoron, Ellipsis and Apostrophe** were named in the earlier syllabus and are still worth knowing.

Named in the 2022 syllabus (9)	Alliteration, Simile, Metaphor, Personification, Onomatopoeia, Anaphora, Repetition, Rhyme Scheme, Rhyming Words → Section 3 (3.1 to 3.9)
Named in the earlier syllabus (4)	Apostrophe, Allusion, Oxymoron, Ellipsis → 4.1 to 4.4
Covered by "etc." (23 more)	Assonance, Hyperbole, Irony, Antithesis and the rest → 4.5 to 4.27

THE 25 SYLLABUS POEMS

The same syllabus lists 25 poems. Section 5 covers each poem in turn, and the figure cards in Sections 3 and 4 quote them as examples.

No.	Poem	Poet	Notes in
1	Life	Henry Van Dyke	5.1
2	I am Every Woman	Rakhi Nariani Shirke	5.2
3	The Secret of the Machines	Rudyard Kipling	5.3
4	The Ant and the Cricket	Adapted from Aesop's fables	5.4
5	No Men are Foreign	James Falconer Kirkup	5.5
6	The House on Elm Street	Nadia Bush	5.6
7	Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening	Robert Frost	5.7
8	A Poison Tree	William Blake	5.8
9	On Killing a Tree	Gieve Patel	5.9
10	The Spider and the Fly	Mary Botham Howitt	5.10
11	The River	Caroline Ann Bowles	5.11
12	The Comet	Norman Littleford	5.12
13	The Stick-together Families	Edgar Albert Guest	5.13
14	Special Hero	Christina M. Kerschen	5.14
15	Making Life Worth While	George Eliot	5.15
16	A Thing of Beauty	John Keats	5.16
17	Lessons in Life	Brigette Bryant and Daniel Ho	5.17
18	My Computer Needs a Break	Shanthini Govindan	5.18
19	Your Space	David Bates	5.19
20	Sea Fever	John Masefield	5.20
21	Courage	Edgar Albert Guest	5.21

No.	Poem	Poet	Notes in
22	Team Work	Edgar Albert Guest	5.22
23	From a Railway Carriage	Robert Louis Stevenson	5.23
24	Indian Seasons	Nisha Dyrene	5.24
25	A Tragic Story	William Makepeace Thackeray	5.25

Note for poet-matching: Edgar Albert Guest wrote three of the 25 poems — The Stick-together Families (5.13), Courage (5.21) and Team Work (5.22).

DO NOT CONFUSE: "A Psalm of Life", "The Solitary Reaper", "Sonnet 116" etc. belong to the OLDER syllabus. Old question banks and guides still carry them. For the 2022 syllabus, master the 25 poems above first.

Syllabus details can change: always check the latest official notification on tnpsc.gov.in.

1.3 How questions are framed

Be ready for these five types of questions. Do not depend on any fixed pattern; check the latest official notification.

Question type	Sample stem	How to answer
Identify the figure in a quoted line	Identify the figure of speech: " <i>My little horse must think it queer</i> "	Find the clue: a horse "thinks", which is a human act → Personification (3.4). Run the 10-Second Method (7.2) on every such line.
Pick out the rhyming words	Pick out the rhyming words: " <i>I was angry with my friend; / I told my wrath, my wrath did end.</i> "	Look only at the last word of each line: friend - end . Trust the sound, not the spelling (3.9).
Give the rhyme scheme	The rhyme scheme of the first stanza of "Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening" is ____.	Write the end words: know, though, here, snow. Same end-sound = same letter; new end-sound = next letter: aaba (3.8, 5.7).
Poetry appreciation	In " <i>But I have promises to keep,</i> " the word "promises" stands for ____.	Know each poem's theme and symbols (Section 5). Answer from the poem, not the dictionary: here promises = the duties the poet must still do.
Match the figure with the example	Match (1) Simile (2) Metaphor (3) Onomatopoeia (4) Anaphora with (a) " <i>and give my mouse a click,</i> " (b) " <i>Like a child at play.</i> " (c) " <i>She's a lioness; don't mess with her.</i> " (d) " <i>I was angry with my friend; ... I was angry with my foe:</i> "	Fix the surest pair first (a sound-word, or "like"), then eliminate. Answer: 1-b, 2-c, 3-a, 4-d. The reverse form, "Which line contains a simile?", is solved the same way.

TRY TWO

QC1. Identify the figure of speech: "*Fly as thick as driving rain;*" (PYQ-style)

- a. Alliteration
- b. Simile
- c. Onomatopoeia
- d. Anaphora

Answer: (b) - Simile: "as thick as" compares the rushing sights with heavy rain, two unlike things. Eliminate the rest: no sound-word (not c), no repeated first sound (not a), and no word repeated at the start of lines or clauses (not d).

QC2. The rhyme scheme of the first four lines of "The Secret of the Machines" (end words: mine, pit, design, fit) is: (PYQ-style)

- a. aabb
- b. abab
- c. abcb
- d. abba

Answer: (b) - mine = a, pit = b, design rhymes with mine = a, fit rhymes with pit = b: abab.

1.4 How to use these notes

Sections 2 and 7 give the big picture and the tricks. Sections 3 and 4 explain each figure. Section 5 goes poem by poem. Section 6 separates look-alike figures. Section 8 tests you, and Section 9 is for the last day. One week is enough if you follow this plan.

SIGNS USED IN THESE NOTES

IN SYLLABUS	Named in the 2022 syllabus (the 9 figures of Section 3)
ALSO ASKED	Not among the 9 named figures, but covered by "etc."
Family chip, e.g. Comparison	The job the figure does — one of the 7 families in Section 2
Clue-word box, e.g. like	A word that points to a figure (full list in 7.3)
MUST REMEMBER	A core fact to learn by heart
EXAM TIP	How to choose the right option
MEMORY TRICK	A short hook to recall a figure
DO NOT CONFUSE	A trap: two look-alike figures or facts
Verse card	An exact line from a syllabus poem; the clue words are highlighted and the figure is explained below the line

THE 7-DAY PLAN

Day	Study	Self-test
1	Sections 1 and 2: the syllabus, the 25 poems, the 7 families and the master map	Write the 9 syllabus figures from memory with the mnemonic (7.1) and name the family of each.
2	3.1 to 3.5: Alliteration, Simile, Metaphor, Personification, Onomatopoeia	Do the quick checks in each card; make one everyday example of each figure.
3	3.6 to 3.9: Anaphora, Repetition, Rhyme Scheme, Rhyming Words	Work out the rhyme scheme of five poems; check your answers in Section 5.
4	Section 4: the other figures (4.1 to 4.27)	Write one easy example of each figure without looking.
5	Section 5: poems 5.1 to 5.13	For each poem, say the poet, the rhyme scheme and two figures.
6	Section 5: poems 5.14 to 5.25, then Section 6	Explain five look-alike pairs in one line each.
7	Sections 7, 8 and 9	Do all the practice questions; reread the notes for every wrong answer.

MUST REMEMBER: The 2022 syllabus names 9 figures and ends the list with "etc.", so other figures can also be asked. Master the 9 first (Section 3), then the 4 from the earlier syllabus — Apostrophe, Allusion, Oxymoron, Ellipsis (4.1 to 4.4) — then the rest of Section 4.

MUST REMEMBER: Read every line aloud in your mind. Alliteration and rhyme depend on SOUND, not spelling. “*My heart will keep the courage of the quest,*” repeats the k sound (keep, courage, quest), but “*Whose woods*” is NOT alliteration, because “whose” begins with an h sound.

MUST REMEMBER: One line can hold several figures. Choose the one the question and the options point to (see 7.5). Learn the 25 poems with their poets: a line you can place is a line you can answer.

2 The Segregation Map

These notes cover 36 figures. That sounds like a lot, but every figure does one of only seven jobs. Learn the seven **families** first. Then every figure has a home, and a puzzling line becomes a choice between two or three members of one family.

Key used in this section: **(S)** = named in the 2022 syllabus; **(E)** = named in the earlier syllabus; no mark = covered by "etc."

2.1 The 7 families

Family	What it does	Figures in it	Master clue
Comparison	Shows one thing through another, unlike thing	Simile (S), Metaphor (S), Personification (S), Apostrophe (E), Extended Metaphor and Allegory	Is one thing shown as, or spoken to as, something it is not?
Sound	Makes music with the sounds of words	Alliteration (S), Assonance, Consonance, Onomatopoeia (S), Rhyme Scheme (S), Rhyming Words (S)	Say it aloud: which sound repeats, or which word copies a sound?

Family	What it does	Figures in it	Master clue
Repetition and order	Repeats, re-orders or leaves out words for effect	Anaphora (S), Repetition (S), Epistrophe, Refrain, Polysyndeton and Asyndeton, Chiasmus, Inversion, Climax and Anticlimax, Ellipsis (E)	Look at the shape: what repeats and where, what order, what is missing?
Contrast	Sets opposite words or ideas against each other, often in a sharp, witty line	Oxymoron (E), Paradox, Antithesis, Epigram	Do opposites meet?
Exaggeration and understatement	Makes a thing bigger, smaller or softer than it really is	Hyperbole, Litotes and Understatement, Euphemism	Is it more, less or milder than the truth?
Indirect meaning	Means more than, or the opposite of, the plain words	Irony and Sarcasm, Pun, Rhetorical Question, Exclamation	Does the tone (a double meaning, an opposite meaning, a ? or a !) carry the message?
Association and reference	Points to something linked: a story, a part, a related object, a sign or a sense	Allusion (E), Metonymy, Synecdoche, Transferred Epithet, Imagery and Symbolism	Does something stand for, or point to, something else?

Count them: 5 + 6 + 9 + 4 + 3 + 4 + 5 = 36. All 9 syllabus figures come from just the first three families: Comparison (3), Sound (4) and Repetition and order (2).

THE SEVEN FAMILIES IN THE SYLLABUS POEMS

Every family appears in the 25 poems. One clear line for each:

Family	A line from the syllabus poems	Figure
Comparison	<i>"Like a child at play."</i> (The River, 5.11)	Simile: the river is compared with a child
Sound	<i>"With forward face and reluctant soul,"</i> (Life, 5.1)	Alliteration: forward, face
Repetition and order	<i>"And miles to go before I sleep, / And miles to go before I sleep."</i> (Stopping by Woods, 5.7)	Repetition: the same line twice
Contrast	<i>"and it's empty joy they find,"</i> (The Stick-together Families, 5.13)	Oxymoron: empty joy
Exaggeration and understatement	<i>"It seems to know mountains of information by heart."</i> (My Computer Needs a Break, 5.18)	Hyperbole: mountains of information
Indirect meaning	<i>"How could this be?"</i> (The House on Elm Street, 5.6)	Rhetorical question: no answer is expected
Association and reference	<i>"Till it bore an apple bright."</i> (A Poison Tree, 5.8)	Allusion: the forbidden fruit in the Garden of Eden

TELLING FAMILY MEMBERS APART

- **Comparison:** "like / as" = Simile; "is" = Metaphor; a thing acting like a human = Personification; a thing or an absent person spoken TO = Apostrophe.
- **Sound:** same first consonant sound = Alliteration; same vowel sound = Assonance; same consonant sound inside or at the end = Consonance; a word that copies a noise = Onomatopoeia.
- **Repetition and order:** same opening word(s), the rest of the line changing = Anaphora; same word(s) at the END = Epistrophe; a line closing every stanza = Refrain; a whole line said again, or a word repeated ANYWHERE = Repetition.
- **Contrast:** two opposite WORDS side by side = Oxymoron; two opposite IDEAS in balance = Antithesis; a whole statement that seems absurd but is true = Paradox.
- **Exaggeration and understatement:** bigger = Hyperbole; smaller, often with "not" = Litotes; softer = Euphemism.

Section 6 explains these look-alike pairs in full.

2.2 Master map of all 36 figures

Use this table as your one-page index. Clue words are in boxes. "Notes in" gives the full card.

Figure	Key / clue words	Tiny example	Notes in
A. Comparison (5 figures)			
Simile (S)	like as as ... as as if than comparing two unlike things	She sings like a koel.	3.2
Metaphor (S)	A is B, with no like or as	The classroom was a zoo.	3.3
Personification (S)	human actions or feelings given to things, animals or ideas: smiled wept danced	The coconut trees danced in the wind.	3.4
Apostrophe (E)	O + a name; speaking TO a thing, an idea or an absent person	Twinkle, twinkle, little star, how I wonder what you are!	4.1
Extended Metaphor and Allegory	one comparison kept up for many lines; a whole story with a hidden lesson	Life shown as a journey through a whole poem (5.1); a fable with a moral (5.4)	4.27
B. Sound (6 figures)			
Alliteration (S)	same first consonant SOUND in nearby words	Peter Piper picked a peck of pickled peppers.	3.1
Assonance	same VOWEL sound inside nearby words	The rain in Spain stays mainly in the plain.	4.5
Consonance	same CONSONANT sound inside or at the end of words	first and last (st); odds and ends (ds)	4.6
Onomatopoeia (S)	sound words: buzz hiss click sizzle tick-tock	The dosa sizzled on the tawa.	3.5
Rhyme Scheme (S)	letters a, b, c ... for the line-end sounds	Twinkle, Twinkle: star, are, high, sky = aabb	3.8
Rhyming Words (S)	words with the same END sound	star - are; high - sky	3.9
C. Repetition and order (9 figures)			
Anaphora (S)	same word or words at the START of lines or clauses; the rest changes	Work hard, work honestly, work every day.	3.6
Repetition (S)	a word, phrase or line repeated anywhere, for emphasis	Rain, rain, go away.	3.7
Epistrophe	same word or words at the END of lines or clauses	of the people, by the people, for the people	4.21
Refrain	a line or phrase that returns at the end of every stanza, like a chorus	" <i>behind him</i> " closes every stanza of A Tragic Story (5.25)	4.22
Polysyndeton and Asyndeton	many and s / no "and" at all	idli and dosa and vada and pongal / I came, I saw, I conquered.	4.23
Chiasmus	criss-cross order: A B / B A	Eat to live; do not live to eat.	4.24
Inversion	normal word order turned round	Sweet is the mango. (normal: The mango is sweet.)	4.20
Climax and Anticlimax	ideas in rising order / a sudden drop to something trivial	He studied, he passed, he topped the state. / He lost his house, his car and his pencil.	4.25
Ellipsis (E)	words left out that the reader can supply; the mark ...	Some like tea; others, coffee.	4.4
D. Contrast (4 figures)			
Oxymoron (E)	two opposite WORDS side by side	deafening silence; sweet sorrow	4.3
Paradox	a statement that seems absurd but holds a truth	Less is more.	4.11
Antithesis	opposite IDEAS in balanced halves	Speech is silver, silence is golden.	4.12
Epigram	a short, witty, memorable saying	Brevity is the soul of wit.	4.13
E. Exaggeration and understatement (3 figures)			
Hyperbole	deliberate, impossible exaggeration: a thousand times tons of	I have told you a thousand times!	4.7
Litotes and Understatement	not + the opposite; playing a thing down	Your coffee is not bad. (= good)	4.8
Euphemism	a mild word for a harsh fact: passed away	Grandpa passed away last year. (= died)	4.9
F. Indirect meaning (4 figures)			

Figure	Key / clue words	Tiny example	Notes in
Irony and Sarcasm	the opposite of what is said or expected; sarcasm is irony meant to hurt	A fire station burns down (irony). "Oh, great! Another power cut." (sarcasm)	4.10
Pun	one word used with two meanings	I used to be a banker, but I lost interest.	4.14
Rhetorical Question	a  asked for effect, not for an answer	Who does not love holidays?	4.18
Exclamation	   for strong feeling	Alas! We missed the bus.	4.19
G. Association and reference (5 figures)			
Allusion (E)	a brief reference to a famous person, place, story or text	He is the Kumbhakarna of our hostel. (he sleeps all day)	4.2
Metonymy	a thing named by something closely linked to it	The kettle is boiling. (the water in it boils)	4.15
Synecdoche	a part for the whole, or the whole for a part	All hands on deck! (hands = sailors)	4.16
Transferred Epithet	an adjective moved from a person to a thing	a sleepless night; a busy day	4.17
Imagery and Symbolism	words for the five senses; an object that stands for an idea	the smell of hot sambar (imagery); a dove = peace (symbol)	4.26

2.3 Segregation by syllabus status

Read across each family to see which of its members the syllabus names. Study column 1 first, then column 2, then column 3.

Named in the 2022 syllabus (9)	Named in the earlier syllabus (4)	Also asked (the rest)
A. Comparison		
Simile (3.2), Metaphor (3.3), Personification (3.4)	Apostrophe (4.1)	Extended Metaphor and Allegory (4.27)
B. Sound		
Alliteration (3.1), Onomatopoeia (3.5), Rhyme Scheme (3.8), Rhyming Words (3.9)	—	Assonance (4.5), Consonance (4.6)
C. Repetition and order		
Anaphora (3.6), Repetition (3.7)	Ellipsis (4.4)	Inversion (4.20), Epistrophe (4.21), Refrain (4.22), Polysyndeton and Asyndeton (4.23), Chiasmus (4.24), Climax and Anticlimax (4.25)
D. Contrast		
—	Oxymoron (4.3)	Paradox (4.11), Antithesis (4.12), Epigram (4.13)
E. Exaggeration and understatement		
—	—	Hyperbole (4.7), Litotes and Understatement (4.8), Euphemism (4.9)
F. Indirect meaning		
—	—	Irony and Sarcasm (4.10), Pun (4.14), Rhetorical Question (4.18), Exclamation (4.19)
G. Association and reference		
—	Allusion (4.2)	Metonymy (4.15), Synecdoche (4.16), Transferred Epithet (4.17), Imagery and Symbolism (4.26)
Total: 9	Total: 4	Total: 23

Two facts stand out. First, the 2022 list comes only from the first three families: Comparison, Sound, and Repetition and order. Second, the four earlier-syllabus figures belong to four different families: Apostrophe (Comparison), Ellipsis (Repetition and order), Oxymoron (Contrast) and Allusion (Association and reference). Families E and F have no named figure at all, but their members (Hyperbole, Irony, Rhetorical Question and others) appear in several of the poems, and "etc." keeps them open to questions.

2.4 Remember the map

MEMORY TRICK: The seven families in order: "Can Students Really Crack Exams Instantly? Absolutely!" = Comparison, Sound, Repetition and order, Contrast, Exaggeration and understatement, Indirect meaning, Association and reference. All 9 syllabus figures live in the first three words: C, S, R.

EXAM TIP: When a line puzzles you, first name its FAMILY (is it comparing, sounding, repeating, contrasting ...?), then choose the figure inside that family. This often removes two or three options at once.

3 Syllabus Figures in Depth

The 2022 revised syllabus names **nine** figures of speech. This section takes each of them in depth: the meaning, the exam definition, the clue words, how to spot it, a memory trick, easy everyday examples, the best lines from the 25 syllabus poems, the trap that examiners set, and three quick-check questions. The syllabus list ends with "etc.", so other figures can also be asked — they are in Section 4.

No.	Figure	Meaning in one line	Family
3.1	Alliteration	The same first consonant SOUND in nearby words.	Sound
3.2	Simile	An open comparison of two unlike things with a comparing word (like, as, than ...).	Comparison
3.3	Metaphor	A hidden comparison: one thing IS another, with no like or as.	Comparison
3.4	Personification	A thing, an animal or an idea acts, feels or speaks like a person.	Comparison
3.5	Onomatopoeia	A word that copies the sound it names (buzz, click).	Sound
3.6	Anaphora	The same word or phrase at the START of successive lines or clauses.	Repetition and order
3.7	Repetition	A word, phrase or line repeated anywhere for emphasis.	Repetition and order
3.8	Rhyme Scheme	The pattern of END rhymes, marked with small letters a, b, c ...	Sound
3.9	Rhyming Words	Words whose last sounds match, usually at the ends of lines.	Sound

MEMORY TRICK: "A Smart Monkey Plays On A Rainy Rocky Road" = Alliteration, Simile, Metaphor, Personification, Onomatopoeia, Anaphora, Repetition, Rhyme scheme, Rhyming words — the same order as 3.1 to 3.9.

EXAM TIP: Three of the nine COMPARE (Simile, Metaphor, Personification), four play with SOUND (Alliteration, Onomatopoeia, Rhyme Scheme, Rhyming Words) and two REPEAT (Anaphora, Repetition). In the exam, first decide the family, then the exact figure (see Section 2).

3.1 Alliteration

IN SYLLABUS

Sound

Meaning	The same first sound is repeated in words that stand close together.
Exam definition	Alliteration is the repetition of the same beginning consonant SOUND in two or more nearby words of a line or phrase. It depends on SOUND, not on spelling.
Key / clue words	No fixed clue word — the clue is a repeated first sound: f ... f k = c = q f = ph s ≠ sh say it aloud
How to spot it	1. Say the line aloud (or in your mind). 2. Listen to the FIRST sound of each important word — ignore the spelling. 3. Two or more nearby words with the same first consonant sound = alliteration. Small words (a, the, of, and) may come in between.
Memory trick	ALL-ITERATION: ALL the words start with the same SOUND — say it aloud. Trust your EARS, not your EYES.

EASY EXAMPLES

Amma made dosa, dal and delicious chutney. **d - d - d**

The big blue bus braked at the busy bus stand. **b sound**

Kumar kept cool with coconut water. **k sound: K and C**

Father's phone fell on the floor. **f sound: F and PH**

Seven silly sparrows sat on the Marina sand. **s sound**

Peter Piper picked a peck of pickled peppers. (classic tongue twister) **p sound**

SOUND, NOT LETTER: THE DECIDING TEST

Words	First letters	First sounds	Alliteration?
"keep the courage of the quest"	k, c, q	k, k, k	✓ Yes — three spellings, one sound
phone, fan	ph, f	f, f	✓ Yes
gem, jam	g, j	j, j	✓ Yes
know, nose	k (silent), n	n, n	✓ Yes
city, cat	c, c	s, k	X No — same letter, different sounds
honest, hat	h, h	o (h is silent), h	X No
"Whose woods"	w, w	h, w	X No
"simple sheep"	s, s	s, sh	X No
"short and sweet"	s, s	sh, s	X No

MUST REMEMBER: Alliteration gives a line RHYTHM and MUSIC and makes it EASY TO REMEMBER — that is why proverbs (Practice makes perfect; Look before you leap; Waste not, want not; Time and tide wait for none), tongue twisters, slogans and poems use it. Vowel-sound alliteration exists but is rare; in the exam, alliteration almost always means a repeated CONSONANT sound. Repeated vowel sounds are Assonance (4.5); repeated consonants inside or at the end of words are Consonance (4.6).

EXAM TIP: Besides the eight lines below, also learn "We can print and plough and weave and heat and light," (p), "A flowery band to bind us to the earth," (b), "She's strong in her faith, firm in her belief!" (f), "So I had to call in a doctor, double quick." (d) and "monsoons and mangoes" (m).

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

My heart will **keep** the **c**ourage of the **q**uest,
LIFE • HENRY VAN DYKE

Alliteration (k sound) — keep, courage, quest: three different letters (k, c, q) but ONE sound. The best proof that alliteration is about sound, not letters.

Faster than **f**airies, **f**aster than witches,
FROM A RAILWAY CARRIAGE • ROBERT LOUIS STEVENSON

Alliteration (f) — the quick f sounds copy the speed of the train. The line is ALSO a simile (than) and hyperbole; if the options clash, alliteration is the safest single answer.

To **w**atch his **w**oods fill up **w**ith snow.
STOPPING BY WOODS ON A SNOWY EVENING • ROBERT FROST

Alliteration (w) — watch, woods, with. The same stanza has "His house is in the village though;" (h). But the FIRST line of the poem is a trap — see below.

And all I ask is a tall ship and a **s**tar to **s**teer her by;
SEA FEVER • JOHN MASEFIELD

Alliteration (st) — star, steer. The poem is full of it: "And the wheel's kick and the wind's song and the white sail's shaking," (w).

And I **s**unned it with **s**mile,
A POISON TREE • WILLIAM BLAKE

Alliteration (s) — sunned, smiles. The same line is part of the extended metaphor of anger as a tree (see 3.3).

On you **r**ush through **r**ough and smooth;

THE RIVER • CAROLINE ANN BOWLES

Alliteration (r) — rush, rough: the rolling r suits the rushing young river. Also “Down you dash into the sea,” (d).

And though he **t**wist and **t**wirl, and **t**ack,

A TRAGIC STORY • WILLIAM MAKEPEACE THACKERAY

Alliteration (t) — twist, twirl, tack. “Though” begins with a th sound, so it is NOT part of the pattern.

A **d**aring **d**eed in a moment's flash;

COURAGE • EDGAR ALBERT GUEST

Alliteration (d) — daring, deed.

DO NOT CONFUSE: “Whose woods these are I think I know.” is NOT alliteration. “Whose” begins with an **h** sound (hooz) and “woods” with a **w** sound — similar letters, different sounds. This famous line is **Inversion** (4.20). The real alliteration in this poem is “To watch his woods fill up with snow.” (w).

DO NOT CONFUSE: s is not sh. In “For simple sheep; and such are daffodils” and “but short and sweet”, the two words begin with different sounds (s / sh), so the pairs are not true alliteration. Also, the same WORD said again (“River, river, little river!”) is Repetition (3.7); alliteration needs DIFFERENT words with the same first sound.

QUICK CHECK

QC1. Identify the figure of speech: “With forward face and reluctant soul;” (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Alliteration
- c. Onomatopoeia
- d. Metaphor

Answer: (b) - Alliteration: “forward” and “face” begin with the same f sound. (“Unreluctant” is also litotes, 4.8.)

QC2. Which line is NOT an example of alliteration? (PYQ-style)

- a. “Let me but live my life from year to year,”
- b. “We can run and race and swim and fly and dive,”
- c. “A comet in full flight.”
- d. “Whose woods these are I think I know.”

Answer: (d) - “whose” begins with an h sound and “woods” with a w sound; (a) repeats l, (b) r and (c) f.

QC3. Which sound is repeated in “My heart will keep the courage of the quest,”? (PYQ-style)

- a. the k sound
- b. the h sound
- c. the q sound only
- d. the m sound

Answer: (a) - keep, courage and quest are spelt with k, c and q, but all three begin with the k sound.

3.2 Simile

IN SYLLABUS

Comparison

Meaning	Two different things are compared openly, using a comparing word such as “like” or “as”.					
Exam definition	A simile is an explicit (open, direct) comparison between two UNLIKE things that share a quality, made with a comparing word: like, as, as ... as, so ... as, as if, as though, or than.					
Key / clue words	like	as	as ... as	so ... as	as if	as though
	than					

How to spot it	1. Find the comparing word. 2. Check that two UNLIKE things are compared (charging animals and troops, a friend and a flower). 3. Find the shared quality (speed, care). All three present = simile.
Memory trick	Simile Says "like"; Metaphor Means "is". SIMILE sounds like SIMILAR — it openly says one thing is similar to another.

EASY EXAMPLES

Chennai in May is as hot as an oven.

as ... as

The Marina sand shines like gold in the evening sun.

like

The auto-rickshaw zipped through the traffic as if it had wings.

as if

After the first rain, the paddy fields looked as though someone had spread a green carpet.

as though

In the kabaddi match, Selvi ran faster than a deer.

than

"Twinkle, twinkle, little star ... Like a diamond in the sky." (classic nursery rhyme)

like

THE FULL LIST OF COMPARING WORDS

Comparing word	Everyday example	Syllabus example
like	She sings like a koel.	<i>"Like a child at play."</i>
as ... as	The idli was as soft as cotton.	<i>"Fly as thick as driving rain;"</i>
as (short form)	white as milk; busy as a bee	<i>"still as time;" "mine are dull as lead!"</i>
so ... as	Raju is not so cunning as a fox.	—
as if	He fought as if he were a lion.	—
as though	The old man stood still, as though he were a statue.	—
than	Her heart is softer than butter.	<i>"Faster than a cheetah" "Bigger than a mountain"</i>

Common similes worth knowing: as brave as a lion, as busy as a bee, as cunning as a fox, as proud as a peacock, as gentle as a lamb, as strong as an ox, as slow as a tortoise, as light as a feather, as cool as a cucumber, as white as snow, as quick as lightning, as fresh as a daisy.

WHEN "LIKE" OR "AS" IS NOT A SIMILE

Sentence	Simile?	Why
I like idli.	X No	"like" = enjoy (a verb). Nothing is compared.
As I reached home, it began to rain.	X No	"as" = when (time).
As he was ill, he stayed at home.	X No	"as" = because (reason).
He works as a bus conductor.	X No	"as" = in the role of.
Fruits like mango and banana are good for health.	X No	"like" = such as (giving examples).
She is as tall as her brother.	X No	Two LIKE things (two people): a plain, literal comparison.
She is as tall as a coconut tree.	✓ Yes	A girl and a tree are UNLIKE things (also hyperbole, 4.7).

MUST REMEMBER: (1) A comparison with "than" counts as a SIMILE in textbook keys: *"Faster than a cheetah"*. (2) *"Faster than fairies, faster than witches,"* is ALSO alliteration and hyperbole — answer what the question focuses on; if the options clash, alliteration is the safest single answer. (3) *"a single body breathes / Like ours"* and *"Remember they have eyes like ours that wake"*: the textbook answer is SIMILE (comparison with "like"), even though it compares people with people — the poet's point is that "they" are just like "us".

THE RIVER: A LADDER OF SIMILES

Caroline Ann Bowles compares the river with human life, one stage in each stanza. Learn the four steps in order:

Stanza	The river is	Simile	Stage of human life
1	little — sparkling, dancing over pebbles	<i>“Like a child at play.”</i>	Childhood: playful, carefree
2	swelling — rushing, louder, faster, leaping	<i>“Like impetuous youth.”</i>	Youth: hasty, restless, bold
3	brimming — broad, deep and calm	<i>“Broad and deep, and still as time;” “Just like mortal prime.”</i>	Prime (adult life): mature, steady, moving to its goal
4	headlong — dashing into the endless sea	<i>“Like eternity.”</i>	Death and eternity: life merges into the endless

EXAM TIP: Child → youth → prime → eternity. One comparison (river = human life) carried through the whole poem is an **extended simile** (4.27), and the river's course is a **symbol** of life (4.26).

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

*O'er the yellow pebbles dancing,
Through the flowers and foliage glancing,
Like a child at play.*

THE RIVER • CAROLINE ANN BOWLES

Simile — the sparkling, dancing young river is compared to a playful child with **like**. ("Dancing" is also personification, 3.4.)

*All of the sights of the hill and the plain
Fly **as** thick **as** driving rain;*

FROM A RAILWAY CARRIAGE • ROBERT LOUIS STEVENSON

Simile (as ... as) — the sights rushing past the window are compared to thick, driving rain. The same poem has *“And charging along like troops in a battle,”* (like).

*To the gull's way and the whale's way where the wind's **like** a whetted knife;*

SEA FEVER • JOHN MASEFIELD

Simile — the cold, cutting sea wind is compared to a sharpened (whetted) knife. The w sounds make it alliteration too (3.1).

*Your eyes are **like** the diamond bright, but mine are dull **as** lead!*

THE SPIDER AND THE FLY • MARY BOTHAM HOWITT

Two similes — the Fly's eyes = bright diamonds (like); the Spider's own eyes = dull lead (as). The Spider flatters the Fly to trap her.

*Having a friend is **like** planting a flower*

LESSONS IN LIFE • BRIGETTE BRYANT AND DANIEL HO

Simile — friendship is compared to planting a flower: both need love and care before they bloom.

*Faster **than** a cheetah*

With a tail that's miles long,

THE COMET • NORMAN LITTLEFORD

Simile with **than** (the textbook key) — the comet's speed is compared to a cheetah's. In the same stanza: *“Bigger than a mountain”*.

Beneath all uniforms, a single body breathes

***Like** ours: the land our brothers walk upon*

NO MEN ARE FOREIGN • JAMES FALCONER KIRKUP

Simile (textbook answer) — the body under every uniform breathes "like ours": people are compared with people to show that all humans are the same. ("Uniforms" for soldiers is metonymy, 4.15.)

DO NOT CONFUSE: Simile vs Metaphor. "Chennai is LIKE an oven" (comparing word present) = Simile. "Chennai IS an oven" (no comparing word) = Metaphor (3.3). Remove "like" or "as" from a simile and you get a metaphor.

DO NOT CONFUSE: "than" does not always make a simile. In "*We are nothing more than children of your brain!*", "nothing more than" only means "just"; the figure is the METAPHOR "children of your brain" (3.3). In the same way, "I like idli", "As I reached home" and "She is as tall as her brother" are not similes (table above).

QUICK CHECK

QC4. Identify the figure of speech: "*where the wind's like a whetted knife;*" (PYQ-style)

- a. Metaphor
- b. Personification
- c. Simile
- d. Onomatopoeia

Answer: (c) - Simile: the wind is compared to a sharpened knife with the comparing word "like".

QC5. In which sentence does "like" NOT make a simile? (PYQ-style)

- a. I like idli with coconut chutney.
- b. The lake shone like a mirror.
- c. He fought like a lion.
- d. Her hair is black like the night.

Answer: (a) - here "like" is a verb meaning "enjoy"; nothing is compared.

QC6. According to textbook keys, "*Faster than a cheetah*" is an example of (PYQ-style)

- a. Metaphor
- b. Personification
- c. Onomatopoeia
- d. Simile

Answer: (d) - a comparison of unlike things with "than" is counted as a simile.

3.3 Metaphor

IN SYLLABUS

Comparison

Meaning	One thing is said to BE another thing, without "like" or "as".
Exam definition	A metaphor is an implied (hidden) comparison between two unlike things: one thing is spoken of as if it were the other, without a comparing word. It also covers a single word used in a non-literal (figurative) sense, such as " <i>leperous hide</i> " or " <i>the road's last turn</i> ".
Key / clue words	is / are / was X of Y no like / as a word used non-literally
How to spot it	1. Something is compared, but there is NO like / as / than. 2. Read it literally — it is impossible (a woman cannot really be a lioness). 3. Ask "in what way are they alike?" (brave, fierce). That shared quality is the hidden comparison.
Memory trick	Simile Says "like"; Metaphor Means "is". Metaphor = Simile minus "like".

EASY EXAMPLES

Chennai in May is a furnace. **is (no like)**

The classroom was a fish market before the teacher came. **was**

Our headmaster has a heart of gold. **heart of gold**

My grandfather is a walking encyclopedia. **is**

The teacher's sharp words stung me. **stung (a verb)**

"All the world's a stage." (Shakespeare, As You Like It) **'s = is**

SIMILE TO METAPHOR: DROP THE COMPARING WORD

Simile (open)	Metaphor (hidden)
Chennai in May is as hot as an oven.	Chennai in May is an oven.
In hard times my friend is like a rock.	In hard times my friend is a rock.
Life is like a journey.	Life is a journey.

METAPHOR WITHOUT "IS": NOUNS, VERBS AND ADJECTIVES

A metaphor need not say "X is Y". It can hide inside ONE word — a noun, a verb or an adjective used in a non-literal sense.

Where it hides	Syllabus example	What is compared
Noun: X is Y	<i>"Persistence is the key to everything."</i>	persistence = a key that opens every door
Noun phrase	<i>"And hope the road's last turn will be the best."</i>	life = a road; its last turn = old age, the end of life
Adjective + noun	<i>"leperous hide"</i>	the rough, scaly bark = the diseased skin of a leper; "hide" = an animal's skin
Adjective	<i>"To brave the thickening ills of life;"</i>	troubles grow "thick", like gathering clouds
Verb	<i>"But it's bitterness they harvest"</i>	a selfish life = a field that gives a bitter crop
Possessive phrase	<i>"by war's long winter starv'd"</i>	war = a long, hungry winter

EXTENDED METAPHOR: ONE COMPARISON THROUGH MANY LINES

Poem	The comparison	Words that carry it
A Poison Tree (5.8)	anger (wrath) = a tree	watered with fears and tears, sunned with smiles, grows day and night, and at last bears <i>"an apple bright."</i>
Life (5.1)	life = a journey on a road	way, hill, rough or smooth, journey, quest, <i>"the road's last turn"</i>
Team Work (5.22)	life = a team game	<i>"For there's no lone hand in the game we play,"</i> — star, running mate, score, win the game

EXAM TIP: If a question says the comparison "runs through the whole poem", the answer is **extended metaphor** (4.27). A whole story with a hidden moral (a fable) is an **allegory**.

DEAD METAPHORS IN DAILY SPEECH

Some metaphors are so old that we no longer notice them: **the leg of a table, the foot of a hill, the mouth of a river, the eye of a needle, the arm of a chair, the head of a department, the heart of the city**. Nobody thinks a table walks! These are called **dead metaphors**. They are rarely asked, but they show how common metaphor is — and if one is asked, the answer is still Metaphor.

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

She's a **lioness**; don't mess with her.

I AM EVERY WOMAN • RAKHI NARIANI SHIRKE

Metaphor — the woman IS a lioness: brave, protective, fierce. No "like", so it is not a simile.

We are nothing more than **children of your brain!**

THE SECRET OF THE MACHINES • RUDYARD KIPLING

Metaphor — the machines call themselves the children of the human brain: humans "gave birth" to them by invention. "Nothing more than" just means "only" — it is not a simile.

So let the **way** wind up the hill or down,
O'er rough or smooth, the **journey** will be joy:

LIFE • HENRY VAN DYKE

Metaphor — life is a journey on a road; hills and rough roads = hard times, smooth roads = easy times. Part of the extended metaphor of the whole sonnet.

And I **water'd** it in fears,
Night and morning with my tears:
A POISON TREE • WILLIAM BLAKE

Metaphor (a verb metaphor) — "it" is the poet's anger, treated as a plant he waters. The tree grows through the whole poem: **extended metaphor**.

And out of its **leperous hide**
Sprouting leaves.
ON KILLING A TREE • GIEVE PATEL

Metaphor — the rough, cracked bark of the tree is called the diseased skin ("hide") of a leper.

An endless **fountain** of immortal drink,
Pouring unto us from the heaven's brink.
A THING OF BEAUTY • JOHN KEATS

Metaphor — the beauty of nature and of great stories is an endless fountain of heavenly drink that never runs dry.

The **sands of life** are nearly run,
YOUR SPACE • DAVID BATES

Metaphor — life is the sand in an hourglass; for the aged, the sand has almost run out.

It's the **breath of life** and a strong man's creed.
COURAGE • EDGAR ALBERT GUEST

Metaphor — courage IS the breath of life: we cannot live without it.

DO NOT CONFUSE: Metaphor vs Personification. A PERSON called an animal or a thing ("She's a lioness; don't mess with her.") = Metaphor. A thing or an animal given HUMAN actions ("My little horse must think it queer") = Personification (3.4). Ask which way the comparison goes. When a thing acts like a human, Personification is the more exact answer.

DO NOT CONFUSE: Metaphor vs Simile. "Like impetuous youth." has "like" = Simile; "The sands of life are nearly run," has no comparing word = Metaphor. Look for the comparing word FIRST.

QUICK CHECK

QC7. Identify the figure of speech: "She's a lioness; don't mess with her." (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Metaphor
- c. Personification
- d. Alliteration

Answer: (b) - Metaphor: the woman is called a lioness directly, without "like" or "as".

QC8. Which line contains a metaphor? (PYQ-style)

- a. "Like a child at play."
- b. "Fly as thick as driving rain;"
- c. "The sands of life are nearly run,"
- d. "Faster than a cheetah"

Answer: (c) - the time of a life is spoken of as sand running out of an hourglass, with no comparing word; (a), (b) and (d) use like, as ... as and than.

QC9. In A Poison Tree, the poet's anger is watered (“*And I water'd it in fears*”) and sunned, and it grows until it bears an apple. This comparison, running through the whole poem, is (PYQ-style)

- Extended metaphor
- Onomatopoeia
- Simile
- Alliteration

Answer: (a) - Extended metaphor: anger is treated as a growing tree from start to end, with no "like" or "as".

3.4 Personification IN SYLLABUS Comparison

Meaning	A non-human thing, animal or idea is made to act, feel or speak like a person.
Exam definition	Personification is a figure of speech in which human qualities, feelings or actions are given to non-human things, animals or abstract ideas.
Key / clue words	human action verb human feeling human body part he / she / who for a thing a talking animal
How to spot it	1. Find the subject (who or what does the action). 2. Is it human? If NOT — 3. Is it thinking, feeling, speaking or acting as only a person can? Yes = personification.
Memory trick	PERSONification turns a thing into a PERSON. Subject not human + action human = Personification.

EASY EXAMPLES

- The pressure cooker called Amma with three loud whistles. called
- The angry sun beat down on the Marina. angry
- Our old auto-rickshaw coughed and refused to start. coughed, refused
- The coconut palms danced in the monsoon wind. danced
- Opportunity knocks at the door only once. knocks (an idea acts)
- "The grapes are sour," said the fox. (classic Aesop fable) a talking animal

WHAT CAN BE PERSONIFIED: THINGS, NATURE, IDEAS AND ANIMALS

Personified	Syllabus example	The human touch
A. Things and places		
a computer	<i>“It’s so absent-minded, that I don’t know what to do.”</i>	it forgets, like a person
a house	<i>“It plays with your mind.”</i>	it plays tricks on people
machines	<i>“We can neither love nor pity nor forgive,”</i>	the machines speak as "we"
B. Nature		
the sea	<i>“And a grey mist on the sea’s face, and a grey dawn breaking.”</i>	the sea has a face
the night	<i>“When the night had veiled the pole;”</i>	night covers the sky with a veil
a tree	<i>“The bleeding bark will heal”</i>	it bleeds and heals like a wounded body
C. Ideas and feelings		
love	<i>“Speak gently! - Love doth whisper low”</i>	love whispers
beauty	<i>“Some shape of beauty moves away the pall”</i>	beauty lifts away the dark cloth (pall) of sorrow
the future	<i>“From what the future veils;”</i>	the future hides things behind a veil
D. Animals		
a horse	<i>“He gives his harness bells a shake / To ask if there is some mistake.”</i>	the horse "asks" a question
a spider, a fly, an ant, a cricket	the fables 5.10 and 5.4 (below)	they talk, flatter, beg and argue

FABLES: TALKING ANIMALS

In a fable, animals talk, think and argue like people. The textbook answer for every talking animal is **Personification**. Because the whole story teaches a moral, the poem as a whole is also a fable or allegory (4.27).

- **The Spider and the Fly (5.10):** *"Will you walk into my parlour?" said the Spider to the Fly,* — the spider invites, flatters and lies like a cunning host; the fly answers like a careful guest.
- **The Ant and the Cricket (5.4):** *"Says the ant to the cricket, 'I'm your servant and friend,'"* — the silly cricket begs to borrow; the ant refuses with a mocking reply.

EXAM TIP: Why poets use personification: it makes lifeless things and ideas feel alive and close to us. The sick computer makes us laugh; the "faithful" pigtail makes the sage look silly; the rampaging comet feels powerful and dangerous.

MUST REMEMBER: Personification often comes WITH apostrophe. When a poet speaks TO a river as "you" (apostrophe) and also makes it travel, sparkle and dance like a person (personification), the answer is **Apostrophe + Personification** — see the River verse card below and 4.1.

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

*My little horse must **think** it queer
To stop without a farmhouse near*

STOPPING BY WOODS ON A SNOWY EVENING • ROBERT FROST

Personification — the horse "thinks" it strange to stop in the woods, like a puzzled human. In the next stanza he shakes his harness bells "to ask" if there is some mistake.

*River, river, little river!
Bright **you** sparkle on **your** way;*

THE RIVER • CAROLINE ANN BOWLES

Apostrophe + Personification — the river is spoken to directly as "you" (apostrophe, 4.1) and treated as a living traveller on "your way" (personification).

*At night the house seems to be **alive**,*

THE HOUSE ON ELM STREET • NADIA BUSH

Personification — the empty house seems to live; later *"It plays with your mind."*

*Then my computer caught a virus, and **fell very sick**,
So I had to call in a **doctor**, double quick.*

MY COMPUTER NEEDS A BREAK • SHANTHINI GOVINDAN

Personification — the computer falls sick and needs a doctor, like a patient. ("Virus" is also a pun, 4.14.)

*with sunny **smiles**
and dusty **feet***

INDIAN SEASONS • NISHA DYRENE

Personification — Summer arrives like a person with a smiling face and dusty feet.

*And gently Friendship's **accents** flow;
Affection's **voice** is kind.*

YOUR SPACE • DAVID BATES

Personification — the ideas Friendship and Affection are given a human accent and voice.

Rampaging through the heavens

Never stopping day or night,

THE COMET • NORMAN LITTLEFORD

Personification — the comet rampages (rushes about wildly and violently) like an angry giant who never rests.

Alas! Still *faithful* to his back,

The pigtail hangs behind him.

A TRAGIC STORY • WILLIAM MAKEPEACE THACKERAY

Personification — the pigtail is "faithful", like a loyal friend who never leaves. ("Alas!" is exclamation, 4.19.)

DO NOT CONFUSE: Personification vs Apostrophe. Personification GIVES human qualities to a thing; Apostrophe SPEAKS TO someone absent or to a thing (4.1). "My little horse must think it queer" is only personification — nobody is addressed. The River's opening lines are both. Trick: APOSTROPHE POSTs a message to someone who cannot reply.

DO NOT CONFUSE: A real person doing a human act is NOT personification. In "Doctor, do you think my tired computer wants a holiday?" the doctor is simply a person, but the TIRED computer wanting a HOLIDAY is personification. And a person called an animal ("She's a lioness; don't mess with her.") is Metaphor (3.3), not personification.

QUICK CHECK

QC10. Identify the figure of speech: "My little horse must think it queer" (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Metaphor
- c. Onomatopoeia
- d. Personification

Answer: (d) - Personification: the horse is given human actions - thinking and judging.

QC11. The talking spider and fly in "Will you walk into my parlour?" said the Spider to the Fly," are an example of (PYQ-style)

- a. Onomatopoeia
- b. Personification
- c. Simile
- d. Metaphor

Answer: (b) - Personification: talking animals in a fable are given human speech and thought.

QC12. Choose the best answer for "River, river, little river! / Bright you sparkle on your way;" (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile only
- b. Onomatopoeia
- c. Apostrophe and Personification
- d. Alliteration only

Answer: (c) - the river is addressed as "you" (apostrophe) and treated as a living person on its way (personification).

3.5 Onomatopoeia

IN SYLLABUS

Sound

Meaning	A word that sounds like the sound it names. (Say it: on-o-mat-o-PEE-a.)
Exam definition	Onomatopoeia is the use of a word whose sound imitates (copies) the natural sound of the thing or action it describes, such as buzz, click, hiss, whisper, whistle or snap.
Key / clue words	buzz click whisper whistle snap groan moan sigh bang splash
How to spot it	1. Find a word that names a SOUND. 2. Say it aloud. 3. If the word itself copies that sound (buzz, hiss), it is onomatopoeia. A word that only NAMES a sound without copying it (sound, noise, song, sing) is not.
Memory trick	Onomatopoeia is Greek for "name-making": the word MAKES the noise it NAMES. Say "buzz" — you can hear the bee.

EASY EXAMPLES

The dosa sizzled on the hot tawa. **sizzled**

Amma's pressure cooker whistled three times. **whistled**

Honk! Honk! The auto-rickshaw pushed through the traffic. **honk**

The monsoon rain went pitter-patter on the tin roof. **pitter-patter**

A ripe coconut fell from the tree with a thud. **thud**

"Baa, baa, black sheep, have you any wool?" (classic nursery rhyme) **baa**

SOUND-WORD BANK: LEARN THESE IN GROUPS

Sound words	Who or what makes the sound
A. Animals and birds	
bark, bow-wow	a dog
moo	a cow
meow (mew)	a cat
baa	a sheep or a goat
buzz, hum	a bee, a mosquito
hiss	a snake
quack, croak	a duck, a frog
caw, chirp, tweet, hoot, cuckoo	a crow, a sparrow, small birds, an owl, the cuckoo
roar, neigh, grunt	a lion, a horse, a pig
B. Water and weather	
splash, plop	something falling into water
drip, drip-drop	falling drops, a leaking tap
pitter-patter	light rain
gurgle, gush	flowing water
whoosh, swish	a rush of wind
rumble, boom	thunder
C. Machines and objects	
click	a mouse, a switch, a camera
tick-tock	a clock
ring, ding-dong	a bell
honk, beep, vroom	a horn, an alarm, an engine
bang, crack, crash, thud	things hitting, breaking or falling
clang, clatter, clink	metal vessels and glasses
sizzle, whistle, whirr	a hot pan, a pressure cooker, a fan
snap	a twig or a rope breaking
D. Human sounds	
whisper, murmur, mumble	soft or unclear speech
giggle, chuckle	laughing
sigh, groan, moan	tiredness, pain or sorrow
gasp, hiccup, cough, sneeze, snore	the body
gulp, slurp, munch, crunch	eating and drinking
hush, shush	asking for silence

EXAM TIP: Onomatopoeia can be a whole word (buzz) or the root of a longer word: buzzing, snapped, whistled, clicked are all onomatopoeia. Poets use it to let the reader HEAR the scene.

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

*If I type in a question, and give my mouse a **click**,*

MY COMPUTER NEEDS A BREAK • SHANTHINI GOVINDAN

Onomatopoeia — "click" copies the sound of the mouse button.

*says she. Despite the **sighs** and **groans** and **moans**,*

I AM EVERY WOMAN • RAKHI NARIANI SHIRKE

Onomatopoeia — three sound words for sorrow and pain. The many "and"s are polysyndeton (4.23).

It is to be roped, tied,

*And pulled out - **snapped** out*

ON KILLING A TREE • GIEVE PATEL

Onomatopoeia — "snapped" copies the sharp crack of the root breaking from the earth.

*Speak gently! - Love doth **whisper** low*

YOUR SPACE • DAVID BATES

Onomatopoeia — "whisper" copies soft, breathy speech. Love whispering is also personification (3.4).

And ever again, in the wink of an eye,

*Painted stations **whistle** by.*

FROM A RAILWAY CARRIAGE • ROBERT LOUIS STEVENSON

Onomatopoeia — "whistle" copies the shrill sound heard as the train speeds past each station. The stations seeming to whistle is also personification.

*With **buzzing** wings she hung aloft, then near and nearer drew,*

THE SPIDER AND THE FLY • MARY BOTHAM HOWITT

Onomatopoeia — "buzzing" copies the hum of the fly's wings as she comes closer to the spider's trap.

DO NOT CONFUSE: Onomatopoeia vs Alliteration. Onomatopoeia is ONE word that copies a sound (buzz). Alliteration is the same FIRST sound in several nearby words (busy bees). "Buzzing bees" has both. A word that only NAMES a sound is not onomatopoeia: in "And the wheel's kick and the wind's song and the white sail's shaking," "song" names a sound but does not copy it — this line is alliteration (w) and polysyndeton.

DO NOT CONFUSE: One word, two figures. In "Love doth whisper low" and "Painted stations whistle by.", the WORDS "whisper" and "whistle" are onomatopoeia, while Love and the stations doing these acts is personification (3.4). If the question asks about the word, answer Onomatopoeia; if it asks what is done to Love or the stations, answer Personification.

QUICK CHECK

QC13. Identify the figure of speech in the word "click": "If I type in a question, and give my mouse a click," (PYQ-style)

- a. Onomatopoeia
- b. Simile
- c. Metaphor
- d. Anaphora

Answer: (a) - Onomatopoeia: "click" copies the actual sound of the mouse.

QC14. Which of these is NOT an onomatopoeic word? (PYQ-style)

- a. buzz
- b. hiss
- c. noise
- d. splash

Answer: (c) - "noise" names a sound but does not copy any particular sound.

QC15. In “*With buzzing wings she hung aloft, then near and nearer drew,*” the word "buzzing" is an example of (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Onomatopoeia
- c. Metaphor
- d. Personification

Answer: (b) - Onomatopoeia: "buzzing" imitates the humming sound of the fly's wings.

3.6 Anaphora

IN SYLLABUS

Repetition and order

Meaning	The same word or words come again at the START of lines (or sentences) that follow one another.
Exam definition	Anaphora is the repetition of the same word or phrase at the beginning of successive lines, clauses or sentences, for emphasis, rhythm and strong feeling. Anaphora is one TYPE of repetition (see 3.7).
Key / clue words	No fixed clue word - the clue is the SAME OPENING in line after line. Openers in the syllabus poems: We were We can Speak gently Not a One Here is It isn't It's part of I must go down to the seas again And all I ask is Each Sea that I was angry with my Not They may And though Autumn is
How to spot it	1. Read ONLY the first word or two of each line - cover the rest with your hand. 2. Do two or more lines (or clauses) in a row open with the same word(s)? Then it is anaphora. 3. Check the rest of the line: in anaphora the opening is the same but the rest CHANGES. Whole line the same = repetition (3.7); same words at the END = epistrophe (4.21).
Memory trick	AN aphora is At the stArt ; EP istrophe is at the End . Think of a class promise in which every sentence STARTS the same way: "We will be honest. We will be kind. We will work hard."

EASY EXAMPLES

I came, I saw, I conquered. **I ... I ... I**

Every day I read, every day I write, every day I revise. **every day**

We want clean streets, we want clean water, we want clean air. **we want clean**

Not a cloud in the sky, not a breeze from the sea, not a drop of rain - that is Chennai in May. **not a**

Some watch the cricket match, some play in the street, some sleep after lunch. **some**

Never give up on your studies; never give up on your friends. **never give up on**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

We were taken from the ore-bed and the mine,
We were melted in the furnace and the pit
We were cast and wrought and hammered to design,
We were cut and filed and tooled and gauged to fit.

THE SECRET OF THE MACHINES • RUDYARD KIPLING

Anaphora — **We were** opens four lines in a row. The machines proudly list each step of how they were made. Lines 9-12 do the same with **We can** (see the table below).

Speak gently to the little child!
Speak gently to the young, for they
Speak gently to the aged one,
Speak gently, kindly, to the poor;

YOUR SPACE • DAVID BATES

Anaphora — each of these lines opens a new four-line verse. **Speak gently** begins ten of the poem's 36 lines, so the advice rings again and again: be gentle to the child, the young, the old and the poor.

Not a crumb to be found
On the snow-covered ground;
Not a flower could he see,
Not a leaf on a tree.

THE ANT AND THE CRICKET • ADAPTED FROM AESOP'S FABLES

Anaphora — **Not a** begins three of these four lines. The hammering "not a ... not a ... not a" shows that the hungry cricket finds NOTHING in winter. (Words are also left out here - ellipsis, see 4.4.)

One aspiration yet unfelt;
One bit of courage
For the darkening sky;
One gleam of faith

MAKING LIFE WORTH WHILE • GEORGE ELIOT

Anaphora — **One** opens four lines of this short poem (the fourth comes two lines later). Each "one" is a small gift that a kind person gives to every soul he or she touches.

Here is a child who clammers and scrambles,
All by himself and gathering brambles;
Here is a tramp who stands and gazes;

FROM A RAILWAY CARRIAGE • ROBERT LOUIS STEVENSON

Anaphora — **Here is** opens lines 9, 11 and 13 (line 15 has **And here is**). Like a finger pointing out of the train window, each "Here is" shows one quick sight before it is gone.

It isn't an instantaneous thing
Born of despair with a sudden spring
It isn't a creature of flickered hope
Or the final tug at a slipping rope;

COURAGE • EDGAR ALBERT GUEST

Anaphora — **It isn't** opens lines 3 and 5: the poet first tells us what courage is NOT. The poem also opens lines 1, 9 and 17 with **Courage isn't**, and lines 21, 22 and 29 with **It's part of**.

I must go down to the seas again, to the lonely sea and the sky,
I must go down to the seas again, for the call of the running tide
I must go down to the seas again, to the vagrant gypsy life,

SEA FEVER • JOHN MASEFIELD

Anaphora — these are the first lines of the three stanzas. The same opening shows the sailor's strong, restless pull towards the sea. A second anaphora, **And all I ask is**, comes once in every stanza.

*Each goes searching after pleasure in his own selected way,
Each with strangers likes to wander, and with strangers likes to play.*

THE STICK-TOGETHER FAMILIES • EDGAR ALBERT GUEST

Anaphora — **Each** opens two lines in a row; it stresses that each one goes his OWN way, away from the family. (**with strangers** also comes twice inside line 2 - repetition, 3.7.)

More anaphora to know:

Poem	Lines	Repeated opening
The Secret of the Machines	<i>"We can pull and haul and push and lift and drive, / We can print and plough and weave and heat and light,"</i>	We can (four lines in a row; the many "and"s are polysyndeton, 4.23)
Courage	<i>"It's part of a man when his skies are blue, / It's part of him when he has work to do."</i>	It's part of
The River	<i>"Sea that line hath never sounded, / Sea that sail hath never rounded,"</i>	Sea that
A Poison Tree	<i>"I was angry with my friend; / ... / I was angry with my foe:"</i>	I was angry with my (lines 1 and 3)
Life	<i>"Not hurrying to, nor turning from the goal; / Not mourning for the things that disappear"</i>	Not
Team Work	<i>"They may sound your praise and call you great, / They may single you out for fame,"</i>	They may
A Tragic Story	<i>"And though his efforts never slack, / And though he twist and twirl, and tack,"</i>	And though
Indian Seasons	<i>"Autumn is English / ... / Autumn is Indian"</i>	Autumn is (lines 13 and 15)

ANAPHORA, EPISTROPHE OR PLAIN REPETITION?

Point	Anaphora (3.6)	Epistrophe (4.21)	Plain repetition (3.7)
Where the repeat stands	at the START of lines or clauses that follow one another	at the END of lines or clauses that follow one another	anywhere - side by side, inside a line, or a whole line said again
Shape	X ... / X ... / X ...	... X / ... X / ... X	... X, X ... or the same line twice
Syllabus example	<i>"We can pull ... / We can print ..."</i> (The Secret of the Machines)	<i>"behind him"</i> at the end of every stanza (A Tragic Story)	<i>"And miles to go before I sleep"</i> said twice (Stopping by Woods)
Everyday example	I came, I saw, I conquered.	... of the people, by the people, for the people.	Hurry, hurry, the bus is here!

EXAM TIP: When lines START with the same word(s) and both "Anaphora" and "Repetition" are in the options, choose ANAPHORA - it is the more exact name. Choose "Repetition" when anaphora is not offered, or when the WHOLE line is repeated.

DO NOT CONFUSE: Every anaphora is repetition, but not every repetition is anaphora. Same opening + a different rest of the line = ANAPHORA. The same WHOLE line (*"And miles to go before I sleep"*, twice) = REPETITION (the ruling in 3.7). Same words at the END of lines = EPISTROPHE (4.21); a line that returns at the end of every stanza = REFRAIN (4.22). For the full comparison of these pairs, see Section 6.

QUICK CHECK

QC1. Identify the figure of speech: *"We were taken from the ore-bed and the mine, / We were melted in the furnace and the pit"* (PYQ-style)

- a. Epistrophe
- b. Simile
- c. Anaphora
- d. Onomatopoeia

Answer: (c) - "We were" begins line after line: anaphora. Epistrophe would need the same words at the END of the lines.

QC2. Name the figure of speech: *"Not a flower could he see, / Not a leaf on a tree."* (PYQ-style)

- a. Anaphora
- b. Epistrophe
- c. Simile
- d. Onomatopoeia

Answer: (a) - both lines open with "Not a": anaphora (words are also left out - ellipsis, 4.4).

QC3. Identify the figure of speech: “It’s part of a man when his skies are blue, / It’s part of him when he has work to do.” (PYQ-style)

- a. Epistrophe
- b. Onomatopoeia
- c. Oxymoron
- d. Anaphora

Answer: (d) - "It's part of" opens both lines while the line endings differ (blue / do): anaphora, not epistrophe.

3.7 Repetition

IN SYLLABUS

Repetition and order

Meaning	A word, a phrase or a whole line is used again to stress an idea or a feeling.
Exam definition	Repetition is the deliberate use of the same word, phrase or line more than once - anywhere in a line, stanza or poem - for emphasis, rhythm and feeling. Anaphora (3.6), epistrophe (4.21) and refrain (4.22) are special kinds of repetition, named by WHERE the repeated words stand.
Key / clue words	No clue word - look for the SAME words coming back: no, no never, never round and round my wrath, my wrath we ants never the battle is today's woman comet in full flight behind him Remember
How to spot it	1. Find a word, phrase or line that comes back. 2. Check WHERE it comes back: start of lines = anaphora; end of lines = epistrophe; end of every stanza = refrain; anywhere else, or the whole line again = repetition. 3. If no special name fits, or none is offered, answer "Repetition" - all of them are repetition.
Memory trick	Amma calls, "Come, come, come home!" - she repeats because it is IMPORTANT. Poets repeat for the same reason: EMPHASIS . Then let the POSITION give the name: start = anaphora, end = epistrophe, end of every stanza = refrain, anywhere or whole line = repetition.

EASY EXAMPLES

Hurry, hurry, the school bus is at the gate! **hurry, hurry - a word**

It rained and rained and rained all night in Chennai. **rained - a word**

Practice, practice, practice - that is the secret of every good cricketer. **practice - a word**

Slowly and steadily, slowly and steadily, the tortoise won the race. **slowly and steadily - a phrase**

Happy birthday to you, happy birthday to you ... **a whole line sung again**

Water, water, every where (Coleridge, The Rime of the Ancient Mariner) **water, water - a word**

TYPES OF REPETITION

Type	What comes again	From the syllabus poems
1. Word repetition	One word, often side by side (the side-by-side kind is also called epizeuxis)	“Oh no, no,” and “They never, never wake again” (The Spider and the Fly); “River, river, little river!” (The River); “Then round and round, and out and in,” (A Tragic Story)
2. Phrase repetition	A group of words	“But we ants never borrow; we ants never lend.” (The Ant and the Cricket); “I told my wrath, my wrath did end.” (A Poison Tree); “For the battle is lost or the battle is won” (Team Work); “She’s today’s woman. Today’s woman, dear.” (I am Every Woman)
3. Whole-line repetition	A complete line said again (the same, or nearly the same)	“And miles to go before I sleep, / And miles to go before I sleep.” (Stopping by Woods); the first line of No Men are Foreign returns, reworded, as its last line (see below)
4. Refrain	A line or phrase that returns at REGULAR places, usually the end of every stanza (see 4.22)	“behind him” closes every stanza of A Tragic Story; the chorus line “Lessons in life aren’t always so simple” in the song-poem Lessons in Life

But I have promises to keep,
And miles to go before I sleep,
And miles to go before I sleep.

STOPPING BY WOODS ON A SNOWY EVENING • ROBERT FROST

Repetition (whole line) — the first time, the line means the real journey still ahead that night; said again, it suggests the long journey of life before the "sleep" of death (symbol, see 4.26). The repeat slows the poem down to a quiet close.

MUST REMEMBER: The ruling for "And miles to go before I sleep" (said twice) is REPETITION - not anaphora, not refrain. **Not anaphora:** anaphora repeats only the OPENING words while the rest of each line changes; here the WHOLE line is repeated word for word. **Not refrain:** a refrain comes back at REGULAR places, such as the end of every stanza; this line appears only in the last stanza, twice in a row. The repeated line also gives the last stanza its dddd rhyme (see 3.8).

Remember, no men are *strange*, no countries *foreign*
 Remember, no men are *foreign*, and no countries *strange*.

NO MEN ARE FOREIGN • JAMES FALCONER KIRKUP

Repetition (first and last lines) + **Chiasmus** — the first line comes back as the last line, with **strange** and **foreign** swapped (A-B, then B-A). The message opens and closes the poem like a frame. See 4.24.

EXAM TIP: In No Men are Foreign the word **Remember** also comes five times (lines 1, 9, 13, 16 and 20). If asked WHY the first line returns at the end, answer: for EMPHASIS - to fix the message of universal brotherhood in the reader's mind. If asked to name the figure in the swapped words, answer CHIASMUS (4.24).

"Oh *no, no*," said the little Fly, "for I've often heard it said,
 They *never, never* wake again, who sleep upon your bed!"

THE SPIDER AND THE FLY • MARY BOTHAM HOWITT

Repetition (word) — **no, no** makes the Fly's refusal firm; **never, never** makes the warning frightening. (Never waking from sleep = dying: euphemism, see 4.9.)

But *we ants never* borrow; *we ants never* lend.

THE ANT AND THE CRICKET • ADAPTED FROM AESOP'S FABLES

Repetition (phrase) — the ant repeats **we ants never** to make his refusal final. Coming straight after his polite greeting, it is also ironic (4.10).

A *comet in full flight*.
 Than a *comet in full flight*.

THE COMET • NORMAN LITTLEFORD

Repetition (phrase) — line 4 and line 24, the last line. The picture that ends the first stanza also ends the whole poem, so the comet stays in our mind.

Because it hung *behind him*.
 Not dangling there *behind him*.
 But still it hung *behind him*.
 The pigtail hung *behind him*.

A TRAGIC STORY • WILLIAM MAKEPEACE THACKERAY

Refrain / Epistrophe (also repetition) — these are the last lines of stanzas 1 to 4. **behind him** closes EVERY stanza: however the sage turns, the pigtail stays behind him - that is the joke. See 4.21 and 4.22.

EXAM TIP: If asked WHY a poet uses repetition, choose from: to EMPHASISE an idea, to show strong FEELING, to create RHYTHM and music, to make lines easy to REMEMBER, or to FRAME the poem (the same idea at the start and the end).

DO NOT CONFUSE: (1) Repetition vs anaphora vs refrain - all three repeat words; the POSITION decides the name: start of lines = anaphora (3.6), end of every stanza = refrain (4.22), anywhere else or a whole line = repetition. (2) Repetition vs alliteration - repetition repeats WHOLE words (no, no); alliteration repeats only the first SOUND of different words (forward face, 3.1). (3) Repetition vs rhyme - rhyme repeats only the END SOUND of different words (know - snow, 3.9); the same word twice (sleep - sleep) is repetition, not a true rhyme.

QUICK CHECK

QC4. Identify the figure of speech: “*And miles to go before I sleep, / And miles to go before I sleep.*” (PYQ-style)

- a. Anaphora
- b. Repetition
- c. Refrain
- d. Alliteration

Answer: (b) - the WHOLE line is repeated, so the key says repetition (not anaphora, not refrain - see the ruling above).

QC5. The repeated words "never, never" in “*They never, never wake again, who sleep upon your bed!*” are an example of: (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Onomatopoeia
- c. Metaphor
- d. Repetition

Answer: (d) - the same word is used twice, side by side, for emphasis: repetition.

QC6. The first line of No Men are Foreign, “*Remember, no men are strange, no countries foreign*”, returns as the last line, “*Remember, no men are foreign, and no countries strange.*” Which figures of speech are used? (PYQ-style)

- a. Repetition and chiasmus
- b. Simile and metaphor
- c. Onomatopoeia and alliteration
- d. Anaphora and epistrophe

Answer: (a) - the line is repeated to frame the poem, and "strange" and "foreign" change places (A-B / B-A): chiasmus.

3.8 Rhyme Scheme

IN SYLLABUS

Sound

Meaning	The PATTERN of rhyming sounds at the ends of lines, written with small letters: a, b, c ...
Exam definition	Rhyme scheme is the ordered pattern of end rhymes in a stanza or poem, marked with small letters: lines that end with the same sound get the same letter, and each new end-sound gets the next letter of the alphabet.
Key / clue words	In the question: rhyme scheme pattern of rhyme first stanza aabb abab abcb aaba . In the poem: ONLY the last word of each line.
How to spot it	1. Underline the last word of every line. 2. Say the end sounds aloud - ears, not eyes. 3. Letter them: first sound = a; a sound heard before = its old letter; a new sound = the next letter.
Memory trick	New end-sound = new letter. Same sound, same letter. Like seats on a bus: each NEW passenger (sound) gets the next seat letter; a passenger who comes back sits in his OLD seat.

EASY EXAMPLES

Twinkle, twinkle, little star, / How I wonder what you are! **star - are = aa (a couplet)**

I eat my idli hot, / I finish all I've got; / Then off to school I run, / To learn and play in the sun. **hot - got, run - sun = aabb**

The monsoon clouds are grey, / The farmers smile with cheer, / The rain has come to stay, / Good harvest for the year. **grey - stay, cheer - year = abab**

My mother wakes at five, / She lights the kitchen fire, / She cooks and does not tire, / The whole house comes alive. **five - alive outside, fire - tire inside = abba**

On Marina Beach at evening / The waves come rolling in; / The kites fly high above us, / The sea wind on my skin. **only in - skin**
rhyme = abcb

The bus is late. / I stand at the stop / and count the autos / turning at the signal. **no end rhyme = free verse: no rhyme scheme**

THE 5-STEP METHOD

1. **Find the line-end words.** Write the last word of every line in a column. Ignore commas, full stops and quotation marks.
2. **Say the end sounds aloud.** Take the last stressed vowel and everything after it: know → -oh, here → -eer, dancing → -ancing. Trust your EAR, not the spelling: though also ends in -oh.
3. **First sound = a.** The first line always gets a.
4. **New sound = next letter; same sound = same letter.** Compare each line with the sounds already used. A sound heard before takes its OLD letter; a new sound takes the NEXT unused letter (b, c, d ...).
5. **Write stanza by stanza.** Leave a space between stanzas (aaba bbcb ...). A sound that comes back in a later stanza keeps its old letter.

NOTATION RULES

Rule	Example
Use small letters, written together, with a space between stanzas.	aabb ccdd - not AABB, not 1122
An unrhymed line still gets its own letter.	abcb: line 1 (a) and line 3 (c) rhyme with nothing
Slant (near) rhymes are accepted as rhymes.	arms - harm (Special Hero); smooth - youth (The River)
The same word at two line ends takes the same letter.	sleep - sleep (Stopping by Woods); it - it (Courage)
A refrain line gets its own letter and keeps it every time it returns.	" <i>behind him</i> " = b in every stanza of A Tragic Story: aaab ccdb ddb ...
Free verse has NO rhyme scheme - do not force letters on it.	No Men are Foreign; On Killing a Tree; Making Life Worth While
A few scattered rhymes with no fixed pattern = no regular scheme.	I am Every Woman; The House on Elm Street
Same pattern in every stanza? Write it once. A sound carried into the next stanza? Letter the whole poem without restarting.	A Poison Tree = aabb; Stopping by Woods = aaba bbcb ccdb dddd

PATTERN NAMES

Pattern name	Letters	How it works	Syllabus poems
Rhyming couplets	aabb	Lines rhyme in pairs: 1 with 2, 3 with 4.	The Ant and the Cricket, A Poison Tree, The Spider and the Fly, The Stick-together Families, A Thing of Beauty, My Computer Needs a Break, Sea Fever, Courage, From a Railway Carriage
Alternate rhyme (cross rhyme)	abab	Line 1 rhymes with line 3; line 2 rhymes with line 4.	The Secret of the Machines, Your Space, Team Work
Enclosed rhyme (envelope rhyme)	abba	Lines 1 and 4 "enclose" the rhyming pair, lines 2 and 3.	Life (its first eight lines: abba abba)
Chain rhyme (interlocking rhyme)	aaba bbcb	The odd sound of one stanza becomes the main rhyme of the next.	Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening
Ballad rhyme	abcb	Only lines 2 and 4 rhyme; lines 1 and 3 stay free.	The Comet, Special Hero, Indian Seasons, Lessons in Life (verses)
Sonnet	abbaabba cddcee	14 lines: an 8-line octave + a 6-line sestet. (Other sonnets use other patterns, e.g. Shakespeare's abab cdcd efef gg.)	Life
Heroic couplets	aabb	Rhyming couplets in long lines of about ten syllables (iambic pentameter).	A Thing of Beauty
Triplet + refrain	aaab ccdb	Three lines share one rhyme; a fixed refrain line closes each stanza.	A Tragic Story

MUST REMEMBER: Stanza names by number of lines: 2 = couplet, 3 = tercet (triplet), 4 = quatrain, 5 = quintain (quintet), 6 = sestet, 8 = octave; a 14-line poem with a set rhyme pattern = sonnet.

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

Four worked examples. Cover the tables, letter the lines yourself, then check.

WORKED EXAMPLE 1: STOPPING BY WOODS ON A SNOWY EVENING (STANZA 1)

Whose woods these are I think I **know**.
His house is in the village **though**;
He will not see me stopping **here**
To watch his woods fill up with **snow**.

STOPPING BY WOODS ON A SNOWY EVENING • ROBERT FROST

Rhyme scheme aaba — know, though and snow share one sound; here is the odd one out.

Line-end word	End sound	Letter
know (line 1)	-oh (say "noh") - the first sound	a
though (line 2)	-oh (say "thoh") - the spelling -ough hides the same sound	a
here (line 3)	-eer (say "heer") - a NEW sound	b
snow (line 4)	-oh (say "snoh") - the a sound comes back	a

Result: stanza 1 = **aaba**. Now carry on through the poem, keeping the letters running:

Stanza	Line-end words	Letters	What happens
1	know, though, here, snow	aaba	here is the odd sound: b
2	queer, near, lake, year	bbcb	b (the sound of here) is now the main rhyme; lake is new: c
3	shake, mistake, sweep, flake	ccdc	c (the sound of lake) is now the main rhyme; sweep is new: d
4	deep, keep, sleep, sleep	dddd	d (the sound of sweep) fills the whole stanza: the chain closes

Full rhyme scheme: aaba bbcb ccdc dddd

MUST REMEMBER: WHY "CHAIN RHYME"? In each stanza the THIRD line does not rhyme with the others, and that odd sound becomes the MAIN rhyme of the next stanza: here → queer, near, year; lake → shake, mistake, flake; sweep → deep, keep, sleep. Each stanza is hooked to the next like the links of a chain (also called interlocking rhyme). The last stanza has no new sound to pass on, so the chain ends with dddd - and the repeated last line (3.7) brings the poem to a slow, sleepy close. (A four-line aaba stanza is also known as the Rubaiyat stanza.)

EXAM TIP: "Rhyme scheme of the first stanza" = aaba. "Rhyme scheme of the poem" = aaba bbcb ccdc dddd. Read which one is asked.

WORKED EXAMPLE 2: THE RIVER (STANZA 1)

Bright you sparkle on your **way**;
O'er the yellow pebbles **dancing**,
Through the flowers and foliage **glancing**,
Like a child at **play**.

THE RIVER • CAROLINE ANN BOWLES

Lines 2-5 of stanza 1 — way and play (b) close in the couplet dancing - glancing (c). Line 1 ends with the word river (a).

Line	Line-end word	End sound	Letter
1	river	-iver	a
2	way	-ay	b
3	dancing	-ancing	c
4	glancing	-ancing	c
5	play	-ay	b

Result: abccb - and every stanza follows the same shape, so the poem's scheme is "abccb (every stanza)".

- Line 1 (river) rhymes with nothing in the stanza, but it still gets a letter: a.
- dancing - glancing is a two-syllable (double, or feminine) rhyme: DAN-cing / GLAN-cing.
- Stanza 2 has the same shape: river (a), smooth (b), leaping (c), sweeping (c), youth (b). smooth - youth is a slant rhyme - accepted.

- This five-line pattern has no special name; simply write abccb.

WORKED EXAMPLE 3: LIFE (A 14-LINE SONNET)

*Let me but live my life from year to **year**,*
*With forward face and unreluctant **soul**;*
*Not hurrying to, nor turning from the **goal**;*
*Not mourning for the things that **disappear***

LIFE • HENRY VAN DYKE

abba — year and disappear (a) enclose soul and goal (b): enclosed rhyme.

Part	Lines	Line-end words	Letters
Octave	1-4	year, soul, goal, disappear	abba
Octave	5-8	fear, whole, toll, cheer	abba
Sestet	9-12	down, joy, boy, crown	cddc
Sestet	13-14	quest, best	ee

Full rhyme scheme: abbaabba cddcee

- The octave (lines 1-8) uses only TWO sounds: -eer (year, disappear, fear, cheer) and -ole (soul, goal, whole, toll), in the enclosed pattern abba abba - the octave of the Italian (Petrarchan) sonnet.
- The sestet (lines 9-14) brings three NEW sounds: down - crown enclose joy - boy (cddc), and the poem ends with a rhyming couplet, quest - best (ee).
- Count the lines first: 14 lines + a tight rhyme pattern = a SONNET.

WORKED EXAMPLE 4: A TRAGIC STORY (A REFRAIN LINE)

*There lived a sage in days of **yore**,*
*And he a handsome pigtail **wore**;*
*But wondered much and sorrowed **more**,*
*Because it hung **behind him**.*

A TRAGIC STORY • WILLIAM MAKEPEACE THACKERAY

aaab — yore, wore and more share one sound (a); the refrain line ending in behind him takes b.

Stanza	Line-end words	Letters
1	yore, wore, more, behind him	aaab
2	case, place, face, behind him	cccb
3	found, round, behind him	ddb
4	in, spin, pin, behind him	eeeb
5	about, out, stout, behind him	fffb
6	slack, tack, back, behind him	gggb

Full rhyme scheme: aaab cccb ddb eeeb fffb gggb

- The refrain line takes b in stanza 1 and KEEPS b in every stanza, because the same ending comes back each time.
- Each stanza brings a NEW triple rhyme, so the letters run on: c, d, e, f, g (a is never used again).
- Stanza 3 has only three lines (found, round + the refrain), so it is ddb.
- The repeated b line is a refrain (4.22) and, because it stands at the line end, also epistrophe (4.21).

RHYME SCHEMES OF ALL 25 POEMS

No.	Poem	Rhyme scheme	Pattern name
1	Life	abbaabba cddcee (14-line sonnet)	Sonnet: enclosed octave + sestet ending in a couplet
2	I am Every Woman	no regular scheme (rhymes: stake - fake, dear - near - fear, beliefs - belief)	Irregular: scattered rhymes
3	The Secret of the Machines	abab	Alternate rhyme

No.	Poem	Rhyme scheme	Pattern name
4	The Ant and the Cricket	aabb (rhyming couplets, with a few triplets such as see - tree - me, borrow - tomorrow - sorrow)	Rhyming couplets (with triplets)
5	No Men are Foreign	free verse, no rhyme scheme	Free verse
6	The House on Elm Street	no regular scheme (rhymes: alone - unknown - bone, place - space, day - May, mind - kind, fall - tall, made - fade)	Irregular: scattered rhymes
7	Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening	aaba bcb b cdc dddd	Chain rhyme (interlocking)
8	A Poison Tree	aabb	Rhyming couplets
9	On Killing a Tree	free verse, no rhyme scheme	Free verse
10	The Spider and the Fly	aabb	Rhyming couplets
11	The River	abccb (every stanza)	Five-line stanza: couplet cc closed in by b
12	The Comet	abcb	Ballad rhyme
13	The Stick-together Families	aabb	Rhyming couplets
14	Special Hero	abcb	Ballad rhyme
15	Making Life Worth While	free verse, no rhyme scheme	Free verse
16	A Thing of Beauty	aabb (heroic couplets)	Heroic couplets
17	Lessons in Life	abcb in the verses (bloom - room, sad - bad), chorus rhymes free - me	Ballad rhyme (song: verses + chorus)
18	My Computer Needs a Break	aabb	Rhyming couplets
19	Your Space	abab	Alternate rhyme
20	Sea Fever	aabb	Rhyming couplets
21	Courage	aabb	Rhyming couplets
22	Team Work	abab	Alternate rhyme
23	From a Railway Carriage	aabb	Rhyming couplets
24	Indian Seasons	abcb	Ballad rhyme
25	A Tragic Story	aaab cccb ddb eeb fffb ggg (refrain "behind him" closes every stanza)	Triplet + refrain

MEMORY TRICK: Learn the 25 in groups. **abab** = "MY TEAM": Machines, Your Space, Team Work. **abcb** = "A Special Indian Comet gives Lessons": Special Hero, Indian Seasons, The Comet, Lessons in Life. **Free verse** = "No Killing - Make Life Worth While": No Men are Foreign, On Killing a Tree, Making Life Worth While. **No regular scheme** = the two E poems: Every Woman, Elm Street. **The special four:** Life (sonnet), Stopping by Woods (chain), The River (abccb), A Tragic Story (aaab + refrain). **The other nine are all aabb couplets.**

DO NOT CONFUSE: (1) Rhyme scheme vs rhyming words: the scheme is the PATTERN of letters (aabb); rhyming words are the WORDS that rhyme (friend - end, 3.9). Answer in the form the question asks. (2) abcb vs abab: in abcb only lines 2 and 4 rhyme; in abab lines 1 and 3 rhyme too - always test lines 1 and 3 before you choose. (3) For free verse the answer is "no rhyme scheme" - do not invent letters.

QUICK CHECK

QC7. The rhyme scheme of the first stanza of "Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening" is: (PYQ-style)

- a. abab
- b. aabb
- c. aaba
- d. abcb

Answer: (c) - know, though and snow share one sound (a); here is new (b): aaba.

QC8. Find the rhyme scheme: “I was angry with my friend; / I told my wrath, my wrath did end. / I was angry with my foe: / I told it not, my wrath did grow.” (PYQ-style)

- a. abab
- b. aabb
- c. abba
- d. abcb

Answer: (b) - friend - end (a a), foe - grow (b b): rhyming couplets, aabb.

QC9. The rhyme scheme of the 14-line poem "Life" by Henry Van Dyke is: (PYQ-style)

- a. abbaabba cddcee
- b. abab cdcd efef gg
- c. aabb ccdd eeff gg
- d. aaba bbcb ccde dddd

Answer: (a) - an enclosed octave (abbaabba) and a sestet that ends in the couplet quest - best (cddcee).

3.9 Rhyming Words

IN SYLLABUS

Sound

Meaning	Words whose END sounds are the same: night - bright, friend - end.
Exam definition	Rhyming words are words that share the same final sound - the last stressed vowel and every sound after it - while their opening sounds differ. In poems they usually stand at the ends of lines. Near (slant) rhymes such as arms - harm and smooth - youth are accepted in textbook answers.
Key / clue words	In the question: rhyming words rhymes with pick out the rhyming pair words that rhyme . In the poem: the line-end words of a couplet (aabb) or of lines 2 and 4 (abcb).
How to spot it	1. Take the last word of each line. 2. Cut off the opening sound and compare the TAILS: n-ight / br-ight. 3. Tails that sound the same = rhyme. Judge by SOUND, not spelling (foe - grow rhyme; home - come do not).
Memory trick	Same TAIL, different HEAD. n-IGHT, br-IGHT, fl-IGHT: the heads change, the tail stays. A tail that only LOOKS the same (h-OME, c-OME) does not count.

EASY EXAMPLES

cat - hat - mat - rat **tail -at**

rain - train - plain - chain **tail -ain**

light - bright - kite - height **one sound, three spellings: -ight, -ite, -eight**

blue - shoe - through - too **one -oo sound, four spellings**

dancing - glancing; singing - ringing **two-syllable (double) rhymes**

home - come; love - move **NOT true rhymes - they only LOOK alike (eye rhymes)**

HOW TO PICK RHYMING WORDS

1. **List the line-end words**, stanza by stanza.
2. **Cut off the head** - the opening consonant sound(s): fr-iend / end; f-oe / gr-ow.
3. **Compare the tails** - the final vowel sound plus the consonant(s) after it must SOUND the same: -end / -end; -oh / -oh.
4. **Ignore spelling**: foe - grow, though - snow, stair - there and far - are all rhyme.
5. **Prefer line-end pairs**. In an MCQ the correct pair is usually the two ends of one couplet (aabb) or lines 2 and 4 (abcb). A pair taken from INSIDE a line is usually the trap.

*I was angry with my **foe**;
I told it not, my wrath did **grow**.*

A POISON TREE • WILLIAM BLAKE

foe - grow — different spellings (-oe, -ow), the SAME -oh sound: a true rhyme that closes a couplet (aabb).

*Faster than fairies, faster than **witches**,
Bridges and houses, hedges and **ditches**;*

FROM A RAILWAY CARRIAGE • ROBERT LOUIS STEVENSON

witches - ditches — a two-syllable rhyme (-itches). The whole poem runs in such quick couplets (aabb), like the rattle of the train.

*The woods are lovely, dark and **deep**,
But I have promises to **keep**,*

STOPPING BY WOODS ON A SNOWY EVENING • ROBERT FROST

deep - keep (and sleep) — the d rhyme that fills the last stanza (dddd, see 3.8).

*And the wheel's kick and the wind's song and the white sail's **shaking**,
And a grey mist on the sea's face, and a grey dawn **breaking**.*

SEA FEVER • JOHN MASEFIELD

shaking - breaking — a two-syllable rhyme (-aking) at the ends of a couplet. Words such as grey ... face inside the line share only a vowel sound - that is assonance (4.5), not rhyme.

*It's all very well to have courage and **skill**
And it's fine to be counted a **star**,
But the single deed with its touch of **thrill**
Doesn't tell the man you **are**;*

TEAM WORK • EDGAR ALBERT GUEST

skill - thrill (lines 1 and 3) and **star - are** (lines 2 and 4) — alternate rhyme, abab. star and are look different but sound alike.

*We have imagined for the mighty **dead**;
All lovely tales that we have heard or **read**:*

A THING OF BEAUTY • JOHN KEATS

dead - read — here read is the PAST form, said "red", so this is a true rhyme. Say the word the way the poem means it.

*you would hold me in your **arms**,
keeping me safe from **harm**.*

SPECIAL HERO • CHRISTINA M. KERSCHEN

arms - harm (lines 2 and 4) — a slant (near) rhyme: the extra s does not stop it counting. The poem's scheme is abcb, so lines 2 and 4 are where the rhymes are.

TRAPS TO AVOID

Trap	Syllabus example	What to do
1. Eye rhyme - looks alike, sounds different	<i>"Began to complain when he found that, at home, / His cupboard was empty, and winter was come."</i> (home - come)	home = "hohm", come = "kum": not a true rhyme. The poet uses it as a couplet, so the scheme stays aabb; but if asked for a TRUE rhyming pair, pick one that really sounds alike (sing - spring).
2. The same word repeated	<i>"The brave man never is freed of it. / He has it when there is no need of it."</i> (it - it)	A repeated word is only an identical rhyme - the real echo here is freed - need. The same goes for sleep - sleep (Stopping by Woods), him - him (A Tragic Story's refrain) and beliefs - belief (I am Every Woman): one letter in the scheme, but not the answer when a true pair is offered.

Trap	Syllabus example	What to do
3. Internal chime - an echo INSIDE a line (sometimes called internal rhyme)	<i>“Of scorching and choking”</i>	The two words stand in ONE line, so they are not a pair of line-end words, and only their -ing endings chime (scorch / choke differ). Exam keys treat the repeated ch sound as consonance (4.6). On Killing a Tree is free verse with NO end rhymes, so these are not its rhyming words. A cleaner internal rhyme is thaw - saw in <i>“She knows how to thaw you, saw you - so beware!”</i> - but it is still not a line-end pair.
4. Slant rhyme - ACCEPTED	arms - harm (Special Hero); smooth - youth (The River)	Near rhymes count in textbook answers. Do not reject a pair just because one sound differs slightly.

RHYMING WORDS OF ALL 25 POEMS

No.	Poem	Rhyming words (line-end pairs)
1	Life	year - disappear - fear - cheer; soul - goal - whole - toll; joy - boy; quest - best
2	I am Every Woman	stake - fake; dear - near - fear (scattered rhymes only)
3	The Secret of the Machines	mine - design; pit - fit; ask - task; lie - die
4	The Ant and the Cricket	sing - spring; found - ground; borrow - tomorrow - sorrow; wicket - cricket (eye rhyme: home - come)
5	No Men are Foreign	free verse - no end rhymes
6	The House on Elm Street	alone - unknown - bone; place - space; day - May; made - fade (scattered rhymes only)
7	Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening	know - though - snow; queer - near - year; shake - mistake - flake; deep - keep - sleep
8	A Poison Tree	friend - end; foe - grow; fears - tears; night - bright
9	On Killing a Tree	free verse - no end rhymes
10	The Spider and the Fly	Fly - spy; stair - there; vain - again; said - bed
11	The River	way - play; dancing - glancing; time - prime; sounded - rounded
12	The Comet	night - flight; long - strong; force - course; shake - quake
13	The Stick-together Families	far - are; make - break; sun - done; roam - home
14	Special Hero	arms - harm (slant); see - me; love - above; know - so
15	Making Life Worth While	free verse - no end rhymes
16	A Thing of Beauty	ever - never; keep - sleep; earth - dearth; dead - read
17	Lessons in Life	bloom - room; sad - bad; free - me (chorus)
18	My Computer Needs a Break	smart - heart; click - quick; worm - squirm; say - holiday
19	Your Space	far - mar; fear - here; low - flow; bind - kind
20	Sea Fever	sky - by; shaking - breaking; tide - denied; life - knife
21	Courage	dash - flash; hope - rope; light - sight; deed - creed
22	Team Work	skill - thrill; star - are; great - mate; fame - game
23	From a Railway Carriage	witches - ditches; battle - cattle; plain - rain; eye - by
24	Indian Seasons	heat - feet; roads - toads; sweet - seat; brown - down
25	A Tragic Story	yore - wore - more; case - place - face; about - out - stout; slack - tack - back

DO NOT CONFUSE: Rhyme = the END of words sounds alike (night - bright). Alliteration = the BEGINNING sound repeats (forward face, 3.1). Assonance = only a VOWEL sound repeats in nearby words (grey ... face, 4.5). Consonance = a CONSONANT sound repeats (scorching ... choking, 4.6). And rhyming words are WORDS (friend - end), while a rhyme scheme is LETTERS (aabb, 3.8).

QUICK CHECK

QC10. Pick out the rhyming words: *“And I water'd it in fears, / Night and morning with my tears.”* (PYQ-style)

- a. water'd - morning
- b. night - morning
- c. in - with
- d. fears - tears

Answer: (d) - the two line-end words share the tail -ears: fears - tears.

QC11. In “Began to complain when he found that, at home, / His cupboard was empty, and winter was come.” the pair home - come is: (PYQ-style)

- a. a perfect rhyme
- b. an eye rhyme
- c. alliteration
- d. an internal rhyme

Answer: (b) - the words LOOK alike (-ome) but sound different (hohm / kum): an eye rhyme.

QC12. Choose the rhyming pair: “I must go down to the seas again, to the lonely sea and the sky, / And all I ask is a tall ship and a star to steer her by;” (PYQ-style)

- a. seas - sea
- b. ship - star
- c. sky - by
- d. ask - tall

Answer: (c) - sky and by end the two lines and share the "-eye" sound. The pair seas - sea is the same word repeated; the other pairs do not share an end sound.

4 More Figures You Must Know

The 2022 revised TNPSC General English syllabus names nine figures of speech (Section 3) and ends the list with "etc." So **other figures of speech can also be asked**. This section gives you 27 more figures in short cards: meaning, exam definition, clue words, how to spot it, a memory trick, easy examples, examples from the 25 syllabus poems, one trap and a quick check. Apostrophe, Allusion, Oxymoron and Ellipsis (4.1–4.4) were named in the earlier syllabus and are still worth knowing — learn them first. Then revise the cards marked **HIGH-FREQUENCY**, and finally the rest.

EXAM TIP: One line can carry two or three figures at once. Read what the question points to — a word, a sound, a comparison or a hidden meaning — and choose the figure for that part. For every figure in each poem, see Section 5; for look-alike pairs, see Section 6.

4.1 Apostrophe

ALSO ASKED

Comparison

HIGH-FREQUENCY

Meaning	Speaking directly to someone or something that cannot answer — a dead or absent person, a thing or an idea. Say: uh-POS-truh-fee. (named in the earlier syllabus)
Exam definition	Apostrophe is directly addressing someone absent or dead, or a thing or idea, as if it could hear. Addressing a listener who is present (a doctor in the room) is NOT apostrophe.
Key / clue words	O ... Oh ... a name + comma at the start you / thou / thy (said to a thing) !
How to spot it	1. Is the speaker talking TO someone or something ("you", "O ...")? 2. Can that listener really hear and reply? 3. A thing, an idea, the dead or someone far away → apostrophe. It usually comes with personification.
Memory trick	PERSONification turns a thing into a PERSON. APOSTROPHE POSTs a message to someone who cannot reply.

EASY EXAMPLES

"Twinkle, twinkle, little star, / How I wonder what you are!" **speaks to a star**

"Milton! thou shouldst be living at this hour." (Wordsworth) **speaks to Milton, a poet long dead**

"Rain, rain, go away; come again another day." **speaks to the rain**

River, river, little river!
Bright you sparkle on your way;
THE RIVER • CAROLINE ANN BOWLES

Apostrophe + Personification — the poet calls out to the river and says "you" to it as if it could hear. Making it sparkle and travel also gives it life (see 3.4).

And, O weary, wandering brother, if contentment you would win,
Come you back unto the fireside and be comrade with your kin.
THE STICK-TOGETHER FAMILIES • EDGAR ALBERT GUEST

Apostrophe — "O" + a direct call to an absent brother who has wandered far from home.

DO NOT CONFUSE: Apostrophe = talking TO the thing (the poet says "you" to the river). Personification = only giving the thing human actions or feelings (3.4). The two often come together. In *My Computer Needs a Break* the child asks “*Doctor, do you think my tired computer wants a holiday?*” — the doctor is present in the room, so this is NOT apostrophe. And this figure has nothing to do with the punctuation mark (') of the same name.

QUICK CHECK

QC1. Identify the figure of speech: “*River, river, little river!*” (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Apostrophe
- c. Metaphor
- d. Onomatopoeia

Answer: (b) - the poet speaks directly to the river as if it could hear.

4.2 Allusion

ALSO ASKED

Association and reference

HIGH-FREQUENCY

Meaning	A quick hint to a famous person, place, event or story that the writer expects you to know. (named in the earlier syllabus)
Exam definition	Allusion is a brief reference to a well-known person, place, event, story or text (the Bible, the epics, history, literature), given without explanation.
Key / clue words	Famous names from epics, myths, history and books: Karna Kumbhakarna Pandora's box Herculean task Achilles' heel Eden / the apple
How to spot it	1. Find a famous name or story that the writer does not explain. 2. Ask: "Do I need outside knowledge (an epic, a myth, history, a famous book) to get the full meaning?" Yes → allusion.
Memory trick	ALLusion points to a story ALL of us know — one word opens a whole story.

EASY EXAMPLES

He is a Karna in generosity. Karna, the Mahabharata

On holidays my cousin becomes a Kumbhakarna — he sleeps till noon. Kumbhakarna, the Ramayana

Raising old quarrels at a wedding opens a Pandora's box. Greek myth

And it grew both day and night,
Till it bore an apple bright.
A POISON TREE • WILLIAM BLAKE

Allusion — the shining apple recalls the forbidden fruit in the Garden of Eden (the Bible): something tempting that brings death.

Speak gently! - *He who gave his life*
To bend man's stubborn will,
When elements were in fierce strife,
Said to them, *'Peace, be still.'*

YOUR SPACE • DAVID BATES

Allusion — to the Bible story in which Jesus calms a stormy sea with the words "Peace, be still".

DO NOT CONFUSE: ALLusion (a reference to a known story) ≠ ILLusion (a false picture or belief). "As generous as Karna" is a simile (as ... as) that also carries an allusion (Karna). If the question asks about the famous name, answer allusion; if it asks about the comparing words, answer simile.

QUICK CHECK

QC2. Identify the figure of speech: "Till it bore an apple bright." (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Oxymoron
- c. Allusion
- d. Hyperbole

Answer: (c) - the apple refers to the forbidden fruit of the Garden of Eden.

4.3 Oxymoron

ALSO ASKED

Contrast

HIGH-FREQUENCY

Meaning	Two words with opposite meanings placed together, usually an adjective + a noun. (named in the earlier syllabus)
Exam definition	Oxymoron is a figure in which two contradictory words are placed side by side ("empty joy", "deafening silence").
Key / clue words	deafening silence open secret bitter-sweet living death cruel kindness empty joy
How to spot it	1. Look for a two-word pair. 2. Check if the two words fight each other (silence cannot be deafening). 3. Two clashing words side by side → oxymoron. A whole statement that sounds impossible → paradox (4.11).
Memory trick	OXY (sharp) + MORON (dull): the word oxymoron is itself an oxymoron — it is Greek for "sharp-dull".

EASY EXAMPLES

When the results were read out, there was a deafening silence in the hall. **deafening + silence**

It is an open secret that Ravi loves ghee roast. **open + secret**

Leaving school gave us bitter-sweet memories. **bitter + sweet**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

But it's bitterness they harvest, and it's empty joy they find,

THE STICK-TOGETHER FAMILIES • EDGAR ALBERT GUEST

Oxymoron — joy should fill the heart, but this joy is empty: two opposite ideas sit side by side. (Reaping a harvest of bitterness, in the same line, is a metaphor.)

DO NOT CONFUSE: Oxymoron = two opposite WORDS joined ("empty joy"). Paradox = a whole STATEMENT that sounds impossible but is true ("The child is father of the man", 4.11). Antithesis = two opposite IDEAS in balanced parts ("To err is human, to forgive divine", 4.12).

QUICK CHECK

QC3. Identify the figure of speech in the phrase "empty joy": "*and it's empty joy they find,*" (PYQ-style)

- a. Oxymoron
- b. Paradox
- c. Pun
- d. Litotes

Answer: (a) - two opposite words, "empty" and "joy", are placed side by side.

4.4 Ellipsis

ALSO ASKED

Repetition and order

Meaning	Leaving out words that the reader can easily fill in; also the three dots (...) that show something is left out. (named in the earlier syllabus)
Exam definition	Ellipsis is the leaving out of words that the reader can supply from the context; the name is also used for the mark "..." showing that words have been left out.
Key / clue words	... (three dots) a missing verb "Not a ..." phrases one-word answers
How to spot it	1. The line feels incomplete, but the meaning is still clear. 2. Supply the missing words ("there was", "could he see") — if they fit easily, it is ellipsis. 3. Three dots in the text = the punctuation mark called ellipsis.
Memory trick	ELLIPSIS = words LEFT OUT, meaning LEFT IN. The three dots say "you know the rest".

EASY EXAMPLES

Some students came by bus, others by train. "came" left out

"Who broke the glass?" "Ravi." = Ravi broke the glass

I wanted to tell you ... never mind. the mark ...

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

Not a crumb to be found
On the snow-covered ground;
Not a flower could he see,
Not a leaf on a tree.

THE ANT AND THE CRICKET • ADAPTED FROM AESOP'S FABLES

Ellipsis — "There was" is left out before the first line, and "could he see" is left out in the last line. (The repeated "Not a" at the start is anaphora, 3.6.)

One bit of courage
For the darkening sky;

MAKING LIFE WORTH WHILE • GEORGE ELIOT

Ellipsis — the verb "gets" from an earlier line is understood: every soul gets one bit of courage.

Love her, respect her, keep her near...

I AM EVERY WOMAN • RAKHI NARIANI SHIRKE

Ellipsis (the mark) — the poem's own three dots leave the thought open for the reader to complete.

DO NOT CONFUSE: Ellipsis = any words left out that the reader supplies. Asyndeton = ONLY the joining words (and, or) left out of a list: "I came, I saw, I conquered" (4.23). The mark ellipsis (...) shows missing words; a dash (-) shows a break or an added thought.

QUICK CHECK

QC4. In “*Not a leaf on a tree.*” the words “could he see” are understood but not written. Identify the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

- a. Inversion
- b. Polysyndeton
- c. Hyperbole
- d. Ellipsis

Answer: (d) - words the reader can supply are left out.

4.5 Assonance

ALSO ASKED

Sound

Meaning	The same vowel sound repeated in words that are close together.
Exam definition	Assonance is the repetition of vowel sounds in nearby words (the consonants around the vowels may be different).
Key / clue words	Repeated vowel sounds: long a: grey, face, breaking long e: sweep, easy long i: fly, high, sky long o: go, slow, road
How to spot it	1. Read the line aloud. 2. Ignore the first letters; listen to the vowel sound in the middle of the words. 3. The same vowel SOUND again and again (even with different spellings: grey / face / break) → assonance.
Memory trick	ASSONANCE = vowels (A-E-I-O-U); CONSONANCE = consonants.

EASY EXAMPLES

The rain in Spain stays mainly in the plain. **long a**

I like to fly my kite high in the sky. **long i**

Go slow on the old road. **long o**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

And a **grey** mist on the sea's **face**, and a **grey** dawn **breaking**.

SEA FEVER • JOHN MASEFIELD

Assonance — the long “a” sound repeats in grey, face, grey and breaking.

Full of **sweet dreams**, and health, and quiet **breathing**.

A THING OF BEAUTY • JOHN KEATS

Assonance — the long “e” sound repeats in sweet, dreams and breathing; it makes the line soft and restful.

DO NOT CONFUSE: Assonance = a repeated VOWEL sound anywhere in nearby words (grey - face). Alliteration = a repeated FIRST consonant sound (3.1). Rhyme = matching END sounds, usually at line ends (3.9). In “rain - Spain - plain” the long “a” is assonance, and the whole “-ain” ending is rhyme.

QUICK CHECK

QC5. The repeated long “e” sound (sweep - easy) in “*The only other sound's the sweep / Of easy wind and downy flake.*” is an example of (PYQ-style)

- a. Alliteration
- b. Consonance
- c. Assonance
- d. Onomatopoeia

Answer: (c) - a vowel sound, long “e”, is repeated in nearby words.

4.6 Consonance

ALSO ASKED

Sound

Meaning	The same consonant sound repeated in nearby words, mostly in the middle or at the end of the words.
Exam definition	Consonance is the repetition of consonant sounds, usually inside or at the end of nearby words, with different vowels.
Key / clue words	Repeated middle / end consonants: k: struck, streak, luck ll: all, well dg / tch: hedges, ditches ch: scorching, choking
How to spot it	1. Ignore the first letters. 2. Listen to the consonant sounds inside and at the end of the words. 3. The same consonant sound repeated close together → consonance.
Memory trick	ASSONANCE = vowels (A-E-I-O-U); CONSONANCE = consonants. Consonance hides in the middle and at the END of words.

EASY EXAMPLES

He struck a streak of bad luck. **k sound: struck, streak, luck**

All's well that ends well. **l sound: all's, well, well**

Odds and ends lay on the table. **d sound: odds, and, ends**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

*Of scor**ch**ing and **ch**oking*

ON KILLING A TREE • GIEVE PATEL

Consonance — the "ch" sound repeats in scorching and choking; the two -ing endings add to the harsh sound of the tree's slow death.

*Brid**g**es and houses, hed**g**es and d**it**ches;*

FROM A RAILWAY CARRIAGE • ROBERT LOUIS STEVENSON

Consonance — the "j" sound (dg) repeats inside bridges and hedges, ditches answers it with the close "ch" sound (tch), and all four nouns end in the same -es sound, like the steady clatter of the train.

DO NOT CONFUSE: Consonance = a consonant sound repeated INSIDE or at the END of words (struck - luck). Alliteration = a consonant sound repeated at the START of words (3.1). Some books call alliteration a special kind of consonance; if both are options and the sound is at the start of the words, choose alliteration.

QUICK CHECK

QC6. The repeated "dg" and "tch" sounds in “Bridges and houses, hedges and ditches;” are an example of (PYQ-style)

- a. Assonance
- b. Consonance
- c. Simile
- d. Antithesis

Answer: (b) - consonant sounds are repeated inside nearby words.

4.7 Hyperbole

ALSO ASKED

Exaggeration and understatement

HIGH-FREQUENCY

Meaning	Making something sound much bigger, more or worse than it is, on purpose. Say: hy-PUR-buh-lee (not "hyper-bowl").
Exam definition	Hyperbole is deliberate, obvious exaggeration used for emphasis or humour; it is not meant to be taken literally.
Key / clue words	a thousand times a ton of mountains of for ages a million in the wink of an eye dying of
How to spot it	1. Is the statement impossible, or far beyond the truth? 2. Is the speaker exaggerating on purpose to stress a feeling? Yes + yes → hyperbole.
Memory trick	HYPERbole goes over the top; LITOTES says "not bad" for "good". (A hyper child has too much energy; hyperbole has too much size.)

EASY EXAMPLES

I have told you a thousand times to switch off the fan. **a thousand times**

This school bag weighs a ton! **a ton**

We waited for ages at the bus stop in the Chennai sun. **for ages**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

*It seems to know **mountains of information** by heart.*

MY COMPUTER NEEDS A BREAK • SHANTHINI GOVINDAN

Hyperbole (also metaphor) — information cannot form mountains; the size is exaggerated to show how much the computer knows.

*And ever again, **in the wink of an eye**,*

Painted stations whistle by.

FROM A RAILWAY CARRIAGE • ROBERT LOUIS STEVENSON

Hyperbole — the stations seem to pass in a wink, to show the great speed of the train. (The whistling stations are personification and onomatopoeia.)

DO NOT CONFUSE: "As big as a mountain" has a comparing word (simile) AND an impossible size (hyperbole). If the question asks about the comparing word, answer simile (3.2); if it asks about exaggeration, answer hyperbole. Hyperbole says MORE than the truth; litotes says LESS (4.8).

QUICK CHECK

QC7. Identify the figure of speech: “And inside you can tell it has a ton of space,” (PYQ-style)

- a. Litotes
- b. Euphemism
- c. Metonymy
- d. Hyperbole

Answer: (d) - space cannot be weighed in tons; the size is exaggerated on purpose.

4.8 Litotes and Understatement

ALSO ASKED

Exaggeration and understatement

Meaning	Saying less than you mean, often by using "not" with the opposite word ("not bad" = good). Say: LY-tuh-teez.
Exam definition	Litotes is understatement using a negative: an idea is expressed by denying its opposite ("not bad" = good; "unreluctant" = eager). Understatement (the wider term) makes something sound smaller or less serious than it really is.
Key / clue words	not bad not unkind no small not a simple un- / in- words (unreluctant) a bit
How to spot it	1. Look for "not", "no" or "un-" before a word. 2. Remove the negative and take the opposite: "not bad" → good. 3. The real meaning is STRONGER than the words → litotes / understatement.
Memory trick	HYPERbole goes over the top; LITOTES says "not bad" for "good". LITotes = LITtle words, big meaning.

EASY EXAMPLES

Your idli is not bad at all! **not bad = very good**

Getting a state rank is no small achievement. **no small = very big**

On a 42-degree day in Chennai, Ravi said, "It is a bit warm today." **understatement**

*With forward face and **unreluctant** soul;*

LIFE • HENRY VAN DYKE

Litotes — "unreluctant" (not unwilling) means eager and willing. (The f - f sound in the same line is alliteration, 3.1.)

***Not a simple jab** of the knife*

Will do it.

ON KILLING A TREE • GIEVE PATEL

Litotes / understatement — by denying the small action, the poet means that killing a tree needs far more cruel effort.

DO NOT CONFUSE: Litotes says LESS to mean MORE ("not bad" = good). Euphemism says something SOFTER to hide a harsh fact ("passed away" = died, 4.9). Litotes and hyperbole are opposites: one shrinks the truth, the other blows it up.

QUICK CHECK

QC8. Identify the figure of speech: "*Not so much pain will do it.*" (PYQ-style)

- a. Litotes
- b. Hyperbole
- c. Pun
- d. Oxymoron

Answer: (a) - a negative statement means that much more pain is needed to kill the tree.

4.9 Euphemism

ALSO ASKED

Exaggeration and understatement

Meaning	A mild, polite word used in place of a harsh or unpleasant one. Say: YOO-fuh-miz-um.
Exam definition	Euphemism is the use of a mild or indirect word or phrase for something harsh, sad or unpleasant ("passed away" for "died").
Key / clue words	passed away rest in peace sleep (= death) depart lie in the earth between jobs put to sleep
How to spot it	1. Is the real topic unpleasant (death, illness, failure, old age, losing a job)? 2. Is a soft, polite phrase used instead of the blunt word? Yes + yes → euphemism.
Memory trick	EUphemism = EU (good) word for a harsh fact. (Greek eu = good, pHEME = speech.)

EASY EXAMPLES

Our neighbour's grandfather passed away last night. **passed away = died**

My uncle is between jobs at the moment. **= has no job**

The old, sick dog was put to sleep. **= killed painlessly**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

The sands of life are nearly run,

*Let such in peace **depart**!*

YOUR SPACE • DAVID BATES

Euphemism — "depart" gently means "die". (The sands of life running out, as in an hourglass, is a metaphor.)

*And quiet sleep and a sweet dream **when the long trick's over**.*

SEA FEVER • JOHN MASEFIELD

Euphemism (also metaphor) — a "trick" is a sailor's turn of duty at the wheel; the end of the long trick gently means the end of life.

Is earth like this, in which **we all shall lie**.

NO MEN ARE FOREIGN • JAMES FALCONER KIRKUP

Euphemism — "lie" in the earth softly means to die and be buried.

DO NOT CONFUSE: Euphemism SOFTENS a harsh fact ("passed away"). Litotes UNDERSTATES with a negative to mean more ("not bad" = good, 4.8). Many euphemisms are also metaphors (sleep = death); if the question asks for "a mild way of saying something unpleasant", the answer is euphemism.

QUICK CHECK

QC9. The Fly says that those who visit the Spider's bed die, but puts it gently: *"They never, never wake again, who sleep upon your bed!"* Identify the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

- a. Hyperbole
- b. Euphemism
- c. Onomatopoeia
- d. Chiasmus

Answer: (b) - "never wake again" is a mild way of saying "die".

4.10 Irony and Sarcasm

ALSO ASKED

Indirect meaning

HIGH-FREQUENCY

Meaning	Irony: the opposite of what is said or expected. Sarcasm: bitter irony used to hurt or mock someone.
Exam definition	Irony is the opposite of what is said or expected. Verbal irony: the words say the opposite of what is meant. Situational irony: what happens is the opposite of what is expected. Dramatic irony: the reader or audience knows something that a character does not. Sarcasm is bitter, mocking verbal irony meant to hurt.
Key / clue words	Oh, great! What lovely ...! (said about something bad) praise that is really blame an upside-down result the reader knows, the character does not
How to spot it	1. Words say one thing, the meaning is the opposite → verbal irony (bitter and hurtful → sarcasm). 2. The result is the opposite of what we expect → situational irony. 3. We know a danger or truth that the character does not → dramatic irony.
Memory trick	IRONY turns things upside down: Words (verbal), Events (situational), Knowledge (dramatic). SARCASM comes from a Greek word meaning "to tear flesh" — it is irony that bites.

EASY EXAMPLES

Looking at a torn, dirty notebook, the teacher says, "What a beautiful notebook!"

verbal irony; said to mock = sarcasm

A fire station burns down.

situational irony

In a film, we see the thief hiding behind the door, but the hero walks in smiling.

dramatic irony

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

Says the ant to the cricket, "I'm your **servant and friend**,
But we ants never borrow; we ants never lend.

THE ANT AND THE CRICKET • ADAPTED FROM AESOP'S FABLES

Verbal irony — the ant calls himself the cricket's servant and friend, then at once refuses to help him.

"You sang, Sir, you say?

Go then," says the ant, "and **dance the winter away**."

THE ANT AND THE CRICKET • ADAPTED FROM AESOP'S FABLES

Sarcasm — the ant does not really want the starving cricket to dance; he mocks him bitterly for singing all summer.

Said the cunning Spider to the Fly, "*Dear friend* what can I do,
To prove the *warm affection* I've always felt for you?

THE SPIDER AND THE FLY • MARY BOTHAM HOWITT

Verbal irony + dramatic irony — the Spider's "warm affection" is really hunger; we readers know the Spider's plan while the Fly is being tempted.

Two more: the title of A Tragic Story is ironic, because the poem is a comic tale of a wise sage who acts foolishly; and On Killing a Tree uses a calm, step-by-step "how to kill" tone that exposes the cruelty (see 5.25 and 5.9).

DO NOT CONFUSE: All sarcasm is irony, but not all irony is sarcasm. Sarcasm is aimed at a PERSON, to hurt; a fire station burning down is irony but not sarcasm. Plain bad luck (rain on a picnic day) is NOT irony unless the result is the exact opposite of what was expected or planned.

QUICK CHECK

QC10. A Tragic Story is a funny tale of a sage who spins round and round to bring his pigtail to the front. Calling such a comic tale "tragic" is an example of (*PYQ-style*)

- a. Simile
- b. Apostrophe
- c. Alliteration
- d. Irony

Answer: (d) - the title says the opposite of what the poem really is.

4.11 Paradox

ALSO ASKED

Contrast

Meaning	A statement that sounds impossible or self-contradictory, but has a truth inside it.
Exam definition	Paradox is a statement that seems self-contradictory (or absurd) but contains a truth.
Key / clue words	yet but the more ... the less less is more a whole sentence that sounds impossible
How to spot it	1. First reading: "This is impossible!" 2. Second thought: "But it is true in a deeper way." 3. It is a whole statement, not just two words (two clashing words = oxymoron, 4.3).
Memory trick	A PARADOX is a puzzle sentence: it sounds FALSE, then turns out TRUE.

EASY EXAMPLES

"The child is father of the man." (Wordsworth) **childhood shapes the adult**

More haste, less speed. **rushing slows you down**

"I must be cruel, only to be kind." (Shakespeare) **cruel to be kind**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

Seeming still, yet still in motion,

THE RIVER • CAROLINE ANN BOWLES

Paradox — the broad river looks still (calm), yet it is always moving towards the ocean, like a person in the prime of life. Note the play on "still": first "calm", then "even now".

DO NOT CONFUSE: Paradox = a whole STATEMENT that seems impossible but is true ("The child is father of the man"). Oxymoron = two clashing WORDS side by side ("deafening silence", 4.3). Antithesis = opposite ideas balanced, with no contradiction ("To err is human, to forgive divine", 4.12).

QUICK CHECK

QC11. Identify the figure of speech: “*Seeming still, yet still in motion,*” (PYQ-style)

- a. Onomatopoeia
- b. Metonymy
- c. Paradox
- d. Climax

Answer: (c) - to be still and moving at the same time sounds impossible, but it is true of a broad, deep river.

4.12 Antithesis

ALSO ASKED

Contrast

HIGH-FREQUENCY

Meaning	Opposite ideas placed side by side in balanced words or clauses, to make the contrast sharp.
Exam definition	Antithesis is the placing of opposite (contrasting) ideas side by side in balanced words, phrases or clauses.
Key / clue words	Opposite pairs: friend / foe love / fear lost / won victory / defeat rich / poor err / forgive ; balance words: not ... but or than
How to spot it	1. Find two opposite words or ideas. 2. Check the balance: the two halves have a similar pattern. 3. Both halves are true, with no contradiction → antithesis.
Memory trick	ANTI = against: ANTI-thesis puts an idea against its opposite, like the two pans of a weighing scale.

EASY EXAMPLES

"To err is human, to forgive divine." (Pope) **err / forgive; human / divine**

Speech is silver, silence is golden. **speech / silence**

United we stand, divided we fall. **united / divided; stand / fall**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

*I was angry with my **friend**;
I told my wrath, my wrath did **end**.
I was angry with my **foe**;
I told it not, my wrath did **grow**.*

A POISON TREE • WILLIAM BLAKE

Antithesis — friend / foe, told / told not, end / grow are set against each other in two balanced pairs of lines.

*Speak gently! - It is better far
To rule by **love**, than **fear***

YOUR SPACE • DAVID BATES

Antithesis — ruling by love is set against ruling by fear.

*It's written in **victory and defeat**
And every trial a man may meet.*

COURAGE • EDGAR ALBERT GUEST

Antithesis — victory and defeat, two opposites, are placed together.

DO NOT CONFUSE: Antithesis = two opposite IDEAS in balanced parts, both true. Oxymoron = two clashing WORDS joined into one phrase ("empty joy", 4.3). Paradox = one statement that SEEMS impossible (4.11). Chiasmus = the same words repeated in reverse order (4.24).

QUICK CHECK

QC12. Identify the figure of speech: “*For the battle is lost or the battle is won*” (PYQ-style)

- a. Antithesis
- b. Oxymoron
- c. Simile
- d. Euphemism

Answer: (a) - the opposites "lost" and "won" are placed in balanced phrases.

4.13 Epigram

ALSO ASKED

Contrast

Meaning	A short, clever and memorable saying, often with a twist or a contrast.
Exam definition	An epigram is a short, witty, memorable saying that states a truth in a neat way, often with a surprising twist or contrast.
Key / clue words	short witty easy to quote a general truth in one line a twist at the end
How to spot it	1. Is it short (usually one line)? 2. Is it clever and easy to quote? 3. Does it state a general truth in a neat, balanced way? Yes → epigram.
Memory trick	EPIGRAM = a line fit for the school notice board: short, smart, and it sticks in the mind.

EASY EXAMPLES

"Brevity is the soul of wit." (Shakespeare) **short and witty**

"Little strokes fell great oaks." (Benjamin Franklin) **small efforts, big results**

"I can resist everything except temptation." (Oscar Wilde) **witty twist**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

A thing of beauty is a joy for ever:

A THING OF BEAUTY • JOHN KEATS

Epigram — the famous opening line states a general truth in a few memorable words.

"Persistence is the key to everything."

I AM EVERY WOMAN • RAKHI NARIANI SHIRKE

Epigram (also metaphor) — a short, quotable saying: persistence is called a "key" that opens every door.

DO NOT CONFUSE: EpiGRAM (a witty saying) ≠ EpiGRAPH (a quotation printed at the start of a book or chapter) ≠ EpiTAPH (words written on a tomb). A proverb is an old saying of the people with no known author; an epigram is usually the work of a known writer. An epigram often contains antithesis or paradox: "To err is human, to forgive divine" (Pope) is both an epigram and an antithesis.

QUICK CHECK

QC13. Identify the figure of speech: “*A thing of beauty is a joy for ever:*” (PYQ-style)

- a. Pun
- b. Epigram
- c. Apostrophe
- d. Ellipsis

Answer: (b) - a short, memorable statement of a general truth.

4.14 Pun

ALSO ASKED

Indirect meaning

Meaning	A play on words: one word (or two words that sound alike) used with two meanings at once, usually for fun.
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Exam definition	A pun is a play on two meanings of a word, or on words that sound alike, for a humorous or clever effect.
Key / clue words	Words with two meanings: cricket virus worm mouse bank weak / week two-tired / too tired
How to spot it	1. Find a word that fits two meanings at the same time. 2. Replace it with a synonym: if the joke disappears, it was a pun.
Memory trick	A PUN is FUN: one word, two meanings, one smile.

EASY EXAMPLES

A bicycle cannot stand on its own because it is two-tired. **two-tired / too tired**

Why is a river rich? Because it has two banks. **bank = river side / money bank**

Seven days without a walk makes one weak. **weak / week**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

Folks call this a fable. I'll warrant it true:
*Some **crickets** have four legs, and some have two.*

THE ANT AND THE CRICKET • ADAPTED FROM AESOP'S FABLES

Pun — "cricket" means the insect (four legs, as the poet counts them) and also a lazy, carefree person (two legs) who plays all summer and saves nothing.

*And one day, my naughty computer actually **gobbled a worm**,*

MY COMPUTER NEEDS A BREAK • SHANTHINI GOVINDAN

Pun — a computer worm (a harmful program) and an earthworm that is gobbled up.

*Then my computer **caught a virus**, and fell very sick,*

MY COMPUTER NEEDS A BREAK • SHANTHINI GOVINDAN

Pun + Personification — a computer virus and a germ that makes people ill; the computer "falls sick" like a person.

DO NOT CONFUSE: A pun needs TWO meanings working at once. A word used in only one meaning ("The bat flew out of the cave") is not a pun. When a line has both a pun and personification (the sick computer), answer what the question points to: the double-meaning word → pun; the human action → personification (3.4).

QUICK CHECK

QC14. Identify the figure of speech: “Some crickets have four legs, and some have two.” (PYQ-style)

- a. Hyperbole
- b. Synecdoche
- c. Pun
- d. Inversion

Answer: (c) - "crickets" means both the insects and idle people.

4.15 Metonymy

ALSO ASKED

Association and reference

HIGH-FREQUENCY

Meaning	Calling something by the name of a thing closely connected with it. Say: mi-TON-uh-mee.
Exam definition	Metonymy is naming something by an associated thing (uniforms for soldiers; the crown for the king; the pen for writing).
Key / clue words	the crown (king, queen) the pen (writing) the sword (war, force) the bench (judges) the press (newspapers) the stage (acting) uniforms (soldiers)
How to spot it	1. The word is NOT a part of the real thing, only something linked with it (a tool, symbol, place or dress). 2. Replace it with the real meaning: "the pen" → writing. Linked thing → metonymy; a part of the thing → synecdoche (4.16).
Memory trick	Synecdoche = Some part for the whole; Metonymy = Mention a related thing.

EASY EXAMPLES

The bench gave its judgement today. **bench = judges**

Have you read Bharathiyar? **the poet's name for his poems**

Kodambakkam has released three new films this week. **a place for the Tamil film industry**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

*Beneath all **uniforms**, a single body breathes*

NO MEN ARE FOREIGN • JAMES FALCONER KIRKUP

Metonymy — "uniforms" stands for soldiers. A uniform is not a part of a soldier's body, only connected with him. (The full sentence, which compares their bodies with ours using "like", is a simile — see 3.2.)

DO NOT CONFUSE: "All hands on deck" — hands are a PART of the sailors → synecdoche (4.16). "Uniforms" are not a part of the soldiers, only CONNECTED with them → metonymy. Many books treat synecdoche as a special kind of metonymy; if both are options, ask: "part or connection?"

QUICK CHECK

QC15. Identify the figure of speech in the words "pen" and "sword": "The pen is mightier than the sword." (PYQ-style)

- a. Synecdoche
- b. Pun
- c. Oxymoron
- d. Metonymy

Answer: (d) - "pen" stands for writing and "sword" for war or force: things named by objects linked with them.

4.16 Synecdoche

ALSO ASKED

Association and reference

HIGH-FREQUENCY

Meaning	A part used for the whole, or the whole used for a part. Say: si-NEK-duh-kee.
Exam definition	Synecdoche is a figure in which a part stands for the whole, or the whole stands for a part (hands for workers; soul for person; roof for home).
Key / clue words	hands (workers) heads (people, cattle) mouths to feed soul (person) roof (home) wheels (vehicle) India won (the team)
How to spot it	1. Is the word a PART of the real thing (the hands of a worker, the roof of a home)? 2. Or is the WHOLE used for a part ("India won" = the Indian team)? Either → synecdoche.
Memory trick	Synecdoche = Some part for the whole; Metonymy = Mention a related thing.

EASY EXAMPLES

All hands on deck! **hands = sailors**

The farmer has five mouths to feed. **mouths = family members**

India won the match by six wickets. **whole country = the team**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

*Their **hands** are ours, and in their lines we read*

NO MEN ARE FOREIGN • JAMES FALCONER KIRKUP

Synecdoche — "hands" (a part) stands for the working people of other lands; their labour is like ours.

It's the old home **roof** that shelters all the charm that life can give;

THE STICK-TOGETHER FAMILIES • EDGAR ALBERT GUEST

Synecdoche — the roof (a part) stands for the whole home and family.

DO NOT CONFUSE: Synecdoche uses a PART (hands, roof, soul); metonymy uses a CONNECTED thing (uniforms, crown, pen, 4.15). A quick test: is it a part of the thing itself? Hands are part of the worker's body → synecdoche. A crown or a uniform can be taken off; it is only connected with the person → metonymy.

QUICK CHECK

QC16. In "Every soul that touches yours -" the word "soul" stands for a whole person. Identify the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

- a. Synecdoche
- b. Metonymy
- c. Euphemism
- d. Irony

Answer: (a) - a part (the soul) stands for the whole person.

4.17 Transferred Epithet

ALSO ASKED

Association and reference

HIGH-FREQUENCY

Meaning	An adjective that really describes a person is moved to a thing, a time or an action connected with that person.
Exam definition	A transferred epithet is an adjective (epithet) transferred from the person it really describes to a thing connected with that person ("busy day", "sleepless night").
Key / clue words	Feeling or state adjective + a thing or time: sleepless night busy day weary way anxious hours nervous wait lazy afternoon
How to spot it	1. Find an adjective + noun pair. 2. Ask: "Can this NOUN really feel or be this?" (Can a night be sleepless? No — the person is.) 3. The quality belongs to a person nearby → transferred epithet.
Memory trick	Transferred epithet: the night was not sleepless - YOU were.

EASY EXAMPLES

I spent a sleepless night before the exam. **I was sleepless, not the night**

After a busy day, Amma made hot idlis for us. **Amma was busy, not the day**

"The ploughman homeward plods his weary way." (Thomas Gray) **the ploughman is weary, not the way**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

And the finest of conventions ever held beneath the sun
Are the little family gatherings when the **busy day** is done.

THE STICK-TOGETHER FAMILIES • EDGAR ALBERT GUEST

Transferred epithet — the people are busy, not the day; the adjective has moved from the people to the day.

DO NOT CONFUSE: "The angry sea" — the sea itself is shown raging like a person → personification (3.4). "A sleepless night" — the quality really belongs to a nearby PERSON → transferred epithet. Always ask: "Whose quality is it really?"

QUICK CHECK

QC17. Identify the figure of speech in the phrase "busy day": "But the gladdest sort of people, when the busy day is done," (PYQ-style)

- a. Oxymoron
- b. Personification
- c. Transferred epithet
- d. Hyperbole

Answer: (c) - the people are busy; the adjective is transferred to the day.

4.18 Rhetorical Question

ALSO ASKED

Indirect meaning

Meaning	A question asked for effect, not to get an answer.
Exam definition	A rhetorical question is a question asked for effect or emphasis, not for an answer; the answer is obvious, or no answer is expected.
Key / clue words	? (no reply follows) How could ...? Who knows ...? Isn't it ...? What will become of ...?
How to spot it	1. Find the question mark. 2. Does anyone answer it? Is an answer really needed? 3. If the question is really a strong statement or feeling → rhetorical question.
Memory trick	A rhetorical question is ASKED, not ANSWERED — its answer is hidden inside it.

EASY EXAMPLES

Who does not love Marina Beach at sunset? = everyone loves it

Do you think money grows on trees? = it does not

How many times must I tell you? no answer wanted

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

"Oh! *what will become,*" says cricket, "*of me?*"

THE ANT AND THE CRICKET • ADAPTED FROM AESOP'S FABLES

Rhetorical question (with exclamation) — the cricket expects no answer; the question shows his fear and despair.

How did I get so lucky,

you were the dad chosen for me.

SPECIAL HERO • CHRISTINA M. KERSCHEN

Rhetorical question — the child does not want an answer; the question shows wonder and thanks.

How could this be?

THE HOUSE ON ELM STREET • NADIA BUSH

Rhetorical question — the poet wonders at the tree that never grows leaves; no answer is given, and the next line admits the poet does not know.

DO NOT CONFUSE: "What time is it?" needs an answer → an ordinary question, not rhetorical. The cricket's cry above has two figures: "Oh!" is an exclamation (4.19), and the question that follows, which expects no answer, is a rhetorical question.

QUICK CHECK

QC18. Identify the figure of speech: "What happened inside that house?" (PYQ-style)

- a. Exclamation
- b. Rhetorical question
- c. Apostrophe
- d. Ellipsis

Answer: (b) - the poet asks for effect; no answer is expected, and the poem ends by calling the house a mystery.

4.19 Exclamation

ALSO ASKED

Indirect meaning

Meaning	A sudden cry of strong feeling — joy, sorrow, surprise, anger or wonder.
Exam definition	Exclamation is a figure of speech in which strong feeling is expressed suddenly, usually with words like "Oh!", "Alas!", "Ah!", "What a ...!", "How ...!" and the exclamation mark (!).
Key / clue words	Oh! Alas! Ah! Hurrah! What a ...! How ...! !

How to spot it	1. Look for "!" and words like Oh, Alas, Ah. 2. Is a strong feeling being poured out? Yes → exclamation. 3. If the line also speaks TO someone absent or to a thing, it is apostrophe too (4.1).
Memory trick	EXCLAMATION = EXCLAIM = cry out a feeling: Alas = sad, Hurrah = glad.

EASY EXAMPLES

Hurrah! We won the match!	joy
Alas! The poor bird is dead.	sorrow
What a beautiful sunrise at Kanyakumari!	wonder

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

*Alas! Still faithful to his back,
The pigtail hangs behind him.*

A TRAGIC STORY • WILLIAM MAKEPEACE THACKERAY

Exclamation — "Alas!" shows mock sorrow: after all his spinning, the pigtail is still behind him. (The faithful pigtail is personification.)

*Perchance unkindness made them so;
Oh, win them back again!*

YOUR SPACE • DAVID BATES

Exclamation — "Oh" and "!" make an earnest cry: win back, with gentle words, those who have gone wrong.

DO NOT CONFUSE: "River, river, little river!" ends with "!", but the main figure is apostrophe, because the poet speaks TO the river (4.1). Exclamation is only the strong cry; apostrophe needs someone absent, or a thing, to be spoken TO.

QUICK CHECK

QC19. Identify the figure of speech: "She's real, she's not fake!" (PYQ-style)

- a. Exclamation
- b. Hyperbole
- c. Pun
- d. Synecdoche

Answer: (a) - a strong feeling is expressed with an exclamation mark.

4.20 Inversion

ALSO ASKED

Repetition and order

Meaning	Changing the normal order of words in a sentence, for rhyme, rhythm or emphasis.
Exam definition	Inversion (also called anastrophe) is the reversal of the normal order of words in a sentence: "Whose woods these are I think I know." for "I think I know whose woods these are."
Key / clue words	verb before subject (Strong is she) adjective after noun (apple bright) object first Down came ... Never have I ...
How to spot it	1. Read the line as normal prose — does it sound upside down? 2. Rewrite it in normal order (subject + verb + object). 3. Same meaning, only a different order → inversion.
Memory trick	INVERSION = INVERTED (upside-down) word order. Put it back the right way up to check.

EASY EXAMPLES

Sweet is the mango of Salem.	= The mango of Salem is sweet.
Down came the rain.	= The rain came down.
Never have I seen such a crowd at Marina Beach.	= I have never seen ...

Whose woods these are I think I know.

STOPPING BY WOODS ON A SNOWY EVENING • ROBERT FROST

Inversion — normal order: I think I know whose woods these are. (This line is NOT alliteration: "whose" begins with an h sound, "woods" with a w sound.)

In the morning glad I see,

My foe outstretched beneath the tree.

A POISON TREE • WILLIAM BLAKE

Inversion — normal order: In the morning I gladly see my foe lying dead under the tree.

That for themselves a cooling covert make

A THING OF BEAUTY • JOHN KEATS

Inversion — about the clear streams (rills); normal order: that make a cool, shady shelter for themselves.

DO NOT CONFUSE: Inversion changes the word order inside ONE sentence. Chiasmus repeats words in REVERSED order across TWO balanced parts (4.24). An adjective placed after its noun (an apple bright) is also inversion, but for that line of A Poison Tree the figure usually asked is allusion (4.2).

QUICK CHECK

QC20. Identify the figure of speech: “Strong is she in her faith and beliefs.” (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Chiasmus
- c. Metonymy
- d. Inversion

Answer: (d) - normal order: She is strong in her faith and beliefs.

4.21 Epistrophe

ALSO ASKED

Repetition and order

Meaning	The same word or words repeated at the END of lines, clauses or sentences that come one after another. Say: i-PIS-truh-fee.
Exam definition	Epistrophe is the repetition of the same word(s) at the end of successive lines, clauses or sentences. It is the opposite of anaphora.
Key / clue words	the same ending words ... the people / ... the people ... no evil / ... no evil behind him
How to spot it	1. Look at the LAST words of each line or clause. 2. The same word(s) at the end again and again → epistrophe. 3. The same words at the START → anaphora (3.6).
Memory trick	ANaphora is At the stArt; EPistrophe is at the End.

EASY EXAMPLES

"... government of the people, by the people, for the people ..." (Abraham Lincoln) **the people**

See no evil, hear no evil, speak no evil. **no evil**

In the morning it rained, in the afternoon it rained, all night it rained. **it rained**

There lived a sage in days of yore,
And he a handsome pigtail wore;
But wondered much and sorrowed more,
Because it hung **behind him**.

A TRAGIC STORY • WILLIAM MAKEPEACE THACKERAY

Epistrophe / refrain — every stanza of the poem closes with the same words, "behind him".

The same ending returns in the other stanzas: "Not dangling there behind him." • "The pigtail hung behind him." • "Hung steadily behind him." Each time, the sage's spinning ends where it began — that is the joke of the poem.

DO NOT CONFUSE: Epistrophe = same words at the END (4.21). Anaphora = same words at the START (3.6). Refrain = a line or phrase that returns at regular intervals, usually at stanza ends (4.22). Rhyme = only the SOUND matches (sing - spring); in epistrophe the same WORD comes back.

QUICK CHECK

QC21. In A Tragic Story every stanza ends with the same words, as in "The pigtail hangs behind him." Repeating the same words at the END of lines is called (PQ-style)

- a. Anaphora
- b. Epistrophe
- c. Alliteration
- d. Chiasmus

Answer: (b) - the same words come at the end of the lines; anaphora would need them at the start.

4.22 Refrain

ALSO ASKED

Repetition and order

Meaning	A line or phrase that comes back at regular places in a poem or song, usually at the end of each stanza — like a chorus.
Exam definition	A refrain is a line or phrase repeated at regular intervals in a poem or song, usually at the end of stanzas (a chorus).
Key / clue words	chorus the same last line in every stanza the pallavi of a song regular intervals
How to spot it	1. Look at the end of each stanza, or at the chorus. 2. Does the same line or phrase come back at REGULAR places? Yes → refrain. 3. A line said just twice, side by side, is repetition, not refrain (3.7).
Memory trick	REFRAIN = the line that RETURNS again and again, like the pallavi of a Tamil film song.

EASY EXAMPLES

In "Twinkle, twinkle, little star", the opening lines come back at the end of the rhyme. **refrain**

"Old MacDonald had a farm, E-I-E-I-O" — "E-I-E-I-O" returns in every verse. **refrain**

The pallavi of a film song is sung again after every charanam. **refrain**

Says he, "The mystery I've found,
I'll turn me round," he turned him round;
But still it hung **behind him**.

A TRAGIC STORY • WILLIAM MAKEPEACE THACKERAY

Refrain / epistrophe (also repetition) — the words of the last line change a little, but "behind him" closes all six stanzas, coming back at regular places like a chorus.

Lessons in life aren't always so simple

LESSONS IN LIFE • BRIGETTE BRYANT AND DANIEL HO

Refrain (chorus) — this line opens the chorus of the song-poem; a chorus is sung again after each verse, so it works as a refrain.

DO NOT CONFUSE: “*And miles to go before I sleep, / And miles to go before I sleep.*” — the same line said twice, side by side, at the end of the poem = REPETITION (3.7), not refrain and not anaphora. A refrain returns at REGULAR intervals (every stanza or every chorus).

QUICK CHECK

QC22. A line or phrase repeated at regular intervals in a poem or song, usually at the end of each stanza, is called (*PYQ-style*)

- a. Rhyme scheme
- b. Pun
- c. Refrain
- d. Climax

Answer: (c) - a refrain returns at regular places, like a chorus.

4.23 Polysyndeton and Asyndeton

ALSO ASKED

Repetition and order

Meaning	Polysyndeton: many joining words ("and ... and ... and") one after another. Asyndeton: the joining words are left out; only commas remain.
Exam definition	Polysyndeton is the use of many conjunctions (usually "and" or "or") in close succession. Asyndeton is the deliberate leaving out of conjunctions between words, phrases or clauses.
Key / clue words	and ... and ... and (polysyndeton) nor ... nor (polysyndeton) commas only, no "and" (asyndeton)
How to spot it	1. Count the "and"s: more than grammar needs → polysyndeton (it slows the line and piles things up). 2. A list joined only by commas, with no "and" before the last item → asyndeton (it speeds the line up and sounds urgent).
Memory trick	POLY = many (a polygon has many sides): many ANDs. A- = without (as in "atypical"): WITHOUT ands.

EASY EXAMPLES

At the wedding we ate idli and dosa and vada and pongal. **polysyndeton**

"I came, I saw, I conquered." (Julius Caesar) **asyndeton: no "and"**

He ran, jumped, caught the ball. **asyndeton**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

And the wheel's kick and the wind's song and the white sail's shaking,

SEA FEVER • JOHN MASEFIELD

Polysyndeton — "and" joins every item; the sights and sounds of the ship pile up one after another.

Louder, faster, brawling, leaping,

THE RIVER • CAROLINE ANN BOWLES

Asyndeton — no "and" at all; the quick list matches the rushing, impatient river of youth.

Browning, hardening,

Twisting, withering,

ON KILLING A TREE • GIEVE PATEL

Asyndeton — the stages of the tree's death follow one another with only commas.

More: polysyndeton in “*And up and down and in and out*” and “*the sighs and groans and moans,*” · asyndeton in “*That we shall dispossess, betray, condemn.*”

DO NOT CONFUSE: In *The Secret of the Machines*, "We can" at the START of each line is anaphora (3.6), while the many "and"s INSIDE each line are polysyndeton. Asyndeton drops only the joining words; ellipsis drops other words that the reader must supply (4.4).

QUICK CHECK

QC23. Identify the figure of speech: "*We can pull and haul and push and lift and drive,*" (PYQ-style)

- a. Polysyndeton
- b. Asyndeton
- c. Ellipsis
- d. Epistrophe

Answer: (a) - many "and"s join the actions one after another.

4.24 Chiasmus

ALSO ASKED

Repetition and order

Meaning	A criss-cross pattern: words from the first half come back in reverse order in the second half (A-B, B-A). Say: ky-AZ-mus.
Exam definition	Chiasmus is a criss-cross (ABBA) reversal of words or ideas in two parallel clauses.
Key / clue words	A ... B / B ... A eat to live / live to eat ask not ... ask fair ... foul / foul ... fair
How to spot it	1. Split the sentence into two halves. 2. Label the key words of the first half A and B. 3. If the second half has them as B and A → chiasmus.
Memory trick	CHIasmus comes from the Greek letter CHI, written X: the words cross over like an X.

EASY EXAMPLES

"Ask not what your country can do for you — ask what you can do for your country." (John F. Kennedy) **country - you / you - country**

When the going gets tough, the tough get going. **going - tough / tough - going**

"Fair is foul, and foul is fair." (Shakespeare) **fair - foul / foul - fair**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

*Remember, no men are **strange**, no countries **foreign***

NO MEN ARE FOREIGN • JAMES FALCONER KIRKUP

Chiasmus — the first line; the last line reverses the pair: "*Remember, no men are foreign, and no countries strange.*" Strange - foreign (A-B) becomes foreign - strange (B-A), so the poem ends where it began.

DO NOT CONFUSE: Antithesis needs OPPOSITE ideas (4.12); chiasmus needs the SAME words in REVERSED order. "Fair is foul, and foul is fair" has both. Inversion upsets the word order inside ONE clause (4.20); chiasmus mirrors TWO clauses.

QUICK CHECK

QC24. Identify the figure of speech: "Eat to live; do not live to eat." (PYQ-style)

- a. Climax
- b. Inversion
- c. Simile
- d. Chiasmus

Answer: (d) - eat - live (A-B) is reversed as live - eat (B-A).

4.25 Climax and Anticlimax

ALSO ASKED

Repetition and order

Meaning	Climax: words or ideas arranged in rising order of importance, like steps going up. Anticlimax: a sudden drop from something important to something small or silly.
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Exam definition	Climax is the arrangement of words, phrases or ideas in rising (ascending) order of importance or force. Anticlimax (also called bathos) is a sudden fall from something serious or important to something trivial, often for humour.
Key / clue words	a list of three or more small → bigger → biggest first ... then ... finally a silly last item (anticlimax)
How to spot it	1. Check the order of a list of three or more items. 2. Each step bigger or stronger than the last → climax. 3. Big, big, big ... then small and silly → anticlimax.
Memory trick	CLIMAX comes from the Greek word for "ladder": climb up, step by step. ANTI-climax = slipping off the ladder at the last step.

EASY EXAMPLES

"I came, I saw, I conquered." (Julius Caesar) **climax: each act bigger than the last**

First he smiled, then he laughed, then he roared with joy. **climax**

The cyclone uprooted trees, flooded streets, wrecked houses — and wet my newspaper. **anticlimax: a sudden, silly drop**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

There is no clear example of climax or anticlimax in the 25 syllabus poems, so learn the classic one: "I came, I saw, I conquered." (Julius Caesar) — came → saw → conquered, each act bigger than the one before. (It is also asyndeton, 4.23.)

DO NOT CONFUSE: Climax as a figure of speech = rising order of words or ideas inside a sentence. The climax of a story = its most exciting turning point. Anticlimax used on purpose, for humour, is a figure of speech, not a mistake.

QUICK CHECK

QC25. Identify the figure of speech: "Some books are to be tasted, others to be swallowed, and some few to be chewed and digested." (Francis Bacon) (PYQ-style)

- a. Anticlimax
- b. Climax
- c. Chiasmus
- d. Polysyndeton

Answer: (b) - tasted → swallowed → chewed and digested: the ideas rise step by step in force.

4.26 Imagery and Symbolism

ALSO ASKED

Association and reference

Meaning	Imagery: word-pictures that let you see, hear, smell, taste or touch what is described. Symbolism: an object, colour or action that stands for a deeper idea.
Exam definition	Imagery is the use of descriptive words that appeal to the five senses: sight (visual), sound (auditory), smell (olfactory), taste (gustatory) and touch (tactile). Symbolism is the use of an object, person or action to stand for an idea (a dove for peace; a road for life).
Key / clue words	Sight: colours, light, shapes Sound: sweep, whistle, buzz Smell: smell, scent, fragrance Taste: sweet, bitter, salty Touch: wet, cold, downy, rough Symbols: road journey woods sleep apple dove
How to spot it	1. Imagery: can you SEE, HEAR, SMELL, TASTE or FEEL the line? Name the sense. 2. Symbolism: does the object mean something MORE than itself through the whole poem (sleep = death; woods = rest)?
Memory trick	IMAGE-ry = an IMAGE in the mind through the 5 senses: See, Hear, Smell, Taste, Touch. A SYMBOL is a SIGN for an idea: a dove = peace, a lamp = knowledge.

EASY EXAMPLES

The jasmine in Amma's hair filled the bus with its fragrance. **smell**

The hot, crisp dosa crackled on the tawa and tasted of ghee. **sound, touch, taste**

A white dove is a symbol of peace. **symbolism**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

*The only other sound's the **sweep**
Of easy wind and **downy flake**.*

STOPPING BY WOODS ON A SNOWY EVENING • ROBERT FROST

Imagery — sound (the soft sweep of the wind) and touch (soft, downy snowflakes).

*when you can **smell the grass**
from your garden seat*

INDIAN SEASONS • NISHA DYRENE

Imagery — smell (olfactory): the fresh scent of spring grass.

*The **woods** are lovely, dark and deep,
But I have **promises** to keep,
And miles to go before I **sleep**,*

STOPPING BY WOODS ON A SNOWY EVENING • ROBERT FROST

Symbolism — the woods stand for rest or temptation, the promises for duties, and sleep for death; the miles to go are the work and life still ahead.

Other symbols in the syllabus poems: the apple in A Poison Tree (deceit that brings death), the river's course in The River (the stages of human life), and the road and journey in Life (life itself).

DO NOT CONFUSE: Imagery shows the thing itself through the senses (a grey mist — we see the mist). Symbolism makes a thing stand for something else (sleep = death). One word can be both: the dark woods are a picture (imagery) and a sign of rest or death (symbol).

QUICK CHECK

QC26. Identify the figure of speech: “And a grey mist on the sea's face, and a grey dawn breaking.” (PYQ-style)

- a. Onomatopoeia
- b. Allusion
- c. Visual imagery
- d. Euphemism

Answer: (c) - the grey mist and the grey dawn are pictures for the eye (sight).

4.27 Extended Metaphor and Allegory **ALSO ASKED** **Comparison**

Meaning	Extended metaphor: one comparison carried on through many lines or a whole poem. Allegory: a whole story with a hidden moral meaning; a fable is a short allegory, often with talking animals.
Exam definition	An extended metaphor is a metaphor developed over several lines or a whole poem. An allegory is a whole story whose characters and events stand for a hidden moral meaning; a fable is a short allegory, often with animals that talk, ending in a moral.
Key / clue words	the same comparison all through fable moral talking animals "like" in every stanza (extended simile)
How to spot it	1. One comparison continues for many lines (anger = a tree that is watered, sunned and bears fruit) → extended metaphor. 2. The whole story teaches a lesson through its characters (spider = flatterer, fly = foolish listener) → allegory / fable. 3. The same comparison made with "like" in stanza after stanza → extended simile (The River).
Memory trick	One metaphor = one photo; an extended metaphor = a whole film. ALLEGORY = ALL of the story hides a lesson.

EASY EXAMPLES

Life is a cricket match: some balls are easy, some are bouncers; some days you score a century, some days you are out for a duck.
extended metaphor

The Hare and the Tortoise **fable: slow and steady wins the race**

The Panchatantra stories **fables with morals**

FROM THE SYLLABUS POEMS

*And I water'd it in fears,
Night and morning with my tears:
And I sunned it with smiles,
And with soft deceitful wiles.*

A POISON TREE • WILLIAM BLAKE

Extended metaphor — the poet's hidden anger is a tree: watered with tears, sunned with false smiles, it grows and bears a poisoned apple that kills the foe.

To idle, silly flattering words, I pray you ne'er give heed:

THE SPIDER AND THE FLY • MARY BOTHAM HOWITT

Allegory — the moral of the whole tale: the Spider stands for a flatterer and the Fly for anyone who listens to sweet, false praise.

*O'er the yellow pebbles dancing,
Through the flowers and foliage glancing,
Like a child at play.*

THE RIVER • CAROLINE ANN BOWLES

Extended simile — each stanza compares the river with a stage of human life using "like": "Like a child at play." → "Like impetuous youth." → "Just like mortal prime." → "Like eternity."

The Ant and the Cricket is a fable adapted from Aesop, and the poet says so: "Folks call this a fable." Its moral: work and save in good times for the hard times ahead. Team Work (life as a game) and Life (life as a journey) are also built on extended metaphors.

DO NOT CONFUSE: The River is an extended SIMILE (the comparison uses "like" in every stanza), not an extended metaphor. In a fable, the talking animals are PERSONIFICATION (3.4), while the whole story with its hidden lesson is ALLEGORY. Answer what the question asks: the talking spider → personification; the kind of story → allegory / fable.

QUICK CHECK

QC27. In A Poison Tree, anger is a tree that the poet waters ("And I water'd it in fears,"), suns with smiles and that finally bears an apple. A comparison carried through the whole poem is called (PYQ-style)

- a. an extended metaphor
- b. a simile
- c. onomatopoeia
- d. litotes

Answer: (a) - one metaphor (anger = a tree) is developed through the whole poem.

5 Poem-wise Figures: the 25 Syllabus Poems

This section takes the 25 syllabus poems one by one, in syllabus order, from 5.1 Life to 5.25 A Tragic Story. Every poem block has the same five parts: (1) the idea of the poem **in one line**; (2) its **form**; (3) its **rhyme scheme** and **rhyming words**, taken from the real line-end words; (4) a **table of figures** with the exact line from the poem, only the clue words highlighted, and the clue explained in a few words; (5) the lines **most likely to be asked**. Every line is quoted word for word, so you can match it with the exam options. A figure is listed only when it is clear-cut; when one line holds two figures, the Clue column says so, and short "word help" notes explain hard words. The meanings of the figures are in Section 3 (syllabus figures) and Section 4 (other figures); confusing pairs are in Section 6.

EXAM TIP: After learning the figures in Sections 3 and 4, revise poem-wise in four quick steps. (1) Read the poem aloud once - alliteration, onomatopoeia and rhyme are heard, not seen. (2) Cover the Figure column, look at the highlighted words and name the figure; then cover the line and recall it from the figure. (3) Write the rhyme scheme yourself: give the last word of each line a letter (new end-sound = new letter, see 3.8) and check it against the box. (4) On the last day, read only the MOST LIKELY ASKED lines of every poem, saying the figure aloud for each. When one line has two figures, answer the one that the words underlined or named in the question point to (see Section 7).

5.1 Life Henry Van Dyke

In one line: The poet wants to live every year of his life with courage and cheer - not mourning the past, not fearing the future - treating life as a joyful journey, and he hopes that its last turn will be the best.

Form	Sonnet of 14 lines: an octave (8 lines, in the Italian abbaabba pattern) and a sestet (6 lines) that ends in a rhyming couplet
Rhyme scheme	abbaabba cddcee
Rhyming words	year - disappear - fear - cheer; soul - goal - whole - toll; down - crown; joy - boy; quest - best

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Alliteration	<u>L</u> et me but <u>l</u> ive my <u>l</u> ife from year to year,	l sound three times: let, live, life
Alliteration	With <u>f</u> orward <u>f</u> ace and <u>u</u> nreluctant soul;	f - f: forward, face. Bonus: <i>unreluctant</i> (= not unwilling = eager) is litotes, see 4.8
Alliteration	And <u>h</u> appy <u>h</u> earth, that pays its toll	h - h: happy, heart (toll = a fee paid to use a road - part of the journey picture)
Alliteration	My heart will <u>k</u> ee <u>p</u> the <u>c</u> ourage of the <u>q</u> uest,	one k SOUND, three spellings: keep, courage, quest - alliteration goes by sound, not by letter (quest = a search)
Metaphor	O'er rough or smooth, the <u>j</u> ourney will be joy:	life is called a journey, without like or as; rough or smooth = hard days and easy days. Also j - j alliteration: journey, joy
Metaphor	And hope the <u>r</u> oad's <u>l</u> ast <u>t</u> urn will be the best.	the road's last turn = the last stage of life (old age); the road and journey picture runs through the poem - extended metaphor, see 4.27
Personification	From what the future <u>v</u> eils;	the future hides what is coming behind a veil, as a person would
Anaphora	<u>N</u> ot hurrying to, nor turning from the goal; / <u>N</u> ot mourning for the things that disappear	"Not" begins two lines in a row
Antithesis	To <u>y</u> outh and <u>a</u> ge,	opposites side by side (see 4.12); so are "hurrying to, nor turning from" and "up the hill or down"

MOST LIKELY ASKED: "Let me but live my life from year to year," - alliteration (l). "My heart will keep the courage of the quest," - alliteration of the k sound (keep, courage, quest). "the journey will be joy" - metaphor (life = a journey). Also learn the sonnet's rhyme scheme abbaabba cddcee and pairs such as joy - boy and quest - best. Trap: the journey line has no like or as, so it is a metaphor, not a simile.

5.2 I am Every Woman Rakhi Nariani Shirke

In one line: A salute to today's woman - beautiful, strong, brave, caring and firm in her faith - who never gives up, must never be taken lightly, and deserves love and respect.

Form	Lines of uneven length with scattered rhymes; no fixed rhyme pattern
Rhyme scheme	No regular scheme
Rhyming words	stake - fake; dear - near - fear; beliefs - belief (dear - near come back in the last two lines)

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Alliteration	She's strong in her <u>f</u> aith, <u>f</u> irm in her belief?	f - f: faith, firm
Metaphor	She's <u>a</u> lioness; don't mess with her.	she IS a lioness - brave, fierce and protective; no like or as

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Metaphor	The <u>summer</u> of life she's ready to see in <u>spring</u> .	seasons stand for stages of life; no like or as (the word order is also inverted)
Metaphor	"Persistence is <u>the key</u> to everything,"	persistence (= not giving up) is a key that opens every door; it is also a short, wise saying - epigram, see 4.13
Onomatopoeia	Despite the <u>sighs</u> and <u>groans</u> and <u>moans</u> ,	sound words: sigh, groan, moan; the repeated "and" is polysyndeton, see 4.23
Repetition	She's <u>today's woman</u> . <u>Today's woman</u> , dear.	"today's woman" is said twice for emphasis
Inversion	<u>Strong is she</u> in her faith and beliefs.	normal order: She is strong in her faith and beliefs (see 4.20)
Ellipsis	Love her, respect her, keep her near...	the closing dots leave the thought open for the reader (see 4.4); "her" three times is repetition

MOST LIKELY ASKED: "She's a lioness; don't mess with her." - metaphor. "Despite the sighs and groans and moans," - onomatopoeia. "She's strong in her faith, firm in her belief!" - alliteration (f). A rhyming pair from this poem: stake - fake. Trap: calling the woman a lioness without like or as is a metaphor; *like a lioness* would have made it a simile.

5.3 The Secret of the Machines Rudyard Kipling

In one line: The machines speak to us: made from ore and shaped in fire, they will work for us day and night, but they cannot understand a lie or feel love, pity or forgiveness, so one careless slip can kill - and in the end they are only children of the human brain.

Form	Rhymed stanzas in alternate rhyme; the machines themselves speak ("We") to human beings
Rhyme scheme	abab
Rhyming words	mine - design; pit - fit; ask - task; play - day; drive - dive; light - write; live - forgive; lie - die; eyes - size; again - brain

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Personification	Some water, coal, and oil is all <u>we ask</u> ,	the machines speak as "We" and ask for fuel as if it were food; they even say "We can neither love nor pity nor forgive,"
Anaphora	<u>We were</u> taken from the ore-bed and the mine, / <u>We were</u> melted in the furnace and the pit	"We were" opens four lines in a row; later "We can" opens four more (see 3.6)
Polysyndeton	We can pull <u>and</u> haul <u>and</u> push <u>and</u> lift <u>and</u> drive,	"and" after every verb - the many conjunctions suggest endless work (see 4.23)
Alliteration	We can <u>p</u> rint and <u>p</u> lough and weave and heat and light,	p - p: print, plough
Alliteration	We can <u>r</u> un and <u>r</u> ace and swim and fly and dive,	r - r: run, race
Alliteration	Though our smoke may <u>h</u> ide the <u>H</u> eavens from your eyes,	h - h: hide, Heavens
Metaphor	We are nothing more than <u>children of your brain!</u>	machines = children (creations) of the human mind. TRAP: "nothing more than" means "only" - it does not make a simile

MOST LIKELY ASKED: "We can print and plough and weave and heat and light," - alliteration (p). "We are nothing more than children of your brain!" - metaphor, not simile. "We were taken from the ore-bed and the mine, / We were melted in the furnace and the pit" - anaphora. Remember: machines that speak and reason = personification. Trap: "We will serve you four and twenty hours a day!" is not hyperbole - machines really can work day and night.

5.4 The Ant and the Cricket Adapted from Aesop's fables

In one line: A fable: the cricket sang all through summer and saved nothing, so in winter, starving and cold, he begs the ant for food and shelter; the ant refuses and mocks him - so work and save in good times for hard times.

Form	A fable in verse: rhyming couplets with a few three-line rhymes; lines of mixed length, much of it dialogue
Rhyme scheme	aabb (rhyming couplets, with a few triplets such as see - tree - me, borrow - tomorrow - sorrow)

Rhyming words	sing - spring; home - come; found - ground; see - tree - me; bold - cold; ant - grant; rain - grain; borrow - tomorrow - sorrow; friend - lend; by - I; light - night; gay - say - away; wicket - cricket; true - two
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Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Alliteration	A <u>silly</u> young cricket, accustomed to <u>sing</u>	s - s: silly, sing (the next line adds sunny, summer, spring)
Personification	<u>Says the ant</u> to the cricket,	the ant and the cricket talk and reason like people - talking animals in a fable = personification
Anaphora	<u>Not a</u> flower could he see, / <u>Not a</u> leaf on a tree.	"Not a" opens two lines in a row ("Not a crumb" opens a line two lines earlier)
Ellipsis	Not a crumb to be found / On the snow-covered ground;	"There was" is left out: (There was) not a crumb to be found (see 4.4)
Rhetorical question	"Oh! <u>what will become</u> ," says cricket, " <u>of me?</u> "	a cry of despair, not a real question; "Oh!" adds an exclamation (see 4.18)
Repetition	But <u>we ants never</u> borrow; <u>we ants never</u> lend.	"we ants never" twice - a flat, firm refusal
Irony	"I'm your <u>servant and friend</u> ,	the ant calls himself a servant and friend, then refuses all help; his "and dance the winter away" is sarcasm (see 4.10)
Pun	Some <u>crickets</u> have four legs, and some have two.	two-legged "crickets" = idle people who play and never save (see 4.14)
Allegory (fable)	Folks call this a <u>fable</u> . I'll warrant it true:	the whole poem is a story with a moral - work and save (see 4.27)

MOST LIKELY ASKED: "A silly young cricket, accustomed to sing" - alliteration (s). "Not a flower could he see, / Not a leaf on a tree." - anaphora. "Some crickets have four legs, and some have two." - pun. The talking ant and cricket = personification. Do not confuse: the "Not a ..." lines show two figures - anaphora (the same opening words) and ellipsis (missing words such as "There was"); answer what the question points to.

5.5 No Men are Foreign James Falconer Kirkup

In one line: A call for universal brotherhood: people of every land share the same body, the same earth, the same needs and the same labour, so when we hate or fight others we only harm ourselves and the earth we all share.

Form	Free verse - no regular rhyme or metre; a direct appeal to the reader that keeps saying "Remember"
Rhyme scheme	Free verse, no rhyme scheme
Rhyming words	None - the line-ends do not rhyme (free verse)

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Simile	a single body breathes / <u>Like</u> ours	comparison with "like"; so is "eyes like ours". It compares people with people, but textbook keys call it a simile (see 3.2)
Metonymy	Beneath all <u>uniforms</u> ,	uniforms stand for the soldiers of every country (see 4.15)
Synecdoche	Their <u>hands</u> are ours,	hands (a part) stand for the working people (see 4.16)
Alliteration	Are fed by peaceful harvests, by <u>war's</u> long <u>winter</u> starv'd.	w - w: war's, winter. "war's long winter" is also a metaphor (war = a long, hungry winter), and fed by peace / starved by war is antithesis
Metaphor	Our <u>hells</u> of fire and dust	the fire and dust of war are called "hells"; no like or as
Euphemism	in which we all shall <u>lie</u> .	to lie in the earth = to be buried, i.e. to die - a gentle way of saying it (see 4.9)
Asyndeton	That we shall dispossess, betray, condemn.	three verbs with no "and" between them (see 4.23). Word help: dispossess = to drive people out of their homes and land; condemn = to blame and punish
Repetition	<u>Remember</u> , no men are strange, no countries foreign	"Remember" comes five times (once as "Let us remember") to drive the message home

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Chiasmus	<i>Remember, no men are foreign, and no countries strange.</i>	the last line repeats the first with the two words swapped: strange ... foreign → foreign ... strange - a criss-cross (see 4.24)

MOST LIKELY ASKED: “a single body breathes / Like ours” - simile. “by war's long winter starv'd” - alliteration (w), and also a metaphor. “Beneath all uniforms,” - metonymy. The first and last lines show repetition with a criss-cross (chiasmus). There is no rhyme scheme: it is free verse. Do not confuse: uniforms for soldiers is metonymy (a related thing); hands for workers is synecdoche (a part for the whole) - see Section 6.

5.6 The House on Elm Street Nadia Bush

In one line: The speaker describes a lonely, mysterious house on Elm Street - its lights flicker at night and a leafless tree stands beside it; the speaker is tempted to look inside but fear wins, and what happened there will always remain a mystery.

Form	Lines of uneven length; scattered rhymes but no regular scheme
Rhyme scheme	No regular scheme
Rhyming words	alone - unknown - bone; place - space; day - May; mind - kind; fall - tall (small, inside the same line as tall, rhymes too); made - fade; tree - be

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Personification	<i>It sat alone.</i>	a house cannot "sit" - a human action is given to a thing; the tree beside it also "sits"
Personification	<i>At night the house seems to be alive,</i>	the house seems to have life, like a living being
Personification	<i>It plays with your mind.</i>	the house plays tricks on you, as a person would
Hyperbole	<i>it has a ton of space,</i>	space cannot be weighed in tons - a deliberate exaggeration for "a lot of space" (see 4.7)
Metaphor	<i>But at the same time it is bare to the bone.</i>	the empty house is pictured as a body stripped to the bone; also b - b alliteration: bare, bone
Alliteration	<i>The house seems to be a bit brighter</i>	b - b: bit, brighter
Rhetorical question	<i>How could this be?</i>	asked for effect - no answer is expected (see 4.18); another such question comes near the end
Antithesis	<i>never getting small or ever growing tall,</i>	opposites small / tall in balanced phrases (see 4.12); the two words also rhyme

MOST LIKELY ASKED: “It sat alone.” - personification. “it has a ton of space,” - hyperbole. “How could this be?” - rhetorical question. Rhyming words such as alone - unknown - bone may also be asked; remember that the poem has no regular rhyme scheme. Trap: “At night the house seems to be alive,” is personification, not simile - “seems” is not a comparing word.

5.7 Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening Robert Frost

In one line: A traveller stops on the darkest evening of the year to watch snow fill a silent wood; the lovely, dark woods tempt him to stay, but he remembers his promises and the long way he must still go before he can rest.

Form	Four quatrains (4-line stanzas) in chain rhyme: the unrhymed third line of each stanza gives the main rhyme of the next stanza; the last stanza keeps one rhyme
Rhyme scheme	aaba bbbcb cddc dddd
Rhyming words	know - though - snow; here - queer - near - year; lake - shake - mistake - flake; sweep - deep - keep - sleep

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Alliteration	<i>His house is in the village though;</i>	h - h: His, house
Alliteration	<i>To watch his woods fill up with snow.</i>	w - w: watch, woods

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Inversion	<i>Whose woods these are I think I know.</i>	normal order: I think I know whose woods these are (see 4.20). TRAP: "Whose woods" is NOT alliteration - "whose" begins with an h sound
Personification	<i>My little horse <u>must think</u> it queer</i>	the horse "thinks" like a person (queer = strange)
Personification	<i>He gives his harness bells a shake / <u>To ask</u> if there is some mistake.</i>	the horse shakes its bells "to ask" a question - a human action (harness = the straps fitted on a horse)
Imagery	<i>The only other sound's the <u>sweep</u> / Of <u>easy</u> <u>wind</u> and <u>downy flake</u>.</i>	hearing (the soft sweep of the wind) and touch (feather-soft snow), see 4.26; also s - s alliteration (sound's, sweep) and long-e assonance (sweep, easy)
Symbolism	<i>The <u>woods</u> are lovely, dark and deep, / But I have <u>promises</u> to keep,</i>	woods = rest, beauty, escape; promises = the duties of life (see 4.26); also d - d alliteration: dark, deep
Repetition	<i><u>And miles to go before I sleep,</u> / <u>And miles to go before I sleep.</u></i>	the last line is repeated: REPETITION, not anaphora or refrain (see 3.7). "Sleep" also hints at death, and "miles" at the work of life still left

MOST LIKELY ASKED: "And miles to go before I sleep, / And miles to go before I sleep." - repetition (not anaphora). "My little horse must think it queer" - personification. "To watch his woods fill up with snow." - alliteration (w). Trap: "Whose woods these are I think I know." is inversion; its first two words are not alliteration. The rhyme scheme aaba bbcb ccdd dddd is a favourite question.

5.8 A Poison Tree William Blake

In one line: Anger spoken out to a friend ends, but anger hidden from an enemy grows like a tree - watered with fears and tears, sunned with false smiles - until it bears a shining apple that tempts the foe and kills him.

Form	Four quatrains in rhyming couplets; short, simple, song-like lines
Rhyme scheme	aabb
Rhyming words	friend - end; foe - grow; fears - tears; smiles - wiles; night - bright; shine - mine; stole - pole; see - tree

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Anaphora	<i><u>I was angry with my friend</u>; ... <u>I was angry with my foe</u>:</i>	the same words open lines 1 and 3; later, line after line begins with "And"
Repetition	<i>I told my <u>wrath</u>, my <u>wrath</u> did end.</i>	"wrath" (anger) twice in one line
Antithesis	<i>I told it not, my wrath did <u>grow</u>.</i>	set against "I told my wrath, my wrath did end." - told / told it not, end / grow, friend / foe (see 4.12)
Metaphor	<i>And I <u>water'd it</u> in fears, / Night and morning with my tears:</i>	anger is a plant that he waters; the tree picture runs through the whole poem - extended metaphor (see 4.27)
Alliteration	<i>And I <u>s</u>unned it with <u>s</u>mile,</i>	s - s: sunned, smiles (and soft in the next line, where wiles = tricks); his false smiles are the "sunshine" that feeds his anger
Allusion	<i>Till it bore an <u>apple</u> bright.</i>	recalls the forbidden fruit (usually pictured as an apple) of the Garden of Eden in the Bible - tempting but deadly (see 4.2)
Personification	<i>When the night had <u>veiled</u> the pole;</i>	night covers the sky as if drawing a veil - a human action (the pole = the night sky around the Pole Star)
Inversion	<i>In the morning <u>glad I see</u>,</i>	normal order: In the morning I gladly see (my foe lying dead) (see 4.20)
Symbolism	<i>My foe outstretched beneath the <u>tree</u>.</i>	the tree = hidden anger grown deadly, the apple = deceit; "outstretched" shows the foe lying dead under it (see 4.26)

MOST LIKELY ASKED: "And I sunned it with smiles," - alliteration (s). "Till it bore an apple bright." - allusion (the Garden of Eden). "I told my wrath, my wrath did end." - repetition, and antithesis with "my wrath did grow". The whole poem is an extended metaphor: hidden anger = a poison tree.

5.9 On Killing a Tree Gieve Patel

In one line: In the cool voice of a "how-to" guide, the poet shows that a tree cannot be killed with a few cuts - it heals and sprouts again - and dies only when its root is pulled out and left to scorch and wither; the calm tone exposes how cruel the act is.

Form	Free verse - no rhyme; short lines of uneven length, written like a set of instructions
Rhyme scheme	Free verse, no rhyme scheme
Rhyming words	None - the line-ends do not rhyme (free verse)

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Irony	<i>It takes much time to kill a tree,</i>	killing is explained calmly, step by step, like a recipe - the cool tone exposes the cruelty (see 4.10)
Metaphor	<i>And out of its leperous hide</i>	the rough, scaly bark is called a leper's skin (hide); no like or as
Personification	<i>The bleeding bark will heal</i>	the bark bleeds and heals like a wounded body; also b - b alliteration: bleeding, bark
Onomatopoeia	<i>And pulled out - snapped out</i>	"snapped" imitates the sound of the root breaking
Repetition	<i>And pulled out - snapped out / Or pulled out entirely,</i>	"pulled out" comes three times within five lines - only uprooting will kill the tree
Metaphor	<i>Out from the earth-cave,</i>	the soil is a cave that hides and protects the root
Alliteration	<i>The source, white and wet,</i>	w - w: white, wet; also imagery of sight and touch (see 4.26)
Consonance	<i>Of scorching and choking</i>	the ch sound is repeated inside one word and at the start of the next (see 4.6)
Asyndeton	<i>Browning, hardening, / Twisting, withering,</i>	-ing words listed with no "and" - the slow death of the tree, stage by stage (see 4.23)

MOST LIKELY ASKED: "The bleeding bark will heal" - personification (with b - b alliteration). "And out of its leperous hide" - metaphor. "And pulled out - snapped out" - onomatopoeia. It is free verse, so it has no rhyme scheme. If a question on the bleeding bark line points to the b sound, answer alliteration; if it points to bleeding and healing, answer personification.

5.10 The Spider and the Fly Mary Botham Howitt

In one line: A cunning spider tries to lure a fly into his "parlour" with sweet invitations, a soft bed and a full pantry; the fly refuses again and again, and the poem warns us never to listen to flatterers (in the full poem, flattery finally traps the fly).

Form	Rhyming couplets in long lines; mostly a dialogue between the Spider and the Fly - a moral tale
Rhyme scheme	aabb
Rhyming words	Fly - spy; stair - there; vain - again; high - Fly; thin - in; said - bed; do - you; nice - slice

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Personification	<i>"Will you walk into my parlour?" said the Spider to the Fly,</i>	the spider and the fly talk like people, and the spider even has a parlour, a bed and a pantry - talking animals = personification
Alliteration	<i>'Tis the prettiest little parlour that ever you did spy;</i>	p - p: prettiest, parlour; the first line has w - w: "Will you walk"
Repetition	<i>"Oh no, no," said the little Fly, "to ask me is in vain,</i>	"no, no" - and a later reply of the Fly opens with the very same words
Euphemism	<i>They never, never wake again, who sleep upon your bed!</i>	never waking again = dying - a soft way of saying it (see 4.9); "never, never" is also repetition
Irony	<i>"Dear friend what can I do, / To prove the warm affection I've always felt for you?"</i>	the spider calls his victim "dear friend" and speaks of warm affection - he only wants to eat the fly (see 4.10)

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Simile	Your eyes are <i>like</i> the diamond bright, but mine are dull <i>as</i> lead!	two similes: eyes like a diamond (like), dull as lead (as) - the spider's flattery, from a later stanza
Onomatopoeia	With <i>buzzing</i> wings she hung aloft, then near and nearer drew,	"buzzing" imitates the sound of the fly's wings; "near and nearer" shows her coming closer (later stanza)
Allegory	To idle, silly <i>flattering words</i> , I pray you ne'er give heed:	the moral of the whole tale: the spider stands for a flatterer, the fly for anyone who listens to flattery (see 4.27). Word help: ne'er give heed = never pay attention

MOST LIKELY ASKED: "Will you walk into my parlour?" - personification (a talking spider), with w - w alliteration. "They never, never wake again, who sleep upon your bed!" - repetition and euphemism. "Your eyes are like the diamond bright, but mine are dull as lead!" - simile. Trap: "Will you walk into my parlour?" is a real invitation that expects an answer, so it is not a rhetorical question.

5.11 The River Caroline Ann Bowles

In one line: The poet speaks to a river and follows it from a playful little stream to a rushing torrent, then a broad, calm river and at last the endless sea - the stages of human life: childhood, youth, mature adult life and eternity.

Form	Four five-line stanzas; each opens with "River, river" and ends with a short simile line
Rhyme scheme	abccb (every stanza)
Rhyming words	way - play; dancing - glancing; smooth - youth (near rhyme); leaping - sweeping; time - prime; motion - ocean; sea - eternity; sounded - rounded

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Apostrophe + Personification	<i>River, river, little river!</i> / Bright <i>you sparkle</i> on your way;	the poet speaks to the river as "you" (apostrophe, see 4.1), and the river sparkles and travels like a living being (personification)
Personification	O'er the yellow pebbles <i>dancing</i> ,	the river dances like a playful child
Simile	<i>Like</i> a child at play.	each stanza ends with a "like" simile for a stage of life: childhood here, then "Like impetuous youth." (youth), "Just like mortal prime." (adult life) and "Like eternity." (endless time after death). Word help: impetuous = rash and hasty; mortal prime = the best years of adult life
Simile	Broad and deep, and still <i>as</i> time;	calm and steady like time itself - a comparison with "as"
Alliteration	On you <i>r</i> ush through <i>r</i> ough and smooth;	r - r: rush, rough (rocks and rose-banks follow two lines later)
Asyndeton	Louder, faster, brawling, leaping,	four words with no "and" - the rush and noise of youth (see 4.23)
Paradox	Seeming <i>still</i> , yet <i>still</i> in motion,	it looks motionless yet keeps moving - a contradiction that is true (see 4.11); "still" first means "calm", then "even now"
Alliteration	<i>D</i> own you <i>d</i> ash into the sea,	d - d: down, dash
Anaphora	<i>Sea that</i> line hath never sounded, / <i>Sea that</i> sail hath never rounded,	"Sea that" opens two lines in a row. Meaning: no measuring line has reached its bottom and no ship has sailed round it
Repetition	<i>River, river!</i> Headlong <i>river!</i>	"river" three times in one line; every stanza opens in this way

MOST LIKELY ASKED: "River, river, little river! / Bright you sparkle on your way;" - apostrophe + personification. "Like a child at play." - simile. "Seeming still, yet still in motion," - paradox. Also learn the rhyme scheme abccb, which is the same in every stanza.

5.12 The Comet Norman Littleford

In one line: The poet marvels at a comet racing across the sky - swift, huge and powerful, with a tail miles long - notes that scientists think comet dust may have started life on earth, and says he knows no finer sight.

Form	Six quatrains (4-line stanzas); only the second and fourth lines of each stanza rhyme
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Rhyme scheme	abcb
Rhyming words	night - flight; long - strong; force - course; shake - quake; behind - mankind; right - flight

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Personification	<i>Rampaging</i> through the heavens / Never stopping day or night,	the comet "rampages" - rushes about wildly like an angry living creature - and never rests
Simile	<i>Faster than</i> a cheetah	two unlike things compared with "than"; textbook keys count this as a simile (see 3.2)
Simile	<i>Bigger than</i> a mountain	the comet is compared with a mountain using "than"
Alliteration	A comet in <i>full flight</i> .	f - f: full, flight
Alliteration	<i>Scientists say</i> the chemicals	s - s: Scientists, say (the same s sound)
Repetition	But I know no better <i>spectacle</i> / Than <i>a comet in full flight</i> .	the ending brings back "spectacle" from line 3 and the whole of line 4, "A comet in full flight." - the poem closes on its opening picture

MOST LIKELY ASKED: "Faster than a cheetah" - simile (a comparison with "than"; see 3.2). "A comet in full flight." - alliteration (f), repeated as the last line. "Rampaging through the heavens" - personification. The rhyme scheme is abcb: only night - flight, long - strong and the like rhyme. Trap: both "than" comparisons of unlike things - with a cheetah and with a mountain - are similes, not metaphors.

5.13 The Stick-together Families Edgar Albert Guest

In one line: Families that stay together are the happiest; those who break family ties to seek pleasure among strangers reap only bitterness, so the poet calls the weary wanderer back home to his own people.

Form	Rhyming couplets in long lines; it ends with a direct call to a wanderer to come home
Rhyme scheme	aabb
Rhyming words	far - are; make - break; sun - done; wise - ties; way - play; find - kind; roam - home; astray - away; done - fun; earth - mirth; give - live; win - kin

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Metaphor	who take <i>separate highways</i> are.	"separate highways" = separate ways of life, away from the family; no like or as
Antithesis	There are <i>rich</i> folk, there are <i>poor</i> folk, who imagine they are wise,	rich / poor in balanced clauses (see 4.12)
Anaphora	<i>Each</i> goes searching after pleasure in his own selected way, / <i>Each</i> with strangers likes to wander, and with strangers likes to play.	"Each" opens two lines in a row; "with strangers likes to" is also repeated inside the second line
Metaphor	But it's bitterness they <i>harvest</i> ,	bitterness is a crop they reap - the fruit of breaking family ties; no like or as
Oxymoron	and it's <i>empty joy</i> they find,	"empty" + "joy": two opposite ideas side by side (see 4.3)
Transferred epithet	Are the little family gatherings when the <i>busy</i> day is done.	the people are busy, not the day - the adjective is shifted to "day" (see 4.17)
Repetition	But the gladdest sort of people, <i>when the busy day is done</i> ,	the same phrase returns from earlier; "gladdest" and "stick-together" also come back again and again
Synecdoche	It's the old home <i>roof</i> that shelters all the charm that life can give;	roof (a part) = the whole home (see 4.16)
Alliteration	And, O <i>w</i> eary, <i>w</i> andering brother, if contentment you <i>w</i> ould <i>w</i> in,	w four times: weary, wandering, would, win; "if contentment you would win" is also inversion (see 4.20)
Apostrophe	And, O weary, wandering <i>brother</i> , ... / <i>Come you back</i> unto the fireside and be comrade with your kin.	"O" + words spoken straight to an absent wanderer, calling him home (see 4.1). Word help: comrade = companion; kin = one's own relatives

MOST LIKELY ASKED: "and it's empty joy they find," - oxymoron. "when the busy day is done." - transferred epithet. "And, O weary, wandering brother, if contentment you would win," - apostrophe and alliteration (w). The whole poem rhymes in couplets: aabb. Do not confuse: "busy day" is a transferred epithet (the people, not the day, are busy), while "empty joy" is an oxymoron (opposite words side by side).

5.14 Special Hero Christina M. Kerschen

In one line: The speaker remembers the father's loving care from babyhood, thanks him for a love that seems to be sent from above, and calls him a special hero.

Form	Short lyric of 16 lines in four quatrains (4-line stanzas); a tribute in which the speaker talks directly to the father (you, your). The tone is loving and grateful, and the words are simple and everyday.
Rhyme scheme	abcb
Rhyming words	arms - harm (near rhyme); see - me; love - above; know - so. Only lines 2 and 4 of each quatrain rhyme.

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Alliteration	There is s omething s pecial	s - s (something, special): two words side by side begin with the same s sound. Say the line aloud to check.
Metaphor	That you're my special hero	The father is called a hero directly - no like or as. A hero is someone we admire and look up to; the speaker sees the dad that way. This line gives the poem its title.
Repetition	I felt the love and tenderness, / ... / Our love is everlasting,	love comes four times (lines 3, 6, 10 and 13) - the key word of the poem. special is repeated too (lines 9 and 15).
Ellipsis	Seems it was sent to me	The subject is left out: (It) seems it was sent to me. The reader supplies the missing word. The line also has s - s alliteration (Seems, sent).
Rhetorical question	How did I get so lucky, / you were the dad chosen for me.	Begins with How : a question asked for effect, not for an answer. It shows wonder and thanks. (The line ends in a comma, not a question mark.)
Inversion	and all the love I would see.	Normal order: and I would see all the love. The object comes first so that see ends the line and rhymes with me .

MOST LIKELY ASKED: "That you're my special hero" → metaphor; "How did I get so lucky," → rhetorical question; "There is something special" → alliteration (s). Rhyme scheme: abcb. Do not call the hero line a simile - there is no like or as.

5.15 Making Life Worth While George Eliot

In one line: Everyone who comes in touch with us, even briefly, should gain some good from us - grace, a kind thought, courage, faith or hope - and such small gifts make life worthwhile and heaven more certain.

Form	Free verse: 12 short lines of uneven length, no regular metre; the whole poem is one long sentence built as a list of small gifts. The tone is gentle and hopeful, like quiet advice.
Rhyme scheme	free verse, no rhyme scheme
Rhyming words	None at the line ends (yours, contact, good, thought, unfelt, courage, sky, faith, life, skies, worthwhile, heritage). Sky and skies are the same word, not a rhyme. The poem's music comes from the repeated One instead.

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Alliteration	And h eaven a surer h eritage.	h - h (heaven, heritage): say it aloud - both important words begin with the h sound. A heritage is something we inherit; heaven is pictured as our inheritance.
Metaphor	One bit of courage / For the darkening sky ;	A darkening sky = troubled, hard times (no like or as). Its opposite, "One glimpse of brighter skies", = hope and happier days.
Metaphor	To brave the thickening ills of life;	Troubles are said to thicken like gathering clouds - they keep growing. Faith helps us face (brave) them.
Anaphora	One bit of courage / ... / One gleam of faith / ... / One glimpse of brighter skies -	One begins lines 5, 6, 8 and 10: a list of small gifts we can give to others (see 3.6).
Ellipsis	Gets therefrom some good; / Some little grace; one kindly thought;	The verb Gets is said once (therefrom = from that contact) and then left out; the reader supplies it before every later item: (gets) one bit of courage, (gets) one gleam of faith ...
Synecdoche	Every soul that touches yours -	A part (the soul) stands for the whole person: every person you meet. Memory trick: Synecdoche = Some part for the whole.
Inversion	Be it the slightest contact -	Verb before subject: Be it = even if it is. Even the smallest meeting should do some good.

MOST LIKELY ASKED: “Every soul that touches yours -” → synecdoche (soul = person); “One bit of courage / For the darkening sky;” → metaphor (the verb gets is also left out - ellipsis); the lines beginning with **One** → anaphora. Remember: this poem is free verse, so it has no rhyme scheme.

5.16 A Thing of Beauty John Keats

In one line: Beautiful things - the sun, the moon, trees, daffodils, clear streams and flowering forest thickets - give a joy that never fades; they bind us to the earth and lift the gloom from our spirits.

Form	The opening 24 lines of Book I of Keats's long poem <i>Endymion</i> ; heroic couplets (pairs of rhyming lines of about ten syllables), with many run-on lines. Some printed versions leave out lines 8-11 and 20-22; line numbers here follow the full 24-line extract.
Rhyme scheme	aabb (heroic couplets)
Rhyming words	ever - never; keep - sleep; breathing - wreathing; earth - dearth; days - ways; all - pall; moon - boon; daffodils - rills; make - brake; blooms - dooms; dead - read (read in the past tense sounds like red); drink - brink.

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Alliteration	<i>That for themselves a cooling covert make</i>	k - k sound (cooling, covert; covert = a shady shelter); also b - b in band, bind (line 7). Trap: “simple sheep” is NOT alliteration - s and sh are different sounds.
Metaphor	<i>A flowery band to bind us to the earth,</i>	Beauty is a garland (a band of flowers) that ties us to life on earth - no like or as.
Metaphor	<i>An endless fountain of immortal drink,</i>	All lovely things are a fountain of heavenly drink (nectar) that never runs dry and pours on us from heaven.
Personification	<i>Some shape of beauty moves away the pall</i>	Beauty acts like a person lifting a pall (the dark cloth over a coffin) from our dark spirits. Here pall = gloom.
Anaphora	<i>Of noble natures, of the gloomy days, / Of all the unhealthy and o'er-darkened ways</i>	Of begins lines 9 and 10 (and each phrase) to list the sorrows of life that beauty helps us bear. These lines are missing from the shorter versions (see Form).
Repetition	<i>Such the sun, the moon, / ... / For simple sheep; and such are daffodils</i>	such is repeated (lines 13 and 15, and again in line 20) to list the things of beauty: sun, moon, trees, daffodils, streams.
Assonance	<i>Full of sweet dreams, and health, and quiet breathing.</i>	The long e vowel sound repeats: sweet, dreams, breathing - soft, restful music (see 4.5).
Epigram	<i>A thing of beauty is a joy for ever;</i>	A short, memorable saying that states a truth; the most famous line of the poem.
Inversion	<i>Therefore, on every morrow, are we wreathing</i>	= we are wreathing (verb before subject). The cooling covert line (17) is inverted too: in normal order it would read “that make a cooling covert for themselves”.
Imagery	<i>Rich with a sprinkling of fair musk-rose blooms:</i>	Appeals to sight and smell (musk-roses are sweet-smelling wild roses); just before it, the cooling streams (rills) against the hot season appeal to touch (see 4.26).

MOST LIKELY ASKED: “A thing of beauty is a joy for ever;” → epigram (the famous opening line); “A flowery band to bind us to the earth,” → metaphor (also b - b alliteration); “Some shape of beauty moves away the pall” → personification. Trap to remember: “simple sheep” is NOT alliteration (s and sh are different sounds).

5.17 Lessons in Life Brigitte Bryant and Daniel Ho

In one line: Simple-sounding lessons - care for friends, make room for every creature, say thank you, and make others feel they matter - are not always easy, but they make life kinder.

Form	Song-poem: two 4-line verses, each followed by the same 5-line chorus, which opens with the title words. The tone is warm and simple; the speaker gives friendly advice.
Rhyme scheme	abcb in the verses (bloom - room, sad - bad), chorus rhymes free - me
Rhyming words	bloom - room (verse 1); sad - bad (verse 2); free - me (chorus). Lines 1 and 3 of each verse (flower - planet, important - difference) do not rhyme.

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Alliteration	<i>Let's be aware as we walk on this planet</i>	w - w (we, walk): two neighbouring words begin with the same w sound.
Simile	<i>Having a friend is like planting a flower</i>	like compares friendship with planting a flower: both need care and time to grow.
Metaphor	<i>Show love and kindness it one day will bloom</i>	The friendship (it) will bloom - a flower word used for a friendship, without like or as. The simile of line 1 is carried on.
Repetition	<i>Even the tiniest creature needs room. / ... / Even the smallest of gifts deserves "thank you"</i>	Even the + an -est word (tiniest, smallest) is repeated: even the smallest things matter.
Paradox	<i>Nothing you're given will ever come free</i>	It seems to contradict itself (what is given should be free), yet it is true: every gift asks for thanks and respect in return.
Refrain	<i>Lessons in life aren't always so simple</i>	This line opens the chorus, which comes back after each verse - a refrain (see 4.22). It also gives the poem its title.
Chiasmus	<i>I think of you and you think of me.</i>	Criss-cross order: I - you / you - me (ABBA). It shows give-and-take between friends; think of is also repeated.

MOST LIKELY ASKED: “Having a friend is like planting a flower” → simile (like); “Let's be aware as we walk on this planet” → alliteration (w); “Lessons in life aren't always so simple” → refrain (the opening line of the chorus). Simile Says "like"; Metaphor Means "is": line 1 is the simile, the bloom of line 2 is the metaphor.

5.18 My Computer Needs a Break Shanthini Govindan

In one line: A humorous poem: the speaker's once brainy computer turns forgetful, catches a virus and, like a tired worker, seems to need a holiday.

Form	Light, humorous poem of 16 lines in rhyming couplets (8 pairs); the computer is treated as a person from the first line to the last. The tone is playful: computer words (mouse, save, worm, virus) are mixed with words for people.
Rhyme scheme	aabb
Rhyming words	smart - heart; click - quick; too - do; away - way; right - sight; worm - squirm; sick - quick; say - holiday.

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Alliteration	<i>So I had to call in a doctor, double quick.</i>	d - d (doctor, double); also b - b in “behaving badly”.
Metaphor + hyperbole	<i>It seems to know mountains of information by heart.</i>	A huge store of facts is called mountains - an obvious exaggeration made through a metaphor. Knowing things by heart is also a human act.
Personification	<i>My computer has always been so brainy and smart -</i>	Brainy and smart are human qualities given to a machine.
Personification	<i>It's so absent-minded, that I don't know what to do.</i>	Forgetfulness is a human weakness. The computer also forgets to save work and hides files, like a person.
Personification	<i>'Doctor, do you think my tired computer wants a holiday.'</i>	The computer is tired and wants a holiday, like an overworked person - the break of the title. This is NOT apostrophe: the doctor is present in the room (see 4.1).
Onomatopoeia	<i>If I type in a question, and give my mouse a click,</i>	click imitates the sound of the mouse button.
Repetition	<i>My computer always gives me the answer really quick! / But of late, my computer has been behaving badly too,</i>	computer comes eight times in 16 lines, keeping the "patient" at the centre of the poem.
Pun	<i>my naughty computer actually gobbled a worm,</i>	worm = a harmful computer program AND an earthworm that gets gobbled up. naughty , like a child, adds personification.
Pun	<i>Then my computer caught a virus, and fell very sick,</i>	virus = a computer virus AND a germ that makes people ill; “ <i>fell very sick</i> ” is personification too.

MOST LIKELY ASKED: “and give my mouse a click,” → onomatopoeia; “It seems to know mountains of information by heart.” → hyperbole (made through a metaphor); “Then my computer caught a virus, and fell very sick,” → personification (and a pun on virus). The whole poem is one long personification: brainy, absent-minded, naughty, sick, tired.

5.19 Your Space David Bates

In one line: Speak gently to everyone - the child, the young, the old, the poor and those who go wrong - because kind words rule better than fear and the good they do lasts for ever.

Form	Lyric of nine quatrains (36 lines); every stanza opens with “ <i>Speak gently</i> ”. Note: the textbook text under the title “Your Space” is David Bates’s poem beginning “ <i>Speak gently!</i> ”
Rhyme scheme	abab
Rhyming words	far - mar, fear - here; low - flow, bind - kind; child - mild, gain - remain; they - may, bear - care; one - run, heart - depart; poor - endure, heard - word; know - so, vain - again; life - strife, will - still; thing - bring, well - tell.

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Alliteration	Let no h arsh tone be h eard;	h - h (harsh, heard): the two key words of the line begin with the h sound.
Metaphor	The sands of life are nearly run,	Life = the sand in an hourglass; for the aged it has almost run out (little time is left).
Metaphor	Dropped in the heart's deep well ;	The heart = a deep well; a gentle word dropped into it stays there and does good.
Personification	And gently Friendship's accents flow; / Affection's voice is kind.	Friendship speaks (accents) and Affection has a voice - feelings act like people. Also “ <i>Love doth whisper low</i> ”.
Onomatopoeia	<i>Speak gently!</i> - Love doth whisper low	whisper imitates a soft, breathy sound - it suits a poem about gentle speech.
Anaphora	Speak gently to the little child! / ... / Speak gently to the young, for they / ... / Speak gently to the aged one,	Speak gently begins all nine stanzas (and line 3) - the key repetition of the poem (see 3.6).
Allusion	<i>Speak gently!</i> - He who gave his life / To bend man's stubborn will, / ... / Said to them, 'Peace, be still.'	A reference to the Bible story in which Jesus calms a storm. The poet uses it as an example of gentle words (see 4.2).
Euphemism	Let such in peace depart!	depart = die: a mild word for the death of the aged (see 4.9).
Antithesis	To rule by love , than fear	Opposite ideas, love and fear, set side by side: it is better to rule by love than by fear.
Inversion	The vows that true hearts bind ;	= the vows that bind true hearts (verb moved to the end to rhyme with kind). Also “ <i>Its love be sure to gain</i> ,” = be sure to gain its love.

MOST LIKELY ASKED: “*Speak gently!*” at the start of every stanza → anaphora; “*Love doth whisper low*” → personification (whisper is also onomatopoeia); “*The sands of life are nearly run*,” → metaphor. **Speak gently** at the START of each stanza is anaphora, not refrain (see 3.6 and 4.22).

5.20 Sea Fever John Masefield

In one line: The speaker longs to go back to the sea and the free, wandering life of a sailor; he asks only for a tall ship, a windy day, cheerful company and peaceful rest when his work is over.

Form	Lyric of three 4-line stanzas with long, rolling lines; each stanza is two rhyming couplets and opens with the same words. The title means a strong, restless longing for the sea, as if the speaker were ill with it.
Rhyme scheme	aabb
Rhyming words	sky - by; shaking - breaking; tide - denied; flying - crying; life - knife; rover - over.

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Alliteration	And all I ask is a tall ship and a st ar to st eer her by;	st - st (star, steer): the same st sound begins two neighbouring words. Sailors once steered by the stars at night.
Alliteration	And the w heel's kick and the w ind's song and the w hite sail's shaking,	w - w - w (wheel's, wind's, white); also s - s in “ <i>quiet sleep and a sweet dream</i> ”.

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Simile	<i>To the gull's way and the whale's way where the wind's like a whetted knife;</i>	like : the cold, cutting sea wind is compared to a sharpened (whetted) knife. The same line has w - w alliteration (whale's, wind's, whetted).
Metaphor	<i>when the long trick's over.</i>	A trick is a sailor's turn of duty at the wheel; the long trick = life's long work. Its end gently hints at death, so it is also a euphemism (see 4.9).
Personification	<i>And a grey mist on the sea's face,</i>	The sea is given a human face. The tide also calls him like a person: "for the call of the running tide".
Anaphora	<i>I must go down to the seas again, to the lonely sea and the sky, / ... / I must go down to the seas again, to the vagrant gypsy life,</i>	The same words open all three stanzas (lines 1, 5 and 9). "And all I ask is" also begins lines 2, 7 and 11.
Repetition	<i>Is a wild call and a clear call that may not be denied;</i>	call is said three times with line 5 - the pull of the sea is too strong to refuse.
Assonance	<i>And a grey mist on the sea's face, and a grey dawn breaking.</i>	The long a vowel sound repeats: grey, face, grey, breaking (see 4.5).
Polysyndeton	<i>And the flung spray and the blown spume, and the sea-gulls crying.</i>	Many ands pile up the sights and sounds of the sea (spume = sea foam); line 3 works the same way (see 4.23).

MOST LIKELY ASKED: "where the wind's like a whetted knife;" → simile (like); "I must go down to the seas again" → anaphora (it opens every stanza); "a star to steer her by;" → alliteration (st). The opening words come at the START of each stanza, so they are anaphora, not a refrain (see 3.6 and 4.22).

5.21 Courage Edgar Albert Guest

In one line: True courage is not a sudden flash of daring but a steady quality deep in the soul, present in good times and bad, through every hour of a person's life.

Form	32 lines in rhyming couplets; the word Courage opens lines 1, 9, 17 and 25, marking groups of eight lines. The poem defines courage mainly by saying what it is NOT; the tone is firm and encouraging. (Compare Team Work, 5.22, by the same poet.)
Rhyme scheme	aabb
Rhyming words	dash - flash; thing - spring; hope - rope; man - plan; resort - sport; call - fall; not - hot; goal - soul; light - sight; trait - wait; blue - do; freed of it - need of it; show - go; defeat - meet; years - tears; deed - creed.

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Alliteration	<i>A daring deed in a moment's flash;</i>	d - d (daring, deed): two neighbouring words begin with the d sound; also s - s in "serve some plan".
Metaphor	<i>It's the breath of life and a strong man's creed.</i>	Courage IS the breath of life (as necessary as breathing) and a creed (a firm belief) - no like or as.
Metaphor	<i>Courage isn't a brilliant dash,</i>	A comparison without like or as, used in the negative: courage is NOT a quick dash. So also "Courage isn't a dazzling light".
Anaphora	<i>It isn't an instantaneous thing / ... / It isn't a creature of flickered hope</i>	It isn't begins lines 3 and 5 (and 11 and 26): the poet lists what courage is not.
Anaphora	<i>It's part of a man when his skies are blue, / It's part of him when he has work to do.</i>	Two lines in a row begin with It's part of (again in line 29). Blue skies = happy times, a metaphor.
Repetition	<i>Courage is more than a daring deed:</i>	daring deed from line 2 returns in the last couplet, and Courage begins lines 1, 9, 17, 25 and 31.
Antithesis	<i>It's written in victory and defeat</i>	Opposites side by side; smiles and tears are set against each other in "Back of his smiles and behind his tears."
Inversion	<i>If he hasn't it now, he will have it not</i>	= he will not have it. Also "The brave man never is freed of it." = is never freed of it.
Climax	<i>It's part of his hours, his days and his years,</i>	Rising order: hours → days → years - courage fills his whole life (see 4.25).

MOST LIKELY ASKED: "A daring deed in a moment's flash;" → alliteration (d); "It's the breath of life and a strong man's creed." → metaphor; "It's part of a man when his skies are blue, / It's part of him when he has work to do." → anaphora. Exam tip: when two lines in a row start with the same words, answer anaphora rather than plain repetition.

5.22 Team Work Edgar Albert Guest

In one line: Personal skill and praise count for less than team spirit; the game of life is won by working with others and helping them succeed.

Form	24 lines; every four lines rhyme abab, and each group of eight lines ends with “the team” (lines 8, 16 and 24). The whole poem pictures life as a game.
Rhyme scheme	abab
Rhyming words	skill - thrill, star - are; play - to-day, scheme - team; great - mate, fame - game; done - won, dream - team; skill - will, do - view; score - o'er, seem - team.

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Alliteration	<i>It's forgetting self till the game is o'er / And fighting for the team.</i>	f - f - f (forgetting, fighting, for): the f sound links the last two lines of the poem.
Metaphor	<i>And it's fine to be counted a star,</i>	A star = an outstanding player who shines above the rest - no like or as.
Metaphor	<i>For there's no lone hand in the game we play,</i>	Life is a game; a lone hand (a card-game term) = playing alone, without partners.
Anaphora	<i>They may sound your praise and call you great, / They may single you out for fame,</i>	Two lines in a row begin with They may : others may praise you and make you famous, but you still need the team.
Repetition	<i>Is to set your mind and set your will</i>	set your is repeated for emphasis. The key word team is repeated too - it ends lines 8, 16 and 24.
Antithesis	<i>For the battle is lost or the battle is won</i>	Lost and won, opposites, in two balanced halves; the battle is is also repeated.
Rhetorical question	<i>And the thing that counts in the world to-day / Is, How do you pull with the team?</i>	Asked to make readers think about themselves, not for a spoken answer.
Inversion	<i>When his chances hopeless seem;</i>	= when his chances seem hopeless (the verb comes last to rhyme with team). Also “Oh, never the work of life is done” = the work of life is never done.
Extended metaphor	<i>But you must work with your running mate / Or you'll never win the game;</i>	The sports picture runs through the whole poem - star, game, running mate, battle, score, goal: life as a game (see 4.27).

MOST LIKELY ASKED: “For the battle is lost or the battle is won” → antithesis (also repetition); “For there's no lone hand in the game we play,” → metaphor (life as a game); “They may sound your praise and call you great, / They may single you out for fame,” → anaphora. Like Courage (5.21), this poem is by Edgar Albert Guest and gives plain, practical advice.

5.23 From a Railway Carriage Robert Louis Stevenson

In one line: From a speeding train the speaker watches fields, animals, people and places rush past - each one seen for a moment and gone forever.

Form	Two stanzas of 8 lines in rhyming couplets; the quick, galloping rhythm suggests the beat of the train's wheels. Stanza 1 shows the rush of speed; stanza 2 picks out single sights (a child, a tramp, a cart, a mill, a river).
Rhyme scheme	aabb
Rhyming words	witches - ditches; battle - cattle; plain - rain; eye - by; scrambles - brambles; gazes - daisies; road - load; river - forever.

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Alliteration	<i>Faster than fairies, faster than witches,</i>	f - f - f (Faster, fairies, faster). The safest single answer for this line; it is also a simile (than) and a hyperbole (see 3.2).
Alliteration	<i>Each a glimpse and gone forever!</i>	g - g (glimpse, gone). The verb is also left out - Each (is) a glimpse - an ellipsis.
Simile	<i>And charging along like troops in a battle,</i>	like : the horses and cattle seem to charge along like soldiers in a battle.
Simile	<i>Fly as thick as driving rain;</i>	as ... as : the sights fly past as thick and fast as heavy rain.
Personification	<i>Painted stations whistle by.</i>	Stations cannot whistle or move; here they seem to whistle and rush past like living things (really it is the train).
Onomatopoeia	<i>Painted stations whistle by.</i>	whistle imitates the sound it names. One line, two figures - learn both.

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Anaphora	<i>Here is a child who clambers and scrambles, / ... / Here is a tramp who stands and gazes;</i>	Here is begins lines 9, 11 and 13: each new sight is pointed out as it flashes past.
Consonance	<i>Bri<u>dg</u>es and houses, he<u>dg</u>es and di<u>tch</u>es;</i>	The dg and tch sounds repeat inside and at the end of the words, not at the start - that is consonance (see 4.6). (The h - h of houses, hedges is a separate alliteration.)
Hyperbole	<i>And ever again, in the wink of an eye,</i>	The scene changes faster than a blink - a deliberate exaggeration of the train's speed (see 4.7).

MOST LIKELY ASKED: “Faster than fairies, faster than witches,” → alliteration (also simile and hyperbole - see 3.2); “Painted stations whistle by.” → personification and onomatopoeia; “Fly as thick as driving rain;” → simile (as ... as).

5.24 Indian Seasons Nisha Dyrene

In one line: A bright word-picture of the seasons in India - hot summer, muddy monsoon, a short, pleasant spring and colourful autumn - drawn through sights, smells and colours.

Form	16 very short lines in four quatrains, one picture per season (summer, monsoon, spring, autumn). The poem paints with nouns and colours rather than long sentences.
Rhyme scheme	abcb
Rhyming words	heat - feet; roads - toads; sweet - seat; brown - down.

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Alliteration	<i>monsoons and mangoes</i>	m - m (monsoons, mangoes). Trap: “short and sweet” is NOT alliteration - sh and s are different sounds.
Alliteration	<i>with sunny smiles</i>	s - s (sunny, smiles); Summer in line 1 adds to the s sound.
Metaphor	<i>in a blaze of heat</i>	A blaze is a bright fire; summer heat is pictured as fire, without like or as.
Personification	<i>with sunny smiles / and dusty feet</i>	Summer comes (line 1) like a visitor, with smiles and dusty feet - a season given a human face and body. Spot it: a season cannot smile or walk; only a person can.
Anaphora	<i>Autumn is English / ... / Autumn is Indian</i>	The same words begin lines 13 and 15, setting the English autumn beside the Indian one.
Imagery	<i>when you can smell the grass / from your garden seat</i>	Appeals to smell; colour imagery follows in “in red, yellow and brown” (see 4.26).

MOST LIKELY ASKED: “with sunny smiles / and dusty feet” → personification (summer as a person); “monsoons and mangoes” → alliteration (m); “Autumn is English” ... “Autumn is Indian” → anaphora.

5.25 A Tragic Story William Makepeace Thackeray

In one line: A comic tale of a sage who wants his pigtail to hang in front of him; however much he turns and spins, it still hangs behind him.

Form	Comic narrative poem of six short stanzas (stanza 3 has 3 lines - some printed versions repeat its first line - and the others 4); every stanza ends with the words “behind him”. A pigtail is a long plait of hair hanging down the back of the head - so of course it can never hang in front.
Rhyme scheme	aaab cccb ddb eebb fffb gggb (refrain “behind him” closes every stanza)
Rhyming words	yore - wore - more; case - place - face; found - round; in - spin - pin; about - out - stout; slack - tack - back; the last line of every stanza ends on him (b).

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Alliteration	<i>He mused upon this curious case,</i>	k - k sound (curious, case); also t - t - t in twist, twirl, tack (stanza 6).
Personification	<i>Alas! Still faithful to his back,</i>	The pigtail is called faithful , like a loyal friend who never leaves his side. Alas! is an exclamation (see 4.19).

Figure	Line from the poem	Clue
Anaphora	<i>And though his efforts never slack, / And though he twist and twirl, and tack,</i>	Two lines in a row begin with And though .
Repetition	<i>Then round and round, and out and in,</i>	round is repeated - the sage spins again and again. The behind him line ending is the poem's biggest repetition (see the refrain row below).
Irony	<i>All day the puzzled sage did spin;</i>	A sage is a wise man, yet he is puzzled and spins all day to move his own pigtail. The title is ironic too: the "tragic" story is really comic (see 4.10).
Inversion	<i>And he a handsome pigtail wore;</i>	= and he wore a handsome pigtail; the verb goes to the end to rhyme with yore and more.
Refrain	<i>Because it hung behind him. / ... / The pigtail hangs behind him.</i>	behind him closes all six stanzas: a refrain, and also an epistrophe because it comes at the END (see 4.21, 4.22). It is NOT anaphora.
Polysyndeton	<i>And right and left and round about, / And up and down and in and out</i>	and seven times in two lines - the endless, useless turning (see 4.23).

MOST LIKELY ASKED: "behind him" at the end of every stanza → refrain / epistrophe (also repetition); "And up and down and in and out" → polysyndeton; "Alas! Still faithful to his back," → personification (and exclamation). The title itself → irony.

6 Do Not Confuse: High-Yield Pairs

Many wrong answers come from mixing up two look-alike figures. This section puts the 14 most-confused groups side by side. For each group: read the table, see the poem line in action, then learn the one-line trick. Revise the six groups marked **HIGH-FREQUENCY** first. The numbers in the table headings point to the full notes in Sections 3 and 4.

EXAM TIP: When two options both look right, first ask what the line is DOING: comparing, sounding, repeating, contrasting, exaggerating, hinting or referring (the seven families in Section 2). Then use the "Test" row of the tables below to pick the exact figure.

6.1 Simile vs Metaphor **HIGH-FREQUENCY**

Basis	Simile (3.2)	Metaphor (3.3)
Meaning	An open comparison of two UNLIKE things using a comparing word.	A hidden comparison: one thing is said to BE another thing, with no comparing word.
Clue words	like as as ... as so ... as as if as though than	No comparing word. Often is are was joins two unlike things, or one word is used in a non-literal sense.
Test	Point to the comparing word, then check that it joins two UNLIKE things. Both yes = simile.	Put "like" in the middle. If it still makes sense as a comparison, the original is a metaphor.
Strength	Softer: A is LIKE B - the two stay separate.	Stronger: A IS B - the two become one.
Easy example	Chennai in May is as hot as an oven.	Chennai in May is an oven.
From the poems	"Like a child at play." (The River); "And charging along like troops in a battle," (From a Railway Carriage)	"She's a lioness; don't mess with her." (I am Every Woman); "the journey will be joy" (Life)

Your eyes are like the diamond bright, but mine are dull as lead!

THE SPIDER AND THE FLY • MARY BOTHAM HOWITT

Simile — two comparing words in one line: eyes **like** diamonds, dull **as** lead. Drop the comparing word ("Your eyes are diamonds") and it turns into a **Metaphor**.

MEMORY TRICK: Simile Says "like"; Metaphor Means "is" - same picture, different grammar.

6.2 Metaphor vs Personification

Basis	Metaphor (3.3)	Personification (3.4)
Meaning	One thing is said to BE another thing - any other thing.	A non-human thing, animal or idea is given human qualities, feelings or actions.

Basis	Metaphor (3.3)	Personification (3.4)
Clue words	"A is B" with a noun that does not literally fit: oven, lioness, bone, children.	Human verbs and adjectives for non-humans: thinks asks smiles whispers sits plays smart
Test	Ask: "A is turned INTO what?" If A is simply called something it is not (an oven, a lioness, a hero), it is a metaphor.	Ask: "Is a non-human doing what only PEOPLE do?" If yes, it is personification.
Easy example	Time is money.	Time waits for no one.
From the poems	<i>"it is bare to the bone."</i> (The House on Elm Street); <i>"And I water'd it in fears,"</i> (A Poison Tree - anger is a tree)	<i>"It plays with your mind."</i> (The House on Elm Street); <i>"My little horse must think it queer"</i> (Stopping by Woods)
If both fit	Personification is a special KIND of metaphor - the "other thing" is always a person. If a thing is made human, the exact answer is Personification.	

*My computer has always been so **brainy and smart** -
It seems to know **mountains** of information by heart.*

MY COMPUTER NEEDS A BREAK • SHANTHINI GOVINDAN

Personification (line 1) — a machine is called **brainy and smart**, like a clever student. **Metaphor** (line 2) — a huge store of facts is called **mountains** (also hyperbole).

MEMORY TRICK: PERSONification turns a thing into a PERSON; a metaphor can turn it into ANYTHING.

6.3 Personification vs Apostrophe **HIGH-FREQUENCY**

Basis	Personification (3.4)	Apostrophe (4.1)
Meaning	Human qualities, feelings or actions are given to a non-human thing, animal or idea. The poet talks ABOUT it.	The poet speaks directly TO someone absent or dead, or to a thing or idea, as if it could hear.
Clue words	Human actions for a thing, in the third person: it he she they	Calling out and second person: O + a name, you thou , often with !
Test	Is the thing DOING something human while the poet describes it?	Is the thing (or absent person) being CALLED and spoken TO?
Easy example	The moon smiled at the sleeping village.	Twinkle, twinkle, little star, / How I wonder what you are!
From the poems	<i>"He gives his harness bells a shake / To ask if there is some mistake."</i> (Stopping by Woods - the horse acts like a person)	<i>"And, O weary, wandering brother, if contentment you would win,"</i> (The Stick-together Families)
Trap	An apostrophe to a thing usually personifies it too (The River). If both are options, answer what the question focuses on: speaking TO it = Apostrophe.	A listener who is PRESENT is not apostrophe: <i>"Doctor, do you think my tired computer wants a holiday?"</i> (My Computer Needs a Break - the doctor is in the room).

River, river, little river!

*Bright **you** sparkle on your way;*

*O'er the yellow pebbles **dancing**,*

THE RIVER • CAROLINE ANN BOWLES

Apostrophe + Personification — the poet calls out to the river and speaks TO it (**you**), though it cannot hear: apostrophe. The river **dancing** over pebbles like a child: personification.

MEMORY TRICK: PERSONification turns a thing into a PERSON (talks ABOUT it); APOSTROPHE POSTs a message TO someone who cannot reply.

6.4 Alliteration vs Assonance vs Consonance **HIGH-FREQUENCY**

Basis	Alliteration (3.1)	Assonance (4.5)	Consonance (4.6)
Meaning	The same BEGINNING consonant sound in two or more nearby words.	The same VOWEL sound repeated in nearby words.	The same CONSONANT sound repeated, usually inside or at the END of nearby words.
Where in the word	Start	Middle (the vowel)	Middle or end

Basis	Alliteration (3.1)	Assonance (4.5)	Consonance (4.6)
Test	Say the line aloud: do the FIRST sounds match? Sound, not spelling: city and sun alliterate; cat and city do not.	Do the VOWEL sounds match? Same letter is not enough: cat and cake do not match (short a, long a).	Do the consonant sounds INSIDE or at the END match? If the repeat is only at the start, call it alliteration.
Easy example	Sita sells sweet sundal at the Marina. (s)	Go slow on the road home. (long o)	Lift the gift and shift it left. (ft)
From the poems	"With forward face and reluctant soul;" (Life - f)	"And a grey mist on the sea's face, and a grey dawn breaking." (Sea Fever - long a)	"Of scorching and choking" (On Killing a Tree - ch)
Trap	"Whose woods" is NOT alliteration: whose begins with an h sound.	Count sounds, not spellings: sweep and easy share the long e sound with different letters.	Consonance and assonance often come together in one line - name the one the question points to.

The only other **sound's** the **sweep**
Of **easy** wind **and** downy flake.

STOPPING BY WOODS ON A SNOWY EVENING • ROBERT FROST

All three in two lines — Alliteration: s at the START (sound's, sweep). **Assonance:** the long e VOWEL inside (sweep, easy). **Consonance:** nd at the END (sound's, wind, and).

MEMORY TRICK: ALL-ITERATION: ALL the words START with the same sound; ASSONANCE = vowels (A-E-I-O-U); CONSONANCE = consonants, mostly at the END.

6.5 Alliteration vs Onomatopoeia

Basis	Alliteration (3.1)	Onomatopoeia (3.5)
Meaning	The same beginning consonant sound repeated in two or more nearby words.	A word that imitates the sound it names.
How many words	At least two words are needed.	One word is enough.
Clue words	Any words - only their FIRST sounds matter, not their meaning.	Sound words: buzz click snap whisper whistle groan moan sigh
Test	Say it aloud: do the first sounds repeat?	Close your eyes and say the word: do you HEAR the thing?
Easy example	Priya picked pink petals. (p)	The pressure cooker whistled; the auto horn went honk, honk.
From the poems	"Down you dash into the sea," (The River - d); "So I had to call in a doctor, double quick." (My Computer Needs a Break - d)	"and give my mouse a click," (My Computer Needs a Break); "With buzzing wings she hung aloft, then near and nearer drew," (The Spider and the Fly)

Speak gently! - **L**ove doth **w**hisper **l**ow

YOUR SPACE • DAVID BATES

Both in one line — Onomatopoeia: **whisper** sounds like soft, breathy speech (one word does the job). **Alliteration:** l at the start of **L**ove and **l**ow (two words share a first sound). Love that whispers is also personification.

MEMORY TRICK: Alliteration needs a TEAM of words with the same first sound; onomatopoeia is ONE word that makes the noise itself.

6.6 Repetition vs Anaphora vs Epistrophe vs Refrain HIGH-FREQUENCY

Basis	Repetition (3.7)	Anaphora (3.6)	Epistrophe (4.21)	Refrain (4.22)
Meaning	A word, phrase or line repeated ANYWHERE for emphasis.	The same word or phrase at the BEGINNING of successive lines or clauses.	The same word or words at the END of successive lines or clauses.	A line or phrase repeated at regular intervals, usually at the end of each stanza.
Position	Anywhere	Start of lines	End of lines	End of stanzas, again and again
Test	Something is said again, and no more exact type fits.	Cover the line endings: do the openings match?	Cover the line openings: do the endings match?	Does it come back stanza after stanza, like a chorus?
Easy example	Water, water, everywhere.	Every day I read, every day I write, every day I improve.	Government of the people, by the people, for the people.	The chorus of a song that returns after every stanza.

Basis	Repetition (3.7)	Anaphora (3.6)	Epistrophe (4.21)	Refrain (4.22)
From the poems	<i>“And miles to go before I sleep, / And miles to go before I sleep.”</i> (Stopping by Woods - a whole line said twice)	<i>“We were taken from the ore-bed and the mine, / We were melted in the furnace and the pit”</i> (The Secret of the Machines)	<i>“The brave man never is freed of it. / He has it when there is no need of it.”</i> (Courage - of it ends both lines)	<i>“Because it hung behind him.” ... “The pigtail hangs behind him.”</i> (A Tragic Story - every stanza; some keys call it epistrophe)
Remember	Anaphora, epistrophe and refrain are all TYPES of repetition - choose the most exact option offered. A whole line said again (Stopping by Woods) stays Repetition: not anaphora, not refrain.			

*And though his efforts never slack,
And though he twist and twirl, and tack,
Alas! Still faithful to his back,
The pigtail hangs behind him.*

A TRAGIC STORY • WILLIAM MAKEPEACE THACKERAY

Anaphora — **And though** begins two lines in a row. **Refrain** — **behind him** ends this stanza and every other stanza of the poem. Both are types of **Repetition**.

MEMORY TRICK: ANaphora is At the stArt; EPIstrophe is at the End; a REFRAIN Returns after every stanza; plain Repetition can sit anywhere.

6.7 Oxymoron vs Paradox vs Antithesis HIGH-FREQUENCY

Basis	Oxymoron (4.3)	Paradox (4.11)	Antithesis (4.12)
Meaning	Two contradictory WORDS placed side by side.	A STATEMENT that seems to contradict itself but contains a truth.	Opposite IDEAS placed side by side in balanced words.
Size	Two words, usually adjective + noun	A whole sentence or idea	Two balanced halves (A ... B)
Is there a contradiction?	Yes - between two touching words.	It only SEEMS so; think again and it is true.	No - only a sharp contrast; both halves are true.
Test	Are the two opposite words TOUCHING?	Does it sound impossible at first, then make sense?	Are two opposites set like a see-saw, in matching grammar?
Easy example	deafening silence; open secret; sweet sorrow	Less is more.	Speech is silver, silence is golden.
From the poems	<i>“and it's empty joy they find,”</i> (The Stick-together Families - empty joy)	<i>“Seeming still, yet still in motion,”</i> (The River)	<i>“I told my wrath, my wrath did end.”</i> vs <i>“I told it not, my wrath did grow.”</i> (A Poison Tree); <i>“For the battle is lost or the battle is won”</i> (Team Work)

Seeming still, yet still in motion.

THE RIVER • CAROLINE ANN BOWLES

Paradox — the deep river looks **still** (not moving), **yet** it is always in **motion**. It sounds impossible but is true. The opposite words are spread across a statement, so it is not an oxymoron, which needs two clashing words side by side (**empty joy**).

MEMORY TRICK: OXY (sharp) + MORON (dull): two clashing WORDS; PARADOX: a whole sentence that seems false but is true; ANTI-thesis: opposites balanced like a see-saw.

6.8 Hyperbole vs Litotes vs Euphemism

Basis	Hyperbole (4.7)	Litotes (4.8)	Euphemism (4.9)
Meaning	Deliberate, obvious exaggeration.	Understatement using a negative: "not" + the opposite idea.	A mild word or phrase for something harsh or unpleasant.
Direction	Makes it BIGGER	Makes it sound SMALLER	Makes it SOFTER
Clue words	Huge numbers and extremes: a thousand times mountains of forever a ton of	not no un- + the opposite: not bad no small unreluctant	Gentle words for death, illness or failure: passed away is no more depart sleep

Basis	Hyperbole (4.7)	Litotes (4.8)	Euphemism (4.9)
Test	Taken literally, is it impossible?	Drop the "not" and use the opposite word: is that the real meaning?	Is a harsh fact hidden behind a polite phrase?
Easy example	I have told you a thousand times!	Your idli is not bad at all. (= very good)	Grandfather passed away last year. (= died)
From the poems	"And inside you can tell it has a ton of space," (The House on Elm Street)	"unreluctant soul" (Life - not unwilling = eager)	"They never, never wake again, who sleep upon your bed!" (The Spider and the Fly - they die)

The sands of life are nearly run,

Let such in peace depart!

YOUR SPACE · DAVID BATES

Euphemism — for old people near death: **in peace depart** = die peacefully. A soft phrase hides a harsh fact; nothing is made bigger (hyperbole) and there is no "not + opposite" (litotes). **The sands of life** is a metaphor from the hourglass.

MEMORY TRICK: HYPERbole goes over the top; LITOTES says "not bad" for "good"; EUPhemism = EU (good) word for a harsh fact.

6.9 Metonymy vs Synecdoche HIGH-FREQUENCY

Basis	Metonymy (4.15)	Synecdoche (4.16)
Meaning	Naming something by a closely ASSOCIATED (linked) thing.	A PART is used for the whole, or the whole for a part.
Link	The named thing is OUTSIDE the real thing but connected to it: worn, used or found with it.	The named thing is a PIECE of the real thing (or the real thing is a piece of it).
Test	Is X a part of Y? NO, only connected = Metonymy.	Is X a part of Y? YES = Synecdoche.
Easy example	The pen is mightier than the sword. (pen = writing; sword = war); The crown ruled the land. (crown = the king)	All hands on deck! (hands = sailors); India won the match. (the whole country for the team: whole for part)
From the poems	"Beneath all uniforms," (No Men are Foreign - uniforms = soldiers)	"Their hands are ours," (No Men are Foreign - hands = workers); "Every soul that touches yours -" (Making Life Worth While - soul = person); "It's the old home roof that shelters all the charm that life can give;" (The Stick-together Families - roof = home)
If both fit	Synecdoche is a special kind of metonymy. When a PART is named, the exact answer is Synecdoche.	

Beneath all uniforms, a single body breathes

NO MEN ARE FOREIGN · JAMES FALCONER KIRKUP

Metonymy — **uniforms** stands for the soldiers who wear them. A uniform is linked to a soldier but is not a part of his body. Compare "Their hands are ours," (5.5): hands ARE a part of the workers, so that line is **Synecdoche**.

MEMORY TRICK: Synecdoche = Some part for the whole; Metonymy = Mention a related thing.

6.10 Irony vs Sarcasm vs Pun

Basis	Irony (4.10)	Sarcasm (4.10)	Pun (4.14)
Meaning	The opposite of what is said or expected: the words mean the opposite (verbal irony), or events turn out the opposite (situational irony).	Bitter verbal irony meant to hurt or mock a person.	A play on two meanings of one word, or on two words that sound alike.
Tone	Can be serious, sad or funny	Sharp and mocking - it stings	Light and clever - it makes you smile
Test	Is the real meaning or result the OPPOSITE of the surface?	Is that opposite aimed at someone, to wound?	Can ONE word be read two ways at the same time?
Easy example	The fire station burned down. / "Lovely weather!" said in a cyclone.	To a friend who is an hour late: "Wow, you are so early!"	A bicycle cannot stand on its own because it is two-tired (too tired).
From the poems	"I'm your servant and friend, / But we ants never borrow; we ants never lend." (The Ant and the Cricket - a self-declared friend who refuses help); the title A Tragic Story for a comic tale	"and dance the winter away." (The Ant and the Cricket - mocking the starving singer)	"Some crickets have four legs, and some have two." (cricket = insect / idle person); "Then my computer caught a virus, and fell very sick," (computer virus / illness)

"You sang, Sir, you say?"

Go then," says the ant, "and *dance the winter away*."

THE ANT AND THE CRICKET • ADAPTED FROM AESOP'S FABLES

Sarcasm — the ant mocks the starving cricket: you sang all summer, so now dance through the winter! It sounds like advice but is meant to sting. A few lines earlier, "I'm your servant and friend," followed by a flat refusal is **irony**; the last line, about crickets with two legs, is a **pun**.

MEMORY TRICK: Irony says the opposite; Sarcasm says the opposite to HURT (irony with teeth); a Pun gives one word two jobs.

6.11 Allusion vs Illusion vs Delusion (vocabulary trap)

Basis	Allusion (4.2)	Illusion	Delusion
Meaning	A brief reference to a well-known person, place, event, story or text.	A false picture: something that LOOKS or SEEMS real but is not (the senses are fooled).	A false BELIEF held firmly even when the facts show it is wrong (the mind is fooled).
Figure of speech?	YES (see 4.2)	NO - an ordinary noun	NO - an ordinary noun
Clue	A famous name or story in a few words: the Bible, the epics, history, literature.	Eyes and senses: a mirage, a magic trick, an optical illusion.	Mind and belief: a false idea a person will not give up.
Easy example	My brother is a real Kumbhakarna on holidays. (the giant of the Ramayana famous for his long sleep)	The water you see far ahead on a hot road is an illusion (a mirage).	He has the delusion that he can pass without studying.
From the poems	"Till it bore an <i>apple bright</i> ." (A Poison Tree - the forbidden fruit of Eden); "Said to them, 'Peace, be still.'" (Your Space - the Bible)	Word sense only: "Seeming still, yet still in motion," (The River) - the river's stillness is an illusion.	Word sense only: "And swore he'd change the <i>pigtail's place</i> ," (A Tragic Story) - the sage's firm false belief is a comic delusion.
Exam use	"Identify the figure of speech"	Vocabulary: The magician created an _____. (illusion)	Vocabulary: He lives under the _____ that he is always right. (delusion)

And it grew both day and night,

Till it bore an *apple bright*.

A POISON TREE • WILLIAM BLAKE

Allusion — the shining apple recalls the forbidden fruit in the Garden of Eden: a famous story brought in with two words. An allusion REFERS; an illusion only fools the eye and a delusion fools the mind — those two are vocabulary words, not figures of speech.

MEMORY TRICK: ALLusion: ALL readers know the story it refers to; ILLusion: the eye is ILL (fooled); DELusion: the mind is DEceived.

6.12 Rhyme vs Rhyme Scheme vs Rhythm

Basis	Rhyme (3.9)	Rhyme scheme (3.8)	Rhythm
Meaning	Words whose last sounds match, usually the words at the end of lines.	The PATTERN of end rhymes in a stanza, marked with small letters a, b, c ...	The BEAT of a line: the pattern of stressed and unstressed syllables.
Your answer looks like	A set of words: know - though - snow	Letters: aaba	Beats: the number of strong stresses, e.g. 4 beats a line
How to find	Read the last word of each line aloud; match the sounds from the last vowel.	First end-sound = a. Same sound again = same letter. New end-sound = next letter.	Read aloud and tap the strong syllables; count the taps in each line.
Easy example	star - are; high - sky	Twinkle, twinkle, little star / How I wonder what you are / Up above the world so high / Like a diamond in the sky = aabb	TWIN-kle, TWIN-kle, LIT-tle STAR = 4 beats
From the poems	lake - shake - mistake - flake (Stopping by Woods); sky - by (Sea Fever)	Stopping by Woods = aaba bbbcb cddc dddd; Life = abbaabba cddcee; The River = abccb	"Faster than fairies, faster than witches," (From a Railway Carriage) - the galloping beat copies the rattle of the train.
Free verse	No Men are Foreign, On Killing a Tree and Making Life Worth While have no regular end rhyme: the answer is "free verse, no rhyme scheme". Free verse has no fixed beat either.		

We can pull and haul and push and lift and **drive**,
 We can print and plough and weave and heat and **light**,
 We can run and race and swim and fly and **dive**,
 We can see and hear and count and read and **write**!

THE SECRET OF THE MACHINES • RUDYARD KIPLING

Rhyme — drive - dive and light - write. **Rhyme scheme** — abab. **Rhythm** — five strong beats in every line (we can PULL and HAUL and PUSH and LIFT and DRIVE), steady like a machine at work.

MEMORY TRICK: Rhyme = the SOUND (words); Rhyme scheme = the PATTERN (letters); Rhythm = the BEAT (claps). New end-sound = new letter.

6.13 Imagery vs Symbolism vs Metaphor

Basis	Imagery (4.26)	Symbolism (4.26)	Metaphor (3.3)
Meaning	Words that appeal to the senses - sight, sound, smell, taste, touch - and paint a picture.	A real object that also STANDS FOR an idea. It stays itself but carries a bigger meaning.	One thing is said to BE another (an implied comparison).
Question it answers	What do I see, hear, smell, taste or feel?	What does this object stand for?	What is compared to what?
Test	Can you picture it with your senses? Nothing needs to be compared.	Is the object real in the scene, yet pointing to an idea (peace, death, duty)?	Is A called B, though A is not literally B?
Easy example	Golden sand, salty wind and roaring waves at the Marina.	In a story, a lamp burning in a dark hut stands for hope.	Hope is a lamp.
From the poems	"The source, white and wet," (On Killing a Tree - sight, touch); "monsoons and mangoes / leapfrogs and toads" (Indian Seasons - sight)	The apple in A Poison Tree (deceit); the river's journey to the sea in The River (the stages of human life)	"And hope the road's last turn will be the best." (Life - the end of life is the road's last turn)
Key difference	Imagery works on the SENSES; a symbol is a real THING with a hidden meaning; a metaphor needs a COMPARISON. The same lines can show all three (see the card below).		

The woods are **lovely, dark and deep**,
 But I have **promises** to keep,
 And miles to go before I **sleep**.

STOPPING BY WOODS ON A SNOWY EVENING • ROBERT FROST

Imagery — **lovely, dark and deep** lets you SEE the woods. **Symbolism** — the woods stand for rest or temptation, the **promises** for duties. **Metaphor** — **sleep** means death, the long rest at the end of life's journey.

MEMORY TRICK: Imagery = I sense it; Symbol = it Stands for an idea; Metaphor = it Means "is" (a comparison).

6.14 False Similes: when "like" or "as" is not a simile

A true simile needs three things: (1) a comparing word, (2) two UNLIKE things, (3) an imaginative point. "Like" and "as" also do ordinary jobs - as a verb, as "when", as "such as", and in plain measurement - so check all three before you answer Simile.

Sentence	Simile? (Yes / No)	Why
I like idli.	No	"like" is a verb (= enjoy). Nothing is compared.
As I reached home, it rained.	No	"as" means "when" - it only tells the time.
She is as tall as her brother.	No	A plain, literal measurement of two people - no imagination.
Do as I say.	No	"as" means "in the way that" - an order, not a comparison.
Fruits like mango and guava are sweet.	No	"like" means "such as" - it only gives examples.
The ball flew to the boundary like a bullet.	Yes	A cricket ball is compared with a bullet: unlike things, joined by "like".
"Like a child at play." (The River)	Yes	The young, playful river is compared with a child.
"where the wind's like a whetted knife;" (Sea Fever)	Yes	The cutting sea wind is compared with a sharpened knife.

Sentence	Simile? (Yes / No)	Why
"Faster than a cheetah" (The Comet)	Yes	A comet is compared with a cheetah using "than": textbook keys count it as a simile.
"a single body breathes / Like ours" (No Men are Foreign)	Yes (exam key)	People are compared with people, but not to measure them: the point is that the "enemy" breathes just as we do. Exam keys call it a simile - learn it as the exception.

All of the sights of the hill and the plain

Fly **as** thick **as** driving rain;

FROM A RAILWAY CARRIAGE • ROBERT LOUIS STEVENSON

A true "as ... as" simile — the sights flashing past the train are compared with **driving rain**: two UNLIKE things, compared to make a picture. "She is as tall as her brother" uses the same pattern only to measure two people, so it is NOT a simile.

MEMORY TRICK: Before you tick Simile, ask: comparing word? unlike things? imaginative? Three Yes = Simile.

6.15 Master Summary

Pair	The one-line difference
Simile vs Metaphor	Simile compares WITH like / as / than; metaphor says A IS B with no comparing word.
Metaphor vs Personification	A metaphor turns a thing into any other thing; personification turns it into a PERSON.
Personification vs Apostrophe	Personification talks ABOUT a thing as if it were human; apostrophe talks TO someone absent or to a thing (you, O).
Alliteration vs Assonance vs Consonance	Same first consonant sound / same vowel sound / same consonant sound inside or at the end.
Alliteration vs Onomatopoeia	Alliteration repeats first sounds across words; onomatopoeia is one word that sounds like its meaning.
Repetition vs Anaphora vs Epistrophe vs Refrain	Repeated anywhere / at the start of lines / at the end of lines / at the end of every stanza.
Oxymoron vs Paradox vs Antithesis	Two clashing words side by side / a statement that seems false but is true / opposite ideas in balance.
Hyperbole vs Litotes vs Euphemism	Makes it bigger / makes it smaller with "not" / makes a harsh fact softer.
Metonymy vs Synecdoche	Metonymy names a linked thing (uniforms = soldiers); synecdoche names a part for the whole (hands = workers).
Irony vs Sarcasm vs Pun	The opposite meaning / the opposite meaning used to hurt / one word with two meanings.
Allusion vs Illusion vs Delusion	Allusion refers to a famous story (a figure of speech); illusion fools the eye and delusion fools the mind (vocabulary only).
Rhyme vs Rhyme Scheme vs Rhythm	Matching end sounds (words) / the pattern of those sounds (letters) / the beat of the line (stresses).
Imagery vs Symbolism vs Metaphor	Appeals to the senses / a real object standing for an idea / one thing called another.
True simile vs False simile	A true simile compares two unlike things imaginatively; "I like idli", "As I reached home" and "as tall as her brother" are not similes.

MUST REMEMBER: When two options both fit, choose the MORE EXACT one: Personification over Metaphor, Anaphora over Repetition, Synecdoche over Metonymy when a PART is named, Apostrophe when the thing is spoken TO. But a whole line said again (Stopping by Woods) stays Repetition.

MUST REMEMBER: Clue words are hints, not proof. "Like" and "as" can be a verb, "when" or "such as"; opposite words side by side = Oxymoron, spread across a true-but-strange statement = Paradox, balanced halves = Antithesis. Always test the MEANING before you answer.

7 Tricks and the 10-Second Method

This section turns the whole book into quick tools: one mnemonic, a 10-step method, a clue-word dictionary, a trick for every figure, four worked lines with many figures, and an exam-day checklist.

7.1 The master mnemonic

MEMORY TRICK: "A Smart Monkey Plays On A Rainy Rocky Road" = Alliteration, Simile, Metaphor, Personification, Onomatopoeia, Anaphora, Repetition, Rhyme scheme, Rhyming words — the 9 figures named in the 2022 syllabus.

Picture a clever monkey playing on a wet, stony road. Each word gives the first letter of one figure, in this order:

Letter	Word	Figure
A	A	Alliteration (3.1)
S	Smart	Simile (3.2)
M	Monkey	Metaphor (3.3)
P	Plays	Personification (3.4)
O	On	Onomatopoeia (3.5)
A	A	Anaphora (3.6)
R	Rainy	Repetition (3.7)
R	Rocky	Rhyme scheme (3.8)
R	Road	Rhyming words (3.9)

Two helpers. The two A's are both about the START: Alliteration repeats the first SOUND of words; Anaphora repeats the first WORD of lines. The three R's all deal with things that come back: Repetition brings back words; Rhyme scheme and Rhyming words follow the end-sounds that come back.

For the 4 figures of the earlier syllabus, add "Ask All Old Exams" = Apostrophe, Allusion, Oxymoron, Ellipsis (4.1 to 4.4).

7.2 The 10-Second Method

Go down the ten questions in order; the early ones are the quickest to see. Tick every YES, then match your ticks with the options.

Step	Ask yourself	If yes, it is ...
1	Is there a word that copies a sound (buzz, hiss, click, whistle, snap)?	Onomatopoeia (3.5)
2	Do two or more nearby words begin with the same consonant SOUND?	Alliteration (3.1). A vowel sound repeated inside words = Assonance (4.5); a consonant sound repeated inside or at the end = Consonance (4.6).
3	Is like , as , as ... as or than used to compare two UNLIKE things?	Simile (3.2)
4	Is one thing said to BE another (A is B), with no like or as?	Metaphor (3.3). The same comparison carried through many lines = Extended Metaphor (4.27).
5	Is a thing, an animal or an idea thinking, feeling, speaking or acting like a human?	Personification (3.4)
6	Is the speaker talking TO someone absent or dead, or to a thing or an idea, as if it could hear? (O ..., "River, river, little river!")	Apostrophe (4.1)
7	Is the same word or phrase repeated — at the START of lines? at the END? ANYWHERE?	Only the START of lines, the rest changing: Anaphora (3.6). The END of lines: Epistrophe (4.21); a line or phrase closing every stanza: Refrain (4.22). A whole line said again, or a word repeated anywhere: Repetition (3.7).
8	Are opposites joined — two words side by side? two ideas in balanced halves? a statement that seems absurd but is true?	Oxymoron (4.3) / Antithesis (4.12) / Paradox (4.11)
9	Is there an impossible exaggeration? an understatement with "not"? a soft word for a harsh fact?	Hyperbole (4.7) / Litotes (4.8) / Euphemism (4.9)
10	Is there a reference to a famous person, story or text? Are words left out that you can supply?	Allusion (4.2) / Ellipsis (4.4)

Still no YES? Check the rarer figures in 2.2: a question asked for effect (4.18), Oh! or Alas! (4.19), unusual word order (4.20), many "and"s (4.23), an A B / B A cross (4.24), a part for the whole (4.16).

TRY IT

Line: "She's a lioness; don't mess with her." Step 1: no sound-word. Step 2: no repeated first sound. Step 3: no like, as or than. Step 4: YES — a woman is said to BE a lioness. Steps 5 to

10: nothing more. Answer: **Metaphor** (3.3). When two or more steps say YES, go to 7.5.

7.3 Clue-word dictionary

Spot the clue, then check the meaning. A clue word only points to a figure; it does not prove it.

Clue word or pattern	Points to	Easy example
like as as ... as so ... as as if as though comparing two unlike things	Simile (3.2)	She sings like a koel.
than comparing two unlike things	Simile in textbook keys (3.2); check for Hyperbole too (4.7)	Her voice is sweeter than honey.
"like" as a verb, "as" meaning "when", or like compared with like	NOT a simile	I like mangoes. She is as tall as her brother.
is are was joining two unlike things	Metaphor (3.3)	The classroom was a zoo.
human verbs or feelings for things: smiled wept danced thought	Personification (3.4)	The coconut trees danced in the wind.
O + a name; you said to a thing, an idea or someone absent	Apostrophe (4.1)	O Moon, why do you follow me home?
sound words: buzz hiss click tick-tock sizzle whisper	Onomatopoeia (3.5)	The dosa sizzled on the tawa.
the same first consonant SOUND in nearby words	Alliteration (3.1)	Clever kids keep calm. (c and k: one sound)
the same vowel sound inside nearby words	Assonance (4.5)	The rain in Spain stays mainly in the plain.
the same consonant sound inside or at the end of words	Consonance (4.6)	first and last; odds and ends
the same word or words at the START of lines or clauses, the rest changing	Anaphora (3.6)	Work hard, work honestly, work every day.
the same word or words at the END of lines or clauses	Epistrophe (4.21)	of the people, by the people, for the people
a line or phrase that returns at the end of every stanza	Refrain (4.22)	the chorus of a song
a word repeated anywhere, or a whole line said again, for emphasis	Repetition (3.7)	Rain, rain, go away.
and ... and ... and	Polysyndeton (4.23)	We bought idli and dosa and vada and pongal.
a list with commas and no "and"	Asyndeton (4.23)	I came, I saw, I conquered.
A B / B A criss-cross	Chiasmus (4.24)	Eat to live; do not live to eat.
odd word order, e.g. an adjective, a verb or an object placed before the subject	Inversion (4.20)	Sweet is the mango.
... or words that are understood but missing	Ellipsis (4.4)	Some like tea; others, coffee.
two opposite words side by side	Oxymoron (4.3)	deafening silence; sweet sorrow
opposite ideas in balanced halves	Antithesis (4.12)	Speech is silver, silence is golden.
a statement that sounds absurd but is true	Paradox (4.11)	Less is more.
a short, witty, wise saying	Epigram (4.13)	Brevity is the soul of wit.
a thousand times tons of mountains of forever	Hyperbole (4.7)	I have told you a thousand times!
not or un- used to say a positive gently	Litotes (4.8)	Your coffee is not bad. (= good)
passed away no more and other mild words for harsh facts	Euphemism (4.9)	Grandpa passed away last year.
the opposite of what is said or expected	Irony (4.10); bitter, mocking irony = Sarcasm	"What lovely weather!" said during a cyclone.
one word with two meanings	Pun (4.14)	I used to be a banker, but I lost interest.
a ? that needs no answer	Rhetorical Question (4.18)	Who does not love holidays?

Clue word or pattern	Points to	Easy example
Oh! Alas! Hurrah!	Exclamation (4.19)	Alas! We missed the bus.
a famous name, place, story or text	Allusion (4.2)	He is the Kumbhakarna of our hostel.
a closely linked thing used as the name: crown (= king), kettle (= the water in it)	Metonymy (4.15)	The kettle is boiling.
a part for the whole: hands heads wheels roof	Synecdoche (4.16)	All hands on deck!
an adjective that fits a person, given to a thing: sleepless night busy day	Transferred Epithet (4.17)	I spent a sleepless night before the exam.
words of sight, sound, smell, taste and touch	Imagery (4.26)	the smell of hot sambar and the crunch of a crisp dosa
an object that stands for an idea	Symbolism (4.26)	a dove (= peace); a white flag (= surrender)
steps rising to a peak / a sudden fall to something trivial	Climax / Anticlimax (4.25)	He studied, he passed, he topped the state. / He lost his house, his car and his pencil.
one comparison kept up for many lines; a whole story with a moral	Extended Metaphor / Allegory (4.27)	life as a journey (5.1); a fable (5.4)
the last words of lines sound alike	Rhyming Words (3.9)	star - are; high - sky
letters a, b, c ... for the end-sounds	Rhyme Scheme (3.8)	star, are, high, sky = aabb

7.4 Memory tricks for all 36 figures

Figure	Trick
3.1 Alliteration	ALL-ITERATION: ALL the words start with the same SOUND — say it aloud.
3.2 Simile	Simile Says "like"; Metaphor Means "is".
3.3 Metaphor	Metaphor Means "is": no like, no as — one thing simply IS another.
3.4 Personification	PERSONification turns a thing into a PERSON.
3.5 Onomatopoeia	ONOMA (name) + POEIA (making): the word makes the very noise it names — buzz, hiss, click.
3.6 Anaphora	ANaphora is At the stArt; EPIstrophe is at the End.
3.7 Repetition	Repetition is the parent. Anaphora (start), Epistrophe (end) and Refrain (end of every stanza) are its children, named by WHERE the repeat sits. A whole line said again, like “ <i>And miles to go before I sleep</i> ”, stays plain Repetition.
3.8 Rhyme Scheme	New end-sound = new letter; same end-sound = same letter.
3.9 Rhyming Words	Trust the ear, not the eye: friend and end rhyme; cough and though do not.
4.1 Apostrophe	APOSTROPHE POSTs a message to someone who cannot reply.
4.2 Allusion	An ALLUSION ALLUDES (hints) to a famous story or person. Do not mix it up with ILLUSION (a false picture).
4.3 Oxymoron	OXY (sharp) + MORON (dull): the word oxymoron is itself an oxymoron.
4.4 Ellipsis	An ELLIPSIS is an ECLIPSE of words: they are hidden, but you know they are there.
4.5 Assonance	ASSONANCE = vowels (A-E-I-O-U); CONSONANCE = consonants.
4.6 Consonance	CONSONANCE = CONSONANTS, usually inside or at the end of words (first and last).
4.7 Hyperbole	HYPERbole goes over the top.
4.8 Litotes and Understatement	LITOTES says "not bad" for "good"; UNDERSTATEMENT calls Chennai's May heat "a little warm".
4.9 Euphemism	EUphemism = EU (good) word for a harsh fact.
4.10 Irony and Sarcasm	IRONY says the opposite; SARCASM bites — its Greek root means "to tear flesh".
4.11 Paradox	PARA (against) + DOX (opinion): it goes against common sense, yet it is true (Less is more).
4.12 Antithesis	ANTI-thesis: two opposite ideas balanced like a see-saw.
4.13 Epigram	An EPIGRAM is a tiny telegram of wisdom: short, sharp and witty.
4.14 Pun	A PUN is FUN with one word that has two meanings.
4.15 Metonymy	Metonymy = Mention a related thing.

Figure	Trick
4.16 Synecdoche	Synecdoche = Some part for the whole.
4.17 Transferred Epithet	The night was not sleepless — YOU were.
4.18 Rhetorical Question	A question that carries its own answer: nobody needs to reply.
4.19 Exclamation	EXCLAMATION = a CLAMOUR of feeling: Oh! Alas! Hurrah!
4.20 Inversion	INVERSION turns the order round: "Sweet is the mango", not "The mango is sweet".
4.21 Epistrophe	EPistrophe is at the End.
4.22 Refrain	A REFRAIN RETURNS like a chorus at the end of every stanza.
4.23 Polysyndeton and Asyndeton	POLY = many "and"s; A = without "and".
4.24 Chiasmus	CHI is the Greek letter X: the words cross over, A B / B A.
4.25 Climax and Anticlimax	CLIMAX (Greek for "ladder") climbs the ladder; ANTICLIMAX falls off the last step.
4.26 Imagery and Symbolism	IMAGERY paints an IMAGE through the five senses; a SYMBOL is a sign for an idea (dove = peace).
4.27 Extended Metaphor and Allegory	An EXTENDED metaphor keeps walking line after line; an ALLEGORY is a whole STORY with a hidden lesson.

7.5 When one line has many figures

Good poetry often packs several figures into one line. List them all, then choose the one the question points to.

Faster than fairies, faster than witches,

FROM A RAILWAY CARRIAGE • ROBERT LOUIS STEVENSON

Present: **Alliteration** (the f sound in Faster, fairies, faster, 3.1); **Simile** (the speed is compared with fairies and witches using **than** ; textbook keys count this as a simile, 3.2); **Hyperbole** (no train is really faster than fairies, 4.7); **Repetition** ("faster than" comes twice, 3.7). **Choose:** ALLITERATION is the safest single answer. If Alliteration is not offered, choose Simile. Choose Hyperbole only when the question asks about exaggeration.

River, river, little river!

Bright you sparkle on your way;

THE RIVER • CAROLINE ANN BOWLES

Present: **Apostrophe** (the poet speaks directly TO the river and calls it "you", as if it could hear, 4.1); **Personification** (the river is treated as a living being going on its way, 3.4); **Repetition** ("river" three times in line 1, 3.7). **Choose:** if an option reads "Apostrophe and Personification", take it. For the address in line 1, choose APOSTROPHE. If Apostrophe is not offered, choose PERSONIFICATION. Choose Repetition only when the question asks about the repeated word.

We can pull and haul and push and lift and drive,

THE SECRET OF THE MACHINES • RUDYARD KIPLING

Present: **Polysyndeton** (and ... and ... and ... and, 4.23); **Anaphora** (the line opens with "We can", and so do the next three lines, such as "We can print and plough and weave and heat and light," 3.6); **Personification** (the machines speak as "We", 3.4); a weak p-alliteration (pull, push) that is not the one to choose. **Choose:** ANAPHORA when two or more "We can" lines are quoted; POLYSYNDETON when only this line is quoted and it is offered, or when the question points to the many "and"s; PERSONIFICATION when the question asks how the machines are presented.

To the gull's way and the whale's way where the wind's like a whettet knife;

SEA FEVER • JOHN MASEFIELD

Present: **Simile** (the sharp, cutting wind is compared with a whetted, that is sharpened, knife using **like** , 3.2); **Alliteration** (the w sound in way, whale's, way, where, wind's, whetted, 3.1); **Repetition** ("way" twice, 3.7); **Imagery** (you can feel the wind cut, 4.26). **Choose:** SIMILE when the question is about the wind or the comparison; ALLITERATION when it is about sound or the w-words. If the whole line is quoted, both are offered and the stem gives no hint, choose SIMILE: "like" comparing two unlike things makes it certain. (In the first card the only comparing word was "than", so Alliteration was safer there.)

EXAM TIP: Underline the words the question quotes or points to; the figure it wants lives in those words. When two answers still fit, prefer the one that is beyond doubt (a clear like or as, an O-address, a sound-word, a plain f-f-f) over one you would have to argue for.

7.6 Exam-day checklist

1. Read the stem twice. Is it "identify the figure", "rhyming words", "rhyme scheme", "match", or "which is NOT"?
2. Read the quoted line aloud in your mind: sound figures need the ear, not the eye.
3. Circle the clue words: like, as, than, is, O, I, ?, and ... and, not (7.3).
4. Run the 10-Second Method (7.2) and tick every figure that fits.
5. Match your ticks with the options; choose what the question points to (7.5).
6. Watch the traps: "like" or "as" without an unlike comparison is not a simile; the same LETTER is not always the same SOUND.
7. For a rhyme scheme, write the last word of each line first, then the letters: same end-sound = same letter, new end-sound = new letter.
8. Place the line in its poem (1.2). Knowing the poem's usual figures (Section 5) confirms your answer.

8 Practice Questions

All 88 questions in this section are **PYQ-style**: they are modelled on the usual exam patterns, but they are NOT actual previous-year questions. Most of them quote a line from the 25 syllabus poems (see Section 5); a few use everyday sentences. Every MCQ has only ONE correct option. Try each question first, then open **Answer** to check the key and the clue words. Use the 10-second method of Section 7: find the clue first, then choose. For the current exam pattern, always check the latest official notification.

8.1 Identify the Figure of Speech (40)

EXAM TIP: Find the clue before you read the options: **like** / **as** / **than** = simile; "is" without like/as = metaphor; same first SOUND = alliteration; same first WORD of lines = anaphora; a sound word = onomatopoeia; a thing that thinks or feels = personification.

MCQ1. Identify the figure of speech in this line from *Life*: "Let me but live my life from year to year," (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Alliteration
- c. Onomatopoeia
- d. Oxymoron

Answer: (b) - Alliteration: the "l" sound begins "Let", "live" and "life" (see 5.1). Say it aloud: alliteration is about the first SOUND.

MCQ2. Identify the figure of speech in this line from *From a Railway Carriage*: "And charging along like troops in a battle," (PYQ-style)

- a. Metaphor
- b. Onomatopoeia
- c. Oxymoron
- d. Simile

Answer: (d) - Simile: the clue word "like" compares the rushing scene to troops charging in a battle. Not metaphor - the comparing word is there (see 5.23).

MCQ3. Identify the figure of speech in this line from *I am Every Woman*: "She's a lioness; don't mess with her." (PYQ-style)

- a. Metaphor
- b. Simile
- c. Onomatopoeia
- d. Apostrophe

Answer: (a) - Metaphor: the woman is said to BE "a lioness" - an implied comparison with no "like" or "as" (see 5.2). Trap: "She is like a lioness" would be a simile.

MCQ4. Identify the figure of speech in this line from *Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening*: “My little horse must think it queer” (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Onomatopoeia
- c. Personification
- d. Hyperbole

Answer: (c) - Personification: the horse is given a human action - it "must think" that the stop is strange (see 5.7). Trap: a horse that runs is not personification; a horse that THINKS is.

MCQ5. Identify the figure of speech in this line from *My Computer Needs a Break*: “If I type in a question, and give my mouse a click,” (PYQ-style)

- a. Oxymoron
- b. Simile
- c. Onomatopoeia
- d. Litotes

Answer: (c) - Onomatopoeia: the word "click" imitates the sound it names (see 5.18).

MCQ6. Identify the figure of speech in these lines from *The Stick-together Families*: “Each goes searching after pleasure in his own selected way, / Each with strangers likes to wander, and with strangers likes to play.” (PYQ-style)

- a. Anaphora
- b. Oxymoron
- c. Onomatopoeia
- d. Euphemism

Answer: (a) - Anaphora: the same word "Each" begins two successive lines (see 5.13). Anaphora is one type of repetition; for the same word at the START of lines, choose anaphora.

MCQ7. Identify the figure of speech in the closing lines of *Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening*: “And miles to go before I sleep, / And miles to go before I sleep.” (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Onomatopoeia
- c. Oxymoron
- d. Repetition

Answer: (d) - Repetition: the whole line “And miles to go before I sleep” is said twice for emphasis. The textbook answer is repetition, not anaphora (see 5.7).

MCQ8. The letters a, a, b, b can be written after these four lines from *From a Railway Carriage*. What do these letters show? (PYQ-style)

“Here is a child who clambers and scrambles,”
“All by himself and gathering brambles;”
“Here is a tramp who stands and gazes;”
“And there is the green for stringing the daisies!”

- a. Refrain
- b. Rhyme scheme
- c. Oxymoron
- d. Euphemism

Answer: (b) - Rhyme scheme: the letters mark the pattern of end rhymes - scrambles - brambles (a a), gazes - daisies (b b) = aabb (see 3.8, 5.23).

MCQ9. Lines 2 and 4 of *Indian Seasons* are “in a blaze of heat” and “and dusty feet”. The words “heat” and “feet” are an example of: (PYQ-style)

- a. Rhyming words
- b. Onomatopoeia
- c. Simile
- d. Oxymoron

Answer: (a) - Rhyming words: “heat” and “feet” end with the same sound (-eet); only lines 2 and 4 rhyme, so the stanza is abcb (see 3.9, 5.24). Trap: “heat - feet” are the rhyming words; the letter pattern abcb is the rhyme scheme.

MCQ10. Identify the figures of speech in these lines from *The River*: “River, river, little river! / Bright you sparkle on your way;” (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile and Metaphor
- b. Oxymoron and Pun
- c. Litotes and Euphemism
- d. Apostrophe and Personification

Answer: (d) - Apostrophe and Personification: the poet speaks directly to the river, calling it “you” as if it could hear, and gives it the life of a person travelling “on your way” (see 4.1, 5.11).

MCQ11. Identify the figure of speech in this line from *A Poison Tree*: “Till it bore an apple bright.” (PYQ-style)

- a. Onomatopoeia
- b. Allusion
- c. Simile
- d. Litotes

Answer: (b) - Allusion: the “apple” recalls the forbidden fruit in the Garden of Eden (the Bible) - a brief reference to a well-known story (see 4.2, 5.8). An allusion works only if the reader knows the story it points to.

MCQ12. Identify the figure of speech in these words from *The Stick-together Families*: “and it's empty joy they find,” (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Onomatopoeia
- c. Oxymoron
- d. Litotes

Answer: (c) - Oxymoron: two contradictory words, “empty” and “joy”, stand side by side (see 4.3, 5.13). Trap: a whole statement that seems false but is true is a paradox (see 4.11); an oxymoron is just two clashing words.

MCQ13. Identify the figure of speech in this line from *A Tragic Story*: “And though he twist and twirl, and tack,” (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Oxymoron
- c. Euphemism
- d. Alliteration

Answer: (d) - Alliteration: the “t” sound begins “twist”, “twirl” and “tack” (“though” starts with a different “th” sound) (see 5.25).

MCQ14. Identify the figure of speech in these lines from *The Ant and the Cricket*: “Not a crumb to be found / On the snow-covered ground;” (PYQ-style)

- a. Ellipsis
- b. Simile
- c. Oxymoron
- d. Onomatopoeia

Answer: (a) - Ellipsis: the words “There was” are left out (There was not a crumb to be found ...); the reader supplies them (see 4.4, 5.4). The mark ... that shows missing words is also called an ellipsis.

MCQ15. Identify the figure of speech in this line from *The Spider and the Fly*: “Your eyes are like the diamond bright, but mine are dull as lead!” (PYQ-style)

- a. Onomatopoeia
- b. Simile
- c. Euphemism
- d. Pun

Answer: (b) - Simile: two open comparisons with clue words - “like the diamond bright” and “dull as lead” (see 5.10).

MCQ16. Identify the figure of speech: "I have told you a thousand times to switch off the fan before you leave the room." (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Onomatopoeia
- c. Hyperbole
- d. Euphemism

Answer: (c) - Hyperbole: "a thousand times" is an obvious exaggeration used for effect (see 4.7). Hyperbole is not a lie - nobody is meant to believe it literally.

MCQ17. Identify the figure of speech in the last line of *Life*: “And hope the road's last turn will be the best.” (PYQ-style)

- a. Metaphor
- b. Simile
- c. Onomatopoeia
- d. Apostrophe

Answer: (a) - Metaphor: “the road's last turn” means the last stage of life - life is treated as a road, with no "like" or "as" (see 5.1).

MCQ18. Identify the figure of speech: "The fire station itself caught fire last night." (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Onomatopoeia
- c. Apostrophe
- d. Irony

Answer: (d) - Irony (situational): "fire station ... caught fire" - the opposite of what we expect happens to the very place that puts out fires (see 4.10). Trap: sarcasm is bitter verbal irony meant to hurt; this is irony of situation.

MCQ19. Identify the figure of speech in this line from *The House on Elm Street*: “At night the house seems to be alive,” (PYQ-style)

- a. Onomatopoeia
- b. Oxymoron
- c. Personification
- d. Litotes

Answer: (c) - Personification: a lifeless house is given life - it “seems to be alive” (see 5.6). Trap: "seems" is not a comparing word, so this is not a simile.

MCQ20. Identify the figure of speech in the last line of *The Ant and the Cricket*: “Some crickets have four legs, and some have two.” (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Pun
- c. Onomatopoeia
- d. Oxymoron

Answer: (b) - Pun: "crickets" has two meanings - the insect of the fable (four legs) and careless, idle people (two legs) (see 4.14, 5.4).

MCQ21. Identify the figure of speech in these words from *I am Every Woman*: “Despite the sighs and groans and moans,” (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Metaphor
- c. Apostrophe
- d. Onomatopoeia

Answer: (d) - Onomatopoeia: "sighs", "groans" and "moans" imitate the sounds they name (see 5.2).

MCQ22. Identify the figure of speech in this line from *Courage*: “It's written in victory and defeat” (PYQ-style)

- a. Antithesis
- b. Simile
- c. Onomatopoeia
- d. Pun

Answer: (a) - Antithesis: opposite ideas, "victory" and "defeat", are placed side by side in balance (see 4.12, 5.21). Trap: not oxymoron - these are two separate ideas joined by "and", not one clashing phrase like "empty joy".

MCQ23. Identify the figure of speech in these lines from *Making Life Worth While*: “One bit of courage / For the darkening sky; / One gleam of faith / To brave the thickening ills of life;” (PYQ-style)

- a. Onomatopoeia
- b. Pun
- c. Anaphora
- d. Oxymoron

Answer: (c) - Anaphora: the same word "One" begins successive phrases (One bit ... One gleam ...) (see 5.15).

MCQ24. Identify the figure of speech in these words from *The Stick-together Families*: “when the busy day is done,” (PYQ-style)

- a. Onomatopoeia
- b. Transferred epithet
- c. Simile
- d. Allusion

Answer: (b) - Transferred epithet: "busy" really describes the people, but it is transferred to the "day" (see 4.17, 5.13). Memory trick: the day was not busy - the people were.

MCQ25. Identify the figure of speech in these words from *The Spider and the Fly*: “‘Oh no, no,’ said the little Fly” (PYQ-style)

- a. Repetition
- b. Simile
- c. Oxymoron
- d. Allusion

Answer: (a) - Repetition: the word "no" is repeated to stress the Fly's firm refusal (see 5.10).

MCQ26. In these words from *No Men are Foreign*, the word "uniforms" stands for soldiers: “Beneath all uniforms,” Identify the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

- a. Hyperbole
- b. Onomatopoeia
- c. Oxymoron
- d. Metonymy

Answer: (d) - Metonymy: "uniforms", a thing closely linked with soldiers, is used to name the soldiers themselves (see 4.15, 5.5). Trap: synecdoche uses a PART (hands, soul); metonymy uses a LINKED thing (uniforms).

MCQ27. In these lines from *Your Space*, "far" rhymes with "mar" and "fear" with "here". What is this pattern of end rhymes (abab) called? (PYQ-style)

"Speak gently! - It is better far"

"To rule by love, than fear"

"Speak gently - let not harsh words mar"

"The good we might do here!"

- a. Euphemism
- b. Rhyme scheme
- c. Onomatopoeia
- d. Oxymoron

Answer: (b) - Rhyme scheme: the pattern of end rhymes is shown with letters - far - mar (a), fear - here (b) = abab (see 3.8, 5.19).

MCQ28. Identify the figure of speech in this line from *Making Life Worth While*: "Every soul that touches yours -" (PYQ-style)

- a. Onomatopoeia
- b. Simile
- c. Synecdoche
- d. Litotes

Answer: (c) - Synecdoche: "soul", a part, stands for the whole person (see 4.16, 5.15). Trap: a soul is part of a person, so this is synecdoche, not metonymy.

MCQ29. In these lines from *A Tragic Story*, the words "case" and "place" are an example of: "He mused upon this curious case, / And swore he'd change the pigtail's place," (PYQ-style)

- a. Onomatopoeia
- b. Simile
- c. Rhyming words
- d. Euphemism

Answer: (c) - Rhyming words: "case" and "place" end two lines with the same sound (-ace) (see 3.9, 5.25).

MCQ30. Identify the figure of speech in the first line of *Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening*: "Whose woods these are I think I know." (PYQ-style)

- a. Inversion
- b. Simile
- c. Onomatopoeia
- d. Hyperbole

Answer: (a) - Inversion: the normal order (I think I know whose woods these are) is reversed. Note: "Whose woods" is NOT alliteration - "whose" begins with an h sound (see 4.20, 5.7).

MCQ31. The word "unreluctant" in this line from *Life* is an example of: "With forward face and unreluctant soul;" (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Oxymoron
- c. Onomatopoeia
- d. Litotes

Answer: (d) - Litotes: "unreluctant" (not unwilling) means eager - a positive idea said through a negative (see 4.8, 5.1). Trap: not oxymoron - nothing in "unreluctant soul" contradicts.

MCQ32. In *Your Space*, the poet says this about the aged: “*Let such in peace depart!*” Identify the figure of speech in “depart”. (PYQ-style)

- a. Onomatopoeia
- b. Euphemism
- c. Simile
- d. Oxymoron

Answer: (b) - Euphemism: “depart” is a mild word for “die” (see 4.9, 5.19). Other euphemisms for death: passed away, no more.

MCQ33. Identify the figure of speech in these words from *Indian Seasons*: “*monsoons and mangoes*” (PYQ-style)

- a. Alliteration
- b. Simile
- c. Oxymoron
- d. Euphemism

Answer: (a) - Alliteration: the “m” sound begins “monsoons” and “mangoes” (see 5.24).

MCQ34. Identify the figure of speech in this line from *The Comet*: “*Faster than a cheetah*” (PYQ-style)

- a. Metaphor
- b. Onomatopoeia
- c. Simile
- d. Litotes

Answer: (c) - Simile: the comet is compared to a cheetah with “faster than”; textbook keys count a “than” comparison as a simile (see 3.2, 5.12).

MCQ35. Identify the figure of speech in this line from *On Killing a Tree*: “*And out of its leperous hide*” (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Onomatopoeia
- c. Apostrophe
- d. Metaphor

Answer: (d) - Metaphor: the rough bark is called a “leperous hide” (a diseased skin) - an implied comparison with no “like” or “as” (see 5.9). Trap: “like a leper’s skin” would make it a simile.

MCQ36. Identify the figure of speech: “The pressure cooker hissed and whistled in the kitchen.” (PYQ-style)

- a. Simile
- b. Onomatopoeia
- c. Metaphor
- d. Oxymoron

Answer: (b) - Onomatopoeia: “hissed” and “whistled” imitate the sounds they name (see 3.5). Other sound words: buzz, click, honk, snap, whisper.

MCQ37. Identify the figure of speech in these lines from *Courage*: “*It’s part of a man when his skies are blue, / It’s part of him when he has work to do.*” (PYQ-style)

- a. Onomatopoeia
- b. Oxymoron
- c. Anaphora
- d. Simile

Answer: (c) - Anaphora: the same words “It’s part of” begin two successive lines (see 3.6, 5.21).

MCQ38. Identify the figure of speech in this line from *I am Every Woman*: “She’s today’s woman. Today’s woman, dear.” (PYQ-style)

- a. Repetition
- b. Simile
- c. Onomatopoeia
- d. Litotes

Answer: (a) - Repetition: "today's woman" is said twice for emphasis (see 3.7, 5.2).

MCQ39. The end words of these lines from *The Secret of the Machines* are mine - pit - design - fit, which gives the pattern abab. Name this device. (PYQ-style)

“We were taken from the ore-bed and the mine,”

“We were melted in the furnace and the pit”

“We were cast and wrought and hammered to design,”

“We were cut and filed and tooled and gauged to fit.”

- a. Oxymoron
- b. Euphemism
- c. Pun
- d. Rhyme scheme

Answer: (d) - Rhyme scheme: the letters show the pattern of end rhymes - mine - design (a), pit - fit (b) = abab (see 3.8, 5.3).

MCQ40. In these lines from *Sea Fever*, the words "shaking" and "breaking" are an example of: “And the wheel’s kick and the wind’s song and the white sail’s shaking, / And a grey mist on the sea’s face, and a grey dawn breaking.” (PYQ-style)

- a. Oxymoron
- b. Rhyming words
- c. Euphemism
- d. Simile

Answer: (b) - Rhyming words: "shaking" and "breaking" end two lines with the same sound (-aking) (see 3.9, 5.20).

DO NOT CONFUSE: Anaphora vs Repetition - the same word at the START of successive lines or clauses is anaphora (MCQ6, MCQ23, MCQ37); a whole line said again is repetition (MCQ7). Metonymy vs Synecdoche - a linked thing (MCQ26) vs a part for the whole (MCQ28). Rhyme scheme vs Rhyming words - the letter pattern (MCQ8, MCQ27, MCQ39) vs the words that rhyme (MCQ9, MCQ29, MCQ40). More pairs: see Section 6.

8.2 Rhyme Scheme and Rhyming Words (12)

EXAM TIP: Look only at the LAST word of each line. The first end-sound is "a"; the same sound gets the same letter; a new end-sound gets the next letter (see 3.8, 3.9). Near rhymes such as arms - harm are accepted in textbook answers.

RS1. What is the rhyme scheme of the first stanza of *Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening*? (PYQ-style)

“Whose woods these are I think I know.”

“His house is in the village though;”

“He will not see me stopping here”

“To watch his woods fill up with snow.”

- a. abab
- b. aabb
- c. aaba
- d. abcb

Answer: (c) - aaba: know - though - snow share one end sound (a); "here" is a new sound (b). The whole poem runs aaba bbbcb ccddc dddd: the odd sound of one stanza ("here") becomes the main rhyme of the next (queer - near - year) (see 5.7).

RS2. Pick out the rhyming words and write the rhyme scheme of these lines from *A Poison Tree*. (PYQ-style)

"I was angry with my friend;"

"I told my wrath, my wrath did end."

"I was angry with my foe;"

"I told it not, my wrath did grow."

Answer: Rhyming words: friend - end, foe - grow. Rhyme scheme: aabb (rhyming couplets). The whole poem follows aabb (see 5.8).

RS3. What is the rhyme scheme of these opening lines of the sonnet *Life* by Henry Van Dyke? (PYQ-style)

"Let me but live my life from year to year,"

"With forward face and unreluctant soul;"

"Not hurrying to, nor turning from the goal;"

"Not mourning for the things that disappear"

a. abab

b. abba

c. aabb

d. abcb

Answer: (b) - abba: year - disappear (a), soul - goal (b). The full 14-line sonnet is abbaabba cddcee (see 5.1).

RS4. Each stanza of *The River* (Caroline Ann Bowles) has five lines. The end words of stanza 1 are: river, way, dancing, glancing, play. What is the rhyme scheme? (PYQ-style)

a. abccb

b. aabba

c. abcbc

d. ababb

Answer: (a) - abccb: river (a), way (b), dancing - glancing (c c), play (b again, rhyming with way). Every stanza follows abccb (smooth - youth, time - prime, sea - eternity) (see 5.11).

RS5. Write the rhyme scheme and pick out the rhyming words in the opening lines of *Team Work*. (PYQ-style)

"It's all very well to have courage and skill"

"And it's fine to be counted a star,"

"But the single deed with its touch of thrill"

"Doesn't tell the man you are;"

Answer: Rhyme scheme: abab. Rhyming words: skill - thrill (lines 1 and 3), star - are (lines 2 and 4). The whole poem keeps abab, e.g. play - to-day, scheme - team (see 5.22).

RS6. What is the rhyme scheme of the first stanza of *A Tragic Story*? (PYQ-style)

"There lived a sage in days of yore,"

"And he a handsome pigtail wore;"

"But wondered much and sorrowed more,"

"Because it hung behind him."

a. aabb

b. abab

c. aaba

d. aaab

Answer: (d) - aaab: yore - wore - more (a a a); "him" is a new sound (b). The refrain "behind him" closes every stanza, so the whole poem runs aaab cccb ddb eebb fffb gggb (see 5.25).

RS7. Pick out the rhyming words in these lines from *My Computer Needs a Break*. What is the rhyme scheme of the poem? (PYQ-style)

"My computer has always been so brainy and smart -"

"It seems to know mountains of information by heart."

Answer: Rhyming words: smart - heart. Rhyme scheme: aabb - the poem rhymes in couplets all through (click - quick, sick - quick, say - holiday) (see 5.18).

RS8. Which of these poems is written in free verse, with no rhyme scheme? (PYQ-style)

- a. A Poison Tree
- b. Sea Fever
- c. On Killing a Tree
- d. Team Work

Answer: (c) - On Killing a Tree has no regular end rhyme. The other free-verse poems are No Men are Foreign and Making Life Worth While; I am Every Woman and The House on Elm Street have scattered rhymes but no regular scheme. A Poison Tree and Sea Fever are aabb; Team Work is abab (see 5.9).

RS9. Pick out the rhyming words and write the rhyme scheme of these lines from *Courage*. (PYQ-style)

“*Courage isn't a brilliant dash,*”
“*A daring deed in a moment's flash;*”
“*It isn't an instantaneous thing*”
“*Born of despair with a sudden spring*”

Answer: Rhyming words: dash - flash, thing - spring. Rhyme scheme: aabb - the whole poem is in rhyming couplets (see 5.21).

RS10. In which pair of poems do only the 2nd and 4th lines of each stanza rhyme (rhyme scheme abcb)? (PYQ-style)

- a. The Comet and Indian Seasons
- b. A Poison Tree and Sea Fever
- c. Team Work and Your Space
- d. The River and Life

Answer: (a) - The Comet (night - flight, long - strong) and Indian Seasons (heat - feet, roads - toads) are both abcb. Pair (b) is aabb, pair (c) is abab, and pair (d) is abccb and abbaabba cddcee. Special Hero and the verses of Lessons in Life are also abcb (see 5.12, 5.24).

RS11. Write the rhyme scheme and the rhyming words of these opening lines of *A Thing of Beauty*. (PYQ-style)

“*A thing of beauty is a joy for ever:*”
“*Its loveliness increases; it will never*”
“*Pass into nothingness; but still will keep*”
“*A bower quiet for us, and a sleep*”

Answer: Rhyme scheme: aabb. Rhyming words: ever - never, keep - sleep. Keats writes in heroic couplets (pairs of rhyming lines) all through the extract (see 5.16).

RS12. These are lines 2 and 4 of the first stanza of *Special Hero*. Pick out the rhyming words. What is the rhyme scheme of the poem? (PYQ-style)

“*you would hold me in your arms.*”
“*keeping me safe from harm.*”

Answer: Rhyming words: arms - harm (a near rhyme, accepted in textbook answers). Rhyme scheme: abcb - only lines 2 and 4 of each stanza rhyme (e.g. see - me, love - above) (see 5.14).

MUST REMEMBER: Write these four schemes exactly as the key does - Stopping by Woods: aaba bbbcb cddc dddd; Life: abbaabba cddcee; The River: abccb; A Tragic Story: aaab cccb ddb eebb fffb gggb. No rhyme scheme (free verse): No Men are Foreign, On Killing a Tree, Making Life Worth While.

8.3 Match the Following (10)

EXAM TIP: Fix the one or two pairs you are surest of, then strike out every option that does not contain them. Usually only one option survives.

M1. Match List I with List II: (PYQ-style)

List I (Line)	List II (Figure of speech)
A. "Fly as thick as driving rain;"	1. Personification
B. "For there's no lone hand in the game we play,"	2. Simile
C. "And pulled out - snapped out"	3. Onomatopoeia
D. "Rampaging through the heavens"	4. Metaphor

- a. A-4, B-2, C-1, D-3
- b. A-2, B-3, C-4, D-1
- c. A-2, B-4, C-3, D-1
- d. A-3, B-4, C-2, D-1

Answer: (c) - A-2 Simile ("as thick as"); B-4 Metaphor (life is "the game we play", no like/as); C-3 Onomatopoeia ("snapped"); D-1 Personification (the comet is "rampaging", like an angry person running wild).

M2. Match List I with List II: (PYQ-style)

List I (Poem)	List II (Poet)
A. Life	1. William Blake
B. A Poison Tree	2. Gieve Patel
C. Sea Fever	3. Henry Van Dyke
D. On Killing a Tree	4. John Masefield

- a. A-3, B-1, C-4, D-2
- b. A-1, B-3, C-4, D-2
- c. A-3, B-4, C-1, D-2
- d. A-2, B-1, C-4, D-3

Answer: (a) - A-3 Life: Henry Van Dyke; B-1 A Poison Tree: William Blake; C-4 Sea Fever: John Masefield; D-2 On Killing a Tree: Gieve Patel.

M3. Match List I with List II: (PYQ-style)

List I (Poem)	List II (Rhyme scheme)
A. Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening	1. abab
B. The River	2. aabb
C. Team Work	3. abccb
D. A Poison Tree	4. aaba bbbcb ccdd dddd

- a. A-4, B-1, C-3, D-2
- b. A-3, B-4, C-1, D-2
- c. A-4, B-3, C-2, D-1
- d. A-4, B-3, C-1, D-2

Answer: (d) - A-4 Stopping by Woods: aaba bbbcb ccdd dddd; B-3 The River: abccb (five-line stanzas); C-1 Team Work: abab; D-2 A Poison Tree: aabb.

M4. Match List I with List II: (PYQ-style)

List I (Clue)	List II (Figure of speech)
A. "like", "as ... as"	1. Exclamation
B. "Oh!", "Alas!"	2. Onomatopoeia
C. "buzz", "click", "hiss"	3. Anaphora
D. the same word at the START of successive lines	4. Simile

- a. A-4, B-2, C-1, D-3
- b. A-4, B-1, C-2, D-3
- c. A-1, B-4, C-2, D-3
- d. A-4, B-1, C-3, D-2

Answer: (b) - A-4 like / as ... as = Simile; B-1 Oh! / Alas! = Exclamation; C-2 sound words = Onomatopoeia; D-3 same word at the start = Anaphora.

M5. Match List I with List II: (PYQ-style)

List I (Figure)	List II (Family)
A. Oxymoron	1. Association and reference
B. Onomatopoeia	2. Contrast
C. Synecdoche	3. Exaggeration and understatement
D. Hyperbole	4. Sound

- a. A-2, B-4, C-1, D-3
- b. A-3, B-4, C-1, D-2
- c. A-2, B-1, C-4, D-3
- d. A-4, B-2, C-1, D-3

Answer: (a) - A-2 Oxymoron joins opposite words (Contrast); B-4 Onomatopoeia copies a sound (Sound); C-1 Synecdoche uses a part for the whole (Association and reference); D-3 Hyperbole over-states (Exaggeration and understatement) (see Section 2).

M6. Match List I with List II: (PYQ-style)

List I (Line)	List II (Figure of speech)
A. "They never, never wake again, who sleep upon your bed!"	1. Inversion
B. "Their hands are ours,"	2. Synecdoche
C. "In the morning glad I see,"	3. Paradox
D. "Seeming still, yet still in motion,"	4. Euphemism

- a. A-2, B-4, C-1, D-3
- b. A-4, B-1, C-2, D-3
- c. A-4, B-2, C-1, D-3
- d. A-3, B-2, C-1, D-4

Answer: (c) - A-4 Euphemism ("*never wake again*" = die); B-2 Synecdoche ("hands" = the people who work); C-1 Inversion (word order changed: "*glad I see*" = "I am glad to see"); D-3 Paradox (still, yet moving - it seems impossible but is true of a deep river).

M7. Match List I with List II: (*PYQ-style*)

List I (Poem)	List II (Poet)
A. The Secret of the Machines	1. Robert Louis Stevenson
B. A Thing of Beauty	2. William Makepeace Thackeray
C. From a Railway Carriage	3. Rudyard Kipling
D. A Tragic Story	4. John Keats

- a. A-4, B-3, C-1, D-2
- b. A-3, B-4, C-1, D-2
- c. A-3, B-4, C-2, D-1
- d. A-1, B-4, C-3, D-2

Answer: (b) - A-3 The Secret of the Machines: Rudyard Kipling; B-4 A Thing of Beauty: John Keats; C-1 From a Railway Carriage: Robert Louis Stevenson; D-2 A Tragic Story: William Makepeace Thackeray.

M8. Match List I with List II: (*PYQ-style*)

List I (Poem)	List II (Rhyme scheme)
A. Indian Seasons	1. aaab cccb ddb eeeb fffb gggb
B. A Tragic Story	2. free verse, no rhyme scheme
C. Your Space	3. abab
D. On Killing a Tree	4. abcb

- a. A-3, B-1, C-4, D-2
- b. A-4, B-2, C-3, D-1
- c. A-1, B-4, C-3, D-2
- d. A-4, B-1, C-3, D-2

Answer: (d) - A-4 Indian Seasons: abcb (heat - feet); B-1 A Tragic Story: aaab cccb ddb eeeb fffb gggb (refrain "behind him"); C-3 Your Space: abab (far - mar, fear - here); D-2 On Killing a Tree: free verse.

M9. Match List I with List II: (*PYQ-style*)

List I (Clue)	List II (Figure of speech)
A. "not bad" (= good), "unreluctant" (= eager)	1. Euphemism
B. "passed away", "no more" (= died)	2. Litotes
C. "deafening silence", "sweet sorrow"	3. Apostrophe
D. speaking to a thing as if it could hear: " <i>River, river, little river!</i> "	4. Oxymoron

- a. A-2, B-1, C-4, D-3
- b. A-1, B-2, C-4, D-3
- c. A-2, B-4, C-1, D-3
- d. A-2, B-1, C-3, D-4

Answer: (a) - A-2 Litotes (a positive said through a negative); B-1 Euphemism (a mild word for a harsh fact); C-4 Oxymoron (two opposite words side by side); D-3 Apostrophe (the river is addressed directly).

M10. Match List I with List II: (PYQ-style)

List I (Figure)	List II (Family)
A. Anaphora	1. Indirect meaning
B. Personification	2. Comparison
C. Euphemism	3. Repetition and order
D. Pun	4. Exaggeration and understatement

- a. A-2, B-3, C-4, D-1
- b. A-3, B-2, C-1, D-4
- c. A-3, B-2, C-4, D-1
- d. A-4, B-2, C-3, D-1

Answer: (c) - A-3 Anaphora repeats the first word (Repetition and order); B-2 Personification compares a thing to a person (Comparison); C-4 Euphemism softens a harsh fact (Exaggeration and understatement); D-1 Pun plays on two meanings (Indirect meaning) (see Section 2).

8.4 Spot the Figure - Rapid Fire (20)

EXAM TIP: Give yourself 10 seconds per line. Say the line aloud - sound figures (alliteration, assonance, onomatopoeia) are easier to hear than to see. Where a line has two figures, the answer names the main one first.

SP1. *"Painted stations whistle by."* Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Personification - the stations "whistle" and rush past like living things; "whistle" is also onomatopoeia (see 5.23).

SP2. *"And one day, my naughty computer actually gobbled a worm,"* Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Pun - "worm" means both an earthworm and a computer worm (a harmful program); the "naughty" computer that "gobbled" it is also personified (see 5.18).

SP3. *"With buzzing wings she hung aloft, then near and nearer drew,"* Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Onomatopoeia - "buzzing" imitates the sound of the fly's wings (see 5.10).

SP4. *"How could this be?"* (about a tree that never grows leaves) Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Rhetorical question - it is asked for effect, to show wonder; no answer is expected (see 4.18, 5.6).

SP5. *"Having a friend is like planting a flower"* Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Simile - friendship is compared to planting a flower with the clue word "like" (see 5.17).

SP6. *"Alas! Still faithful to his back,"* Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Personification and Exclamation - calling the pigtail "faithful" gives it a human quality (personification), and "Alas!" shows strong feeling (exclamation). Name both if you can; in an MCQ, pick the one the options offer (see 3.4, 4.19, 5.25).

SP7. *"That you're my special hero"* (said to a father) Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Metaphor - the father is called a "hero" directly, without like or as (see 5.14).

SP8. *"Louder, faster, bawling, leaping,"* Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Asyndeton - a list of words with no "and" between them, which gives a feeling of speed (see 4.23, 5.11).

SP9. *"A comet in full flight."* Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Alliteration - the "f" sound begins "full" and "flight". The phrase also comes back in the last line of the poem, *"Than a comet in full flight."*, which is repetition (see 3.7, 5.12).

SP10. "Full of sweet dreams, and health, and quiet breathing." Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Assonance - the long "e" vowel sound repeats in "sweet", "dreams" and "breathing" (see 4.5, 5.16).

SP11. "The exam hall fell into a deafening silence when the results were read out." Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Oxymoron - "deafening" and "silence" are contradictory words placed side by side (see 4.3).

SP12. Every stanza of *A Tragic Story* ends with "behind him", as in "*The pigtail hung behind him.*" Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Refrain - the same words close every stanza (also called epistrophe; a kind of repetition) (see 4.22, 5.25).

SP13. "My uncle works hard because he has six mouths to feed." Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Synecdoche - "mouths", a part of the body, stands for the whole persons (the family members) he must feed (see 4.16).

SP14. "And, O weary, wandering brother, if contentment you would win," Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Apostrophe - the poet calls out ("O") to an absent wandering brother as if he could hear; there is also alliteration in "weary, wandering" and inversion in "contentment you would win" (see 4.1, 5.13).

SP15. "Our neighbour's grandfather passed away last night." Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Euphemism - "passed away" is a mild, polite way of saying "died" (see 4.9).

SP16. "And inside you can tell it has a ton of space," Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Hyperbole - "a ton of space" is a deliberate exaggeration (see 4.7, 5.6).

SP17. The miserly ant, who will not help, tells the starving cricket: "*I'm your servant and friend,*" Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Irony - the ant calls himself the cricket's "servant and friend", but his action (refusing help) shows the opposite (see 4.10, 5.4).

SP18. "Strong is she in her faith and beliefs." Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Inversion - the normal order "She is strong in her faith" is reversed to put "Strong" first (see 4.20, 5.2).

SP19. "My brother spent a sleepless night before his results." Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Transferred epithet - "sleepless" really describes the brother, not the night (see 4.17).

SP20. "For the battle is lost or the battle is won" Name the figure of speech. (PYQ-style)

Answer: Antithesis - the opposite ideas "lost" and "won" are set in balanced words; "the battle is" is also repeated (see 4.12, 5.22).

8.5 Mini Poetry Appreciation (6)

EXAM TIP: Read the extract twice - once for meaning, once aloud for sound. Then answer in the order asked: figure, rhyme, meaning. Keep the meaning to one clear line.

PA1. Read these lines from *Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening* and answer the questions. (PYQ-style)

"The woods are lovely, dark and deep,"

"But I have promises to keep,"

"And miles to go before I sleep,"

"And miles to go before I sleep."

(a) Name the figure of speech in the last two lines.

(b) Write the rhyme scheme of this stanza.

(c) What does the poet mean? Answer in one line.

(a) Repetition - the line "And miles to go before I sleep" is repeated for emphasis; "sleep" also suggests death (metaphor/symbol).

(b) All four lines rhyme (deep - keep - sleep - sleep): this last stanza is dddd in the poem's scheme aaba bcb cdd dddd.

(c) The woods are lovely and tempting, but the poet has duties to fulfil and a long way to go before he can rest (see 5.7).

PA2. Read these lines from *A Poison Tree* ("it" is the poet's anger) and answer the questions. (PYQ-style)

"And I water'd it in fears,"

"Night and morning with my tears:"

"And I sunned it with smiles,"

"And with soft deceitful wiles."

(a) Name the main figure of speech.

(b) Pick out the rhyming words.

(c) What does the poet mean? Answer in one line.

(a) Metaphor (extended) - the poet's anger is treated as a plant that he waters with tears and suns with smiles; there is also alliteration of "s" in sunned - smiles - soft.

(b) fears - tears, smiles - wiles (rhyme scheme aabb).

(c) The poet fed his hidden anger with fear and tears and hid it behind false smiles and tricks, so it kept growing (see 5.8).

PA3. Read these lines from *The Secret of the Machines* and answer the questions. (PYQ-style)

"We can pull and haul and push and lift and drive,"

"We can print and plough and weave and heat and light,"

"We can run and race and swim and fly and dive,"

"We can see and hear and count and read and write!"

(a) Name the figure of speech shown by the first words of every line.

(b) Write the rhyme scheme and the rhyming words.

(c) What does the poet mean? Answer in one line.

(a) Anaphora - "We can" begins every line; the many "and"s are polysyndeton, and the machines speaking is personification.

(b) abab - drive - dive, light - write.

(c) The machines proudly say that they can do almost every kind of work for man (see 5.3).

PA4. Read these lines from *Sea Fever* and answer the questions. (PYQ-style)

"I must go down to the seas again, to the vagrant gypsy life,"

"To the gull's way and the whale's way where the wind's like a whetted knife;"

(a) Name the figure of speech that compares the wind to a knife in the second line.

(b) Pick out the rhyming words.

(c) What does the poet mean? Answer in one line.

(a) Simile - "the wind's like a whetted knife" compares the sharp sea wind to a sharpened knife with "like"; the repeated "w" (way, whale's, wind's, whetted) is also alliteration.

(b) life - knife (the poem rhymes in couplets, aabb).

(c) The poet longs to return to the free, wandering life at sea, where the wind cuts like a sharp knife (see 5.20).

PA5. Read these lines from *My Computer Needs a Break* and answer the questions. (PYQ-style)

"Then my computer caught a virus, and fell very sick,"

"So I had to call in a doctor, double quick."

(a) In the first line, the computer "fell very sick". Name this figure of speech.

(b) Pick out the rhyming words.

(c) What does the poet mean? Answer in one line.

(a) Personification - the computer "fell very sick" like a person; "virus" is also a pun (a computer virus and a germ). Line 2 has alliteration in "doctor, double".

(b) sick - quick (the poem is aabb).

(c) A virus made the computer stop working properly, so the speaker had to call an expert at once (see 5.18).

PA6. Read these lines from *Your Space* and answer the questions. (PYQ-style)

“Speak gently! - Love doth whisper low”

“The vows that true hearts bind;”

“And gently Friendship's accents flow;”

“Affection's voice is kind.”

(a) Name the main figure of speech in these lines.

(b) Write the rhyme scheme and the rhyming words.

(c) What does the poet mean? Answer in one line.

(a) Personification - Love "whispers", Friendship has "accents" and Affection has a "voice", like people; "whisper" is also onomatopoeia.

(b) abab - low - flow, bind - kind.

(c) Gentle words carry love, friendship and kindness; true love speaks softly and binds hearts together (see 5.19).

9 Final Revision Sheet

This is your one-sitting revision before the exam. Nothing here is new: every row points back to the full notes in Sections 3 to 7. Read each table row by row, say every poem line aloud, then cover the right-hand columns and test yourself.

9.1 All 36 Figures on One Page

All 36 figures, grouped by the 7 families of Section 2. The 9 syllabus figures carry the

IN SYLLABUS badge; the other 27 are explained in Section 4. The last column tells you where the full card is.

MEMORY TRICK: The 9 syllabus figures: "A Smart Monkey Plays On A Rainy Rocky Road" = Alliteration, Simile, Metaphor, Personification, Onomatopoeia, Anaphora, Repetition, Rhyme scheme, Rhyming words.

Figure	Key / clue word	Trick	Tiny example	See
A. Comparison — 5 figures				
Simile IN SYLLABUS	like as ... as as if than joining two UNLIKE things	Simile Says "like"	Chennai in May is as hot as an oven.	3.2
Metaphor IN SYLLABUS	is are was A is B, with no like / as	Metaphor Means "is"	Our classroom is a zoo when the teacher is away.	3.3
Personification IN SYLLABUS	a thing, animal or idea + a human action or feeling: smiles thinks sits	PERSONification turns a thing into a PERSON	The sun smiled on the paddy fields.	3.4
Apostrophe	O ...! you said to someone absent or dead, or to a thing or idea	APOSTROPHE POSTs a message to someone who cannot reply	Twinkle, twinkle, little star, how I wonder what you are!	4.1
Extended Metaphor and Allegory	one comparison kept up over many lines; a whole story with a hidden moral	one metaphor, many lines; allegory = a story with a lesson inside	Life is a cricket match: we bat, we field, we play till the last over. Allegory: The Hare and the Tortoise.	4.27
B. Sound — 6 figures				
Alliteration IN SYLLABUS	same first SOUND (usually a consonant) in nearby words	ALL-ITERATION: ALL start with the same SOUND — say it aloud	Big black buffaloes block the busy bazaar.	3.1
Assonance	same VOWEL sound repeated in nearby words	ASSONANCE = vowels (A-E-I-O-U)	Go slow over the road. (long o)	4.5
Consonance	same CONSONANT sound, usually inside or at the end of words	CONSONANCE = consonants	Mike struck the black rock. (k)	4.6
Onomatopoeia IN SYLLABUS	buzz click hiss whistle snap bang	the word makes the sound it names	The pressure cooker whistled three times.	3.5

Figure	Key / clue word	Trick	Tiny example	See
Rhyme Scheme IN SYLLABUS	small letters a b c for the line-end sounds	New end-sound = new letter	star - are - high - sky = aabb (Twinkle, twinkle)	3.8
Rhyming Words IN SYLLABUS	same last sound, usually the line-end words; near rhymes accepted	rhyme by ear, not by eye	cat - mat; light - night; blue - shoe	3.9
C. Repetition and order — 9 figures				
Anaphora IN SYLLABUS	same word or phrase at the START of lines or clauses	ANaphora is At the stArt	We shall study, we shall work, we shall win.	3.6
Repetition IN SYLLABUS	same word, phrase or line again, anywhere, for emphasis	same word again, anywhere	It is a long, long way to Kanyakumari.	3.7
Epistrophe	same word or words at the END of lines or clauses	EPistrophe is at the End	government of the people, by the people, for the people	4.21
Refrain	a line or phrase that comes back at regular places, usually each stanza end	refrain = the chorus	the chorus that returns after every stanza of a film song	4.22
Polysyndeton and Asyndeton	and ... and ... and / only commas, no and	POLY = many "and"s; A-syndeton = "and" Absent	We ate idli and dosa and vada and pongal. / I came, I saw, I conquered.	4.23
Chiasmus	criss-cross order: A B ... B A	Chi = X: the words cross over	Eat to live; do not live to eat.	4.24
Inversion	normal word order reversed: verb, object or adjective comes first	sentence turned around	Down came the rain.	4.20
Climax and Anticlimax	ideas rising step by step / a sudden drop to something small	climax climbs; anticlimax falls flat	He lost his job, his home, his family. / He lost his job, his home and his pencil.	4.25
Ellipsis	words left out that the reader supplies; the mark ...	a missing piece the reader fills in	Some like tea; others, coffee. (like left out)	4.4
D. Contrast — 4 figures				
Oxymoron	two opposite words side by side	OXY (sharp) + MORON (dull): the word is itself an oxymoron	deafening silence; open secret; bitter-sweet	4.3
Paradox	a whole statement that seems false but holds a truth	sounds wrong, proves right	You have to be cruel to be kind.	4.11
Antithesis	opposite ideas placed side by side in balanced words	opposites on a see-saw	It was the best of times, it was the worst of times.	4.12
Epigram	a short, witty, memorable saying	a one-line quotable gem	Brevity is the soul of wit.	4.13
E. Exaggeration and understatement — 3 figures				
Hyperbole	a thousand a ton of mountains of forever	HYPERbole goes over the top	I am so hungry I could eat a hundred idlis.	4.7
Litotes and Understatement	not bad not unkind no small ; a big thing made to sound small	LITOTES says "not bad" for "good"	Ninety-nine in maths? Not bad! / Chennai in May is a little warm.	4.8
Euphemism	passed away let go differently abled	EUphemism = EU (good) word for a harsh fact	Grandfather passed away last year.	4.9
F. Indirect meaning — 4 figures				
Irony and Sarcasm	the opposite of what is said or expected; sarcasm = bitter irony meant to hurt	irony says the opposite; sarcasm stings	The fire station burnt down. / "Oh, great — another power cut!"	4.10
Pun	one word (or sound) with two meanings	one word, double duty	A bicycle cannot stand alone because it is two-tired.	4.14
Rhetorical Question	a ? with no answer expected	asked for effect, not for an answer	Who does not love a holiday?	4.18

Figure	Key / clue word	Trick	Tiny example	See
Exclamation	Oh! Alas! Hurrah! What a ...!	"!" = strong feeling	Hurrah! We won the match!	4.19
G. Association and reference — 5 figures				
Allusion	a brief mention of a famous person, place, event, story or text	a quick nod to a famous story	Wake up, Kumbhakarna — it is nine o'clock!	4.2
Metonymy	a related thing names the idea: crown pen uniforms	Metonymy = Mention a related thing	The pen is mightier than the sword.	4.15
Synecdoche	a part for the whole, or the whole for a part: hands wheels roof	Synecdoche = Some part for the whole	The farmer hired ten hands for the harvest.	4.16
Transferred Epithet	a person's feeling-word put on a thing: busy day sleepless night	the night was not sleepless — YOU were	I spent a sleepless night before the exam.	4.17
Imagery and Symbolism	words for the senses (see hear smell touch taste) / an object that stands for an idea	imagery = senses; symbol = a thing that stands for an idea	the smell of hot sambar and golden, crisp dosas (imagery); a white dove = peace (symbol)	4.26

9.2 The 25 Poems at a Glance

No. is also the poem's number in Section 5 (No. 7 = 5.7). The rhyme schemes are the ones used everywhere in this book; the figures are the two or three most important in each poem. Cover the last two columns and recall them for each poem before you look.

No.	Poem	Poet	Rhyme scheme	Top figures
1	Life	Henry Van Dyke	abbaabba cddcee (sonnet)	Alliteration (“forward face”); Metaphor , life as a journey (“the journey will be joy”); Litotes (“unreluctant soul” = eager)
2	I am Every Woman	Rakhi Nariani Shirke	no regular scheme	Metaphor (“She’s a lioness”); Alliteration (“faith, firm”); Onomatopoeia (“sighs and groans and moans”)
3	The Secret of the Machines	Rudyard Kipling	abab	Anaphora (“We were” ... “We can”); Personification (the machines speak); Alliteration (“print and plough”)
4	The Ant and the Cricket	adapted from Aesop’s fables	aabb (couplets; a few triplets)	Personification (a talking ant and cricket in a fable); Anaphora (“Not a flower” / “Not a leaf”); Alliteration (“silly young cricket, accustomed to sing”)
5	No Men are Foreign	James Falconer Kirkup	free verse, no rhyme scheme	Simile (“eyes like ours”; see 3.2); Repetition (first and last lines); Metonymy (“uniforms” = soldiers)
6	The House on Elm Street	Nadia Bush	no regular scheme	Personification (“It sat alone.”); Hyperbole (“a ton of space”); Rhetorical question (“How could this be?”)
7	Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening	Robert Frost	aaba bbbcb ccdd dddd	Repetition (“And miles to go before I sleep”, twice); Personification (“My little horse must think it queer”); Alliteration (“watch his woods”)
8	A Poison Tree	William Blake	aabb	Extended metaphor , anger as a tree (“And I water’d it in fears.”); Anaphora (“I was angry”); Allusion (“an apple bright” = the forbidden fruit)
9	On Killing a Tree	Gieve Patel	free verse, no rhyme scheme	Metaphor (“leperous hide”); Alliteration (“bleeding bark”); Irony (the whole poem reads like cold instructions for killing)
10	The Spider and the Fly	Mary Botham Howitt	aabb	Personification (a talking spider and fly; allegory of the flatterer); Repetition (“Oh no, no”); Euphemism (“never, never wake again” = die)
11	The River	Caroline Ann Bowles	abccb (every stanza)	Apostrophe + Personification (“River, river, little river!”); Simile (“Like a child at play”); Paradox (“Seeming still, yet still in motion”)
12	The Comet	Norman Littleford	abcb	Simile (“Faster than a cheetah”); Personification (“Rampaging through the heavens”); Repetition (“a comet in full flight”, lines 4 and 24)
13	The Stick-together Families	Edgar Albert Guest	aabb	Oxymoron (“empty joy”); Transferred epithet (“the busy day”); Apostrophe (“O weary, wandering brother”)
14	Special Hero	Christina M. Kerschen	abcb	Metaphor (“my special hero”); Rhetorical question (“How did I get so lucky”)

No.	Poem	Poet	Rhyme scheme	Top figures
15	Making Life Worth While	George Eliot	free verse, no rhyme scheme	Anaphora (“One bit of courage ... One gleam of faith”); Metaphor (“the darkening sky” = hard times); Synecdoche (“Every soul” = every person)
16	A Thing of Beauty	John Keats	aabb (heroic couplets)	Epigram (“A thing of beauty is a joy for ever”); Metaphor (“An endless fountain of immortal drink”); Alliteration (“band to bind”)
17	Lessons in Life	Brigitte Bryant and Daniel Ho	abcb (verses); chorus free - me	Simile (“like planting a flower”); Refrain (the chorus “Lessons in life aren't always so simple”)
18	My Computer Needs a Break	Shanthini Govindan	aabb	Personification (“so brainy and smart”); Hyperbole (“mountains of information”); Onomatopoeia (“click”)
19	Your Space	David Bates	abab	Anaphora (“Speak gently” opens the stanzas); Personification (“Affection's voice is kind.”); Allusion (“Peace, be still.” — the Bible, the calming of the storm)
20	Sea Fever	John Masefield	aabb	Alliteration (“a star to steer her by”); Anaphora (“I must go down to the seas again”); Simile (“the wind's like a whetted knife”)
21	Courage	Edgar Albert Guest	aabb	Alliteration (“A daring deed”); Anaphora (“It isn't” ... “It's part of”); Metaphor (“the breath of life”)
22	Team Work	Edgar Albert Guest	abab	Metaphor , life as a game (“no lone hand in the game we play”); Anaphora (“They may”); Antithesis (“the battle is lost or the battle is won”)
23	From a Railway Carriage	Robert Louis Stevenson	aabb	Alliteration (“Faster than fairies”); Simile (“like troops in a battle”); Personification (“Painted stations whistle by”)
24	Indian Seasons	Nisha Dyrene	abcb	Personification (Summer with “sunny smiles / and dusty feet”); Alliteration (“monsoons and mangoes”); Anaphora (“Autumn is English” ... “Autumn is Indian”)
25	A Tragic Story	William Makepeace Thackeray	aaab cccb ddb eeeb fffb gggb	Refrain / Epistrophe (“behind him” closes every stanza); Irony (a comic tale with a “tragic” title); Alliteration (“curious case”)

EXAM TIP: Learn the rhyme schemes in groups. **aabb (9):** The Ant and the Cricket, A Poison Tree, The Spider and the Fly, The Stick-together Families, A Thing of Beauty, My Computer Needs a Break, Sea Fever, Courage, From a Railway Carriage. **abab (3):** The Secret of the Machines, Your Space, Team Work. **abcb (4):** The Comet, Special Hero, Lessons in Life (verses), Indian Seasons. **Free verse (3):** No Men are Foreign, On Killing a Tree, Making Life Worth While. **No regular scheme (2):** I am Every Woman, The House on Elm Street. **One of a kind (4):** Life (abbaabba cddcee), Stopping by Woods (aaba bbcb ccdb dddd), The River (abccb), A Tragic Story (aaab cccb ddb eeeb fffb gggb).

9.3 Top 30 Lines Most Likely to Be Asked

Exact lines from 25 poems, in syllabus order. The highlighted words are the clue. A line can hold more than one figure; the answer given is the one the highlighted clue points to, and it matches the rest of this book. Cover the Figure column, read each line aloud and name the figure in 10 seconds.

No.	Line	Poem	Figure
1	With f orward f ace and u nreluctant s oul;	Life	Alliteration (f - f)
2	She's a lioness ; don't mess with her.	I am Every Woman	Metaphor — she IS a lioness; no like / as
3	We were taken from the ore-bed and the mine, / We were melted in the furnace and the pit	The Secret of the Machines	Anaphora — same start, line after line
4	Not a flower could he see, / Not a leaf on a tree.	The Ant and the Cricket	Anaphora — same start, line after line
5	Remember they have eyes like ours that wake	No Men are Foreign	Simile — comparison with like; the textbook answer (see 3.2)
6	It sat alone .	The House on Elm Street	Personification — a house given a human action
7	My little horse must think it queer	Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening	Personification — a horse given human thoughts
8	And miles to go before I sleep, / And miles to go before I sleep.	Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening	Repetition — not anaphora, not refrain
9	And I water'd it in fears,	A Poison Tree	Metaphor — anger is a tree he waters (extended metaphor)

No.	Line	Poem	Figure
10	And out of its <u>leperous hide</u>	On Killing a Tree	Metaphor — the bark is called a diseased skin
11	Said the <u>cunning Spider</u> to the Fly,	The Spider and the Fly	Personification — a spider that talks and plots
12	<u>River, river</u> , little river! / Bright <u>you sparkle</u> on your way;	The River	Apostrophe + Personification — the river is spoken to directly and treated as a living person
13	<u>Like</u> a child at play.	The River	Simile — the young river is compared to a playing child
14	<u>Seeming still</u> , yet <u>still in motion</u> ,	The River	Paradox — still and moving at once: seems false, is true
15	<u>Faster than</u> a cheetah	The Comet	Simile — comparison with than (see 3.2)
16	and it's <u>empty joy</u> they find,	The Stick-together Families	Oxymoron — two opposite words side by side
17	<u>How did I get so lucky</u> ,	Special Hero	Rhetorical question — wonder, no answer expected
18	<u>One</u> bit of courage ... <u>One</u> gleam of faith ... <u>One</u> glimpse of brighter skies	Making Life Worth While	Anaphora — One ... One ... One
19	An endless <u>fountain</u> of immortal drink,	A Thing of Beauty	Metaphor — beauty is an endless fountain
20	Having a friend is <u>like</u> planting a flower	Lessons in Life	Simile — friendship compared to planting a flower
21	and give my mouse a <u>click</u> ,	My Computer Needs a Break	Onomatopoeia — the word is the sound itself
22	<u>Speak gently</u> to the little child! ... <u>Speak gently</u> to the young, for they	Your Space	Anaphora — the stanzas open with the same words
23	And all I ask is a tall ship and a <u>star</u> to <u>steer</u> her by;	Sea Fever	Alliteration (st - st)
24	A <u>daring deed</u> in a moment's flash;	Courage	Alliteration (d - d)
25	For there's <u>no lone hand in the game</u> we play,	Team Work	Metaphor — life and work are a game played as a team
26	<u>Faster than</u> <u>fairies</u> , <u>faster than</u> witches,	From a Railway Carriage	Alliteration (f - f - f) — the safest single answer; it is also simile and hyperbole (see 3.2, 7.5)
27	And charging along <u>like</u> troops in a battle,	From a Railway Carriage	Simile — the horses and cattle seem to charge along like troops
28	<u>m</u> onsoons and <u>m</u> angoes	Indian Seasons	Alliteration (m - m)
29	He mused upon this <u>c</u> urious <u>c</u> ase,	A Tragic Story	Alliteration (k sound: c - c)
30	Because it hung <u>behind him</u> , ... Not dangling there <u>behind him</u> .	A Tragic Story	Refrain / Epistrophe — the same words close every stanza

DO NOT CONFUSE: three trap lines. “Whose woods these are I think I know.” is inversion, not alliteration (h sound + w sound). “simple sheep” and “short and sweet” are not alliteration (s and sh are different sounds). “Painted stations whistle by.” is personification (the stations act) and also onomatopoeia (whistle), so answer the one the question highlights.

9.4 The 10-Second Method: Recap

Ask these ten questions in this order, as in 7.2. Tick every "yes", then match your ticks with the options; when two or more fit, answer the one the question points to (7.5).

- Sound-word?** buzz, click, whistle, snap → **Onomatopoeia**.
- Same first sound** in nearby words? Say it aloud → **Alliteration**. Same vowel sound → Assonance; same consonant inside or at the end → Consonance.
- like / as / as ... as / than** joining two UNLIKE things → **Simile**.
- A is B**, with no like / as → **Metaphor**; kept up over many lines → Extended metaphor.
- Thing acting human** (thinks, smiles, sits, speaks) → **Personification**.
- Addressing the absent** — a dead or absent person, a thing or an idea called "you" or "O ..." → **Apostrophe**.
- Repeated starts or ends?** Same start → **Anaphora**; same end → Epistrophe; a line back after every stanza → Refrain; the same word or line anywhere → **Repetition**.

8. **Opposites?** Two words side by side → Oxymoron; balanced opposite ideas → Antithesis; a whole statement that seems false but is true → Paradox.
9. **Exaggeration or understatement?** Over the top → Hyperbole; "not bad" for "good" → Litotes; a soft word for a harsh fact → Euphemism.
10. **Reference or omission?** A famous person or story → Allusion; words left out that you can supply → Ellipsis.

9.5 Ten Golden Rules

1. **Alliteration is sound, not letter.** "*keep the courage of the quest*" repeats the k sound, so it is alliteration; "*Whose woods*" is h + w, so it is NOT.
2. **like / as must compare two UNLIKE things.** "I like mangoes" and "She is as tall as her brother" are not similes. A "than" comparison also counts: "*Faster than a cheetah*" = simile.
3. **Anaphora = same START of lines.** "*We were taken*" ... "*We were melted*" = anaphora. A whole line said twice ("*And miles to go before I sleep*") = repetition. Same END = epistrophe; a line after every stanza = refrain.
4. **Apostrophe needs the absent or a thing.** "*River, river, little river!*" = apostrophe (+ personification). Talking to a doctor who is in the room is NOT apostrophe.
5. **Acting human = personification; spoken to = apostrophe.** Talking animals in fables (the spider, the fly, the ant, the cricket) = personification.
6. **Check what the question highlights.** One line can hold two or three figures; the underlined or bold word decides. For "*Faster than fairies, faster than witches*", alliteration is the safest single answer.
7. **Free verse has no rhyme scheme.** No Men are Foreign, On Killing a Tree and Making Life Worth While are free verse. I am Every Woman and The House on Elm Street have scattered rhymes but no regular scheme.
8. **New sound = new letter.** A sound used before takes its old letter back: Stopping by Woods = aaba bbcb ccdc dddd.
9. **Rhyme by ear, not by eye.** Near rhymes such as arms - harm, smooth - youth and scheme - team are accepted in textbook answers.
10. **Oxymoron = two words; paradox = a whole statement.** "*empty joy*" = oxymoron; "*Seeming still, yet still in motion*" = paradox.

9.6 Last Word Before the Exam

MUST REMEMBER: say every line aloud, because sound, not spelling, decides alliteration; like / as / than between unlike things = simile, "is" = metaphor; a thing acting human = personification, a thing spoken to = apostrophe; same start = anaphora, the same line again = repetition; free verse has no rhyme scheme, and every new end-sound takes a new letter; when a line holds two figures, answer the one the question highlights.

Figures of Speech Master Notes — TNPSC General English. Poem texts follow the Tamil Nadu Samacheer Kalvi textbook versions; every quotation was checked word for word.

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